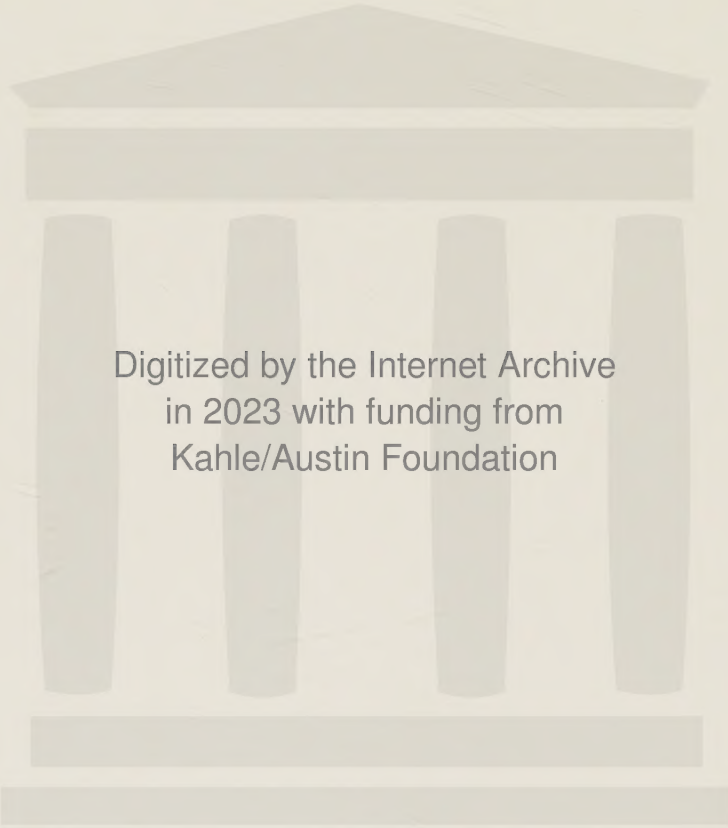




HER BLOOD IS GOLD

CELEBRATING THE
POWER OF
MENSTRUATION

LARA J. OWEN



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L A R A O W E N



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The title, *Her Blood Is Gold*, comes from the creation myth of the Kogi Indians, the only known surviving and intact pre-Columbian society, who live in a secret part of the Sierra mountains of Colombia. The Kogi say that the world was created by the Great Mother while she was menstruating. "Her blood is gold; it remains in the earth; it is fertility."

The Kogi are a mysterious, mystical people who call themselves the "Elder Brothers" and shun contact with the "Younger Brothers"—the invaders from across the ocean. They consider themselves to be the guardians of the planet, and they constantly perform rituals for the balancing of the world from their mountain home in the Heart of the World. Their observations of the recent changes in the natural world around them trouble them deeply, and they warn that the planet faces imminent destruction due to environmental damage from mining and pollution and humans meddling with the balance of nature.

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...

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INTRODUCTION

...

The assumption that lies behind this book is that life is, on balance, a Good Thing, and that the processes of being female are likewise essentially a Good Thing. For the past few thousand years, certainly in Judeo-Christian culture (and in many others), being female has been seen as a Bad Thing. We have had a lineage of descent that honors the male over the female and a preference for giving birth to sons. Consequently that which is special to the female has tended to be denigrated, whereas that which pertains to the male has been prized and respected.

Imagine how the world would be if men had periods and gave birth. The alchemy of producing blood every month would be recognized as a sign of the fertility that would be every man's pride and joy. Instead, what we have is a world in which menstruation is commonly referred to as "the curse" and where women do everything they can to disguise the fact that they are bleeding, often to the detriment of their health and well-being.

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This book is the story of my journey into the menstrual mysteries, which I undertook unconsciously in the beginning, and later, as I began to realize what was happening to me, with more intent. It also includes the stories of several other women who, like me, tumbled down the rabbit hole into the center of the earth, and found that their blood was a key into the heart of the Goddess.

Some years ago I began to understand the relationship between my thoughts and my physical health, and I realized that my sense of myself as a woman was warped and distressed by my thoughts, many of which were so automatic as to be unconscious. Even though I had been raised in a family that was relatively nonsexist and had had many educational opportunities, I lived in a society that, even today, gives women the sometimes subtle, sometimes overt, message that they are inferior.

I began to have a fantasy of living at a time when there was not a thought in the collective that women were in any way lesser than men—a time when the processes of the female body were revered and respected. As I dreamed into this other reality, I realized that my whole body would be affected and that not a cell in my being would have been formed out of ideas of female inferiority. This was a radical thought—imagine not having a trace, a smidgen, hiding anywhere in your cells or your thoughts, that would ever imply that there was anything to be ashamed of about being female. That's what I want, I thought. I want to live like that. I want to really honor and discover the richness of my femininity, and I want to glory in it, revel in it. I want to dance with the mystery of my wondrous alchemical womb.

As a result of this journey, which I am still, of course, on, I now have a very different experience of being a woman, of menstruating, of the moon and the earth, of my body, my psyche, and my spirit. On the way I have learned how to get in touch with the wounded

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woman within, the wounds that we all carry from growing up in a patriarchal culture. I have learned some ways to heal those wounds, and to begin to access the enormous strength that has been obscured by our ignorance of the power and beauty of the monthly cycle. I have learned that if I take time out for myself when I am bleeding I can access a centeredness and a wisdom within that feel eternal.

Recognizing the value and pleasure of my periods has been an opening for me into a deep appreciation of being a woman. The whole process of menstruating has shifted from being something that I found mildly disgusting and certainly inconvenient, to being an in-built time of assessment, clearing, and preparation. It has become a time when I process the last month and prepare for the one coming. I look forward to my period as a time when I am most likely to be able to seek creative solutions to difficulties in my life—provided I make the space for doing so. This process has been so transformative for me that I am excited by its potential for the healing of other women.

• • •

The book is divided into four parts—the first, *Beliefs and Attitudes*, begins with an exploration of our current perspective on menstruation in the Euro-Western industrialized world, seen first from the personal angle of my own initiation (or rather lack of) into menstruation and fertility, and then from the collective angle of the development of patriarchal culture, the subsequent diminishment of female reality, and the role of industrialization in severing us from our cycles. Then I take a look at the eternal archetypes associated with menstruation throughout time and in cultures the world over, in particular the Moon and Blood, the Earth and Snakes. The next chapter discusses the behavior and attitudes of societies that have a positive view of menstruation, cultures that see women's monthly blood as a form of

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gold—a source of richness with the potential to nourish both physical and spiritual life.

Part 2, *Reclaiming the Cycle*, is about being a woman today and about how our health and well-being are damaged by our attitudes toward the menstrual cycle. I discuss ways to work creatively with menstrual symptoms so that we can heal ourselves and also discover what is useful in our premenstrual rages and our cramps and lethargy. I look at what it is about our lifestyles that so readily creates menstrual disharmony and how, by reclaiming the natural impulses of the cycle, we can gain not only physical health but also psychological awareness and spiritual insight.

In part 3, *Waking Up to the Power*, three women tell their stories of awakening to the mystery and magic and healing of menstruation. Wendy Alter was a chemical engineer with NASA who changed her lifestyle after recovering from breast cancer and in the process discovered that her period was the strongest time for her to contact the depths of her nature—depths of feeling and insight that she had felt completely cut off from and that she recognized she had abandoned in her search for career success in a scientific world. Tamara Slayton has been teaching women about the value of getting in touch with our cycles for many years and now directs a growing nonprofit foundation that educates women of all ages about the “menstrual matrix.” She also manufactures cloth menstrual pads and other products for the “ecology of being female.” Hallie Iglehart Austen, author of *Woman-spirit* and *The Heart of the Goddess*, is a leading light of women’s spirituality who works with earth-centered ritual to promote personal and planetary healing. All three women talk openly about their own relationships with their bleeding and explain how, in different ways, making a strong connection with their cycles has empowered and healed them.

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Part 4, Rituals and Recommendations, describes ways to peel away the surface layers of our conditioning and get down to our innate knowledge of the power and beauty of menstruation—knowledge that is in all of us and that is an intrinsic part of having a positive experience of being a woman. Chapter 10 describes rituals, meditations, and practices to help us honor our bleeding and gain deeper awareness of our own individual experiences. Chapter 11 discusses ways in which we can change our lifestyles to incorporate more attention to our cycles in the context of our relationships with men, women, children, and the workplace. The book ends with a vision of a world in which women are free to menstruate in the way they want and where the wisdom of women is once again seen as a valuable social and political resource.

PART ONE

BELIEFS AND
ATTITUDES

1

...

A BRIEF HISTORY OF BLEEDING

THE PERSONAL STORY

I used to think that my periods were a nuisance, a messy intrusion that increased laundry and caused a host of unpleasant symptoms including exhaustion and debilitating pain. Menstruation interfered with my sex life, with athletic activities, and with my energy level. It caused erratic mood swings, irritability, and destructive, unstoppable bitchiness. It cost money—in pads and tampons to mop up the blood, in ruined clothes, in time away from work. It was a mean and sneaky saboteur that always came at the most inconvenient times.

Despite this catechism of woe I wasn't entirely against it. When my period came there was always a part of me that was pleased. It meant I was healthy and fertile and that everything was working properly. There was a sense of pride about bleeding that I felt strongly with my first period, but, in the absence of any external support, the feeling of pleasure dwindled away.

Growing Up

I don't remember when I first heard about menstruation, how I first found out that one day I would bleed and it would be a good thing, not an accident. It was mysterious and I wanted it to happen. It meant I would be almost grown up and another crucial step closer to making my own decisions, living my own life. I wanted very much to leave home and create a different atmosphere for myself—I didn't know what it would be, I just had a feeling of space and excitement. It was confusing though, because there was also something dark about beginning to bleed.

I remember my mother showing me the package of sanitary pads in the airing cupboard in the bathroom—they were for me, for when my bleeding started. There was a belt to hold the pad. I couldn't imagine having that pad between my skinny legs. But I didn't think about that. It was all too much for me. At school my friends started to bleed before me—all except my best friend, Nina. We were the late developers. Very smart, very cute—but no breasts, no blood, no boyfriends. My mother and her friends offered sympathetic comments. "Don't worry about it," they said. "They say that the later you start, the sooner you finish—you're lucky—it means you'll have fewer periods in the long run."

I didn't understand why that made me lucky. Or why they thought that having periods was a bad thing. I hated their knowing looks, their world-weariness. What did they know? I wanted to grow up, and I wanted it now.

My First Period

My first period came in August—a month after my fourteenth birthday. I had a bath one evening and I looked down and there was a thin

trickle of red on the inside of my thigh. I went downstairs. My mother was in the hall. Still on the stairs, holding the stair-rail, clutching the towel around me, feeling a hole where my stomach used to be, I said, "There's some blood on my leg." My mother said, "It must be your period. Oh dear, I used those pads myself last month when I ran out." She held out her hands in apology, "I'd kept them for so long." It was a Sunday. The shops were closed. I don't remember what happened; we must have found a pad somewhere. She was very kind but somehow I felt like a nuisance. I felt empty. Then I felt very excited. I felt special. No one said very much. I carried on bleeding. I felt empty again.

When school started again I told my friend Nina. "I had my period," I said, trying to sound casual. She looked at me angrily, "I suppose you think that makes you something special," she hissed. I stepped back, shocked. Well, yes, it did, but I didn't want to upset her. The fragile little balloon that was my pride in my womanhood deflated even more. I was just having a period. It was nothing special. Who did I think I was anyway?

A Jewish friend of mine told me that when she had her first period her mother slapped her on the face. Reeling with shock, she asked, "Why did you do that?" Her mother replied, "I don't know; it was done to me by my mother. It's tradition." Another friend said that she had been told by her grandmother that this traditional slapping was done so that the girl would always remember this important moment in her life. "They could have thrown a party for her instead," I said, "if what they really wanted was for her to have a memory."

To be hit on the face when first you become a woman—what an interesting statement about how womanliness is regarded. Perhaps it is intended to remove the feeling of pride that comes with the first blood.

Something else took away that feeling of pride for me, and I think it was the absence of ceremony. It felt to me, internally, that something

truly amazing and magical was happening, and yet everyone around me treated it as a commonplace. I felt a sense of achievement mingled with excitement, curiosity, and embarrassment; I also remember a vague awareness of a vast and gaping unknown future. Intuitively I knew it was a massive landmark in my life—and yet no one said or did anything about it, other than to give me some sanitary pads. I know my mother was pleased—after all, it meant I was healthy and growing up normally—but I needed more than that. I needed a ceremony, a party, some joyful public recognition of this huge event in my development. But nothing happened. As the months went by, I felt more and more the shame and embarrassment and less and less the excitement and the pride that had glimmered for a moment with the first blood.

Becoming a Woman

When I had my period I often felt fuzzy and found it hard to concentrate on my schoolwork. When I had important exams coming up, my mother and I went to see the doctor, and he gave me pills to stave off my period until after the exams. It worked great, and I passed all my exams. But my periods became strangely irregular, and I remember several months of very heavy bleeding every two weeks. I have a dim memory of lying in bed and feeling all this blood pouring out of me. Just as we were going to go back to the doctor, they calmed down, and I went back to being regular again. I don't think that either my mother or I ever considered that the pills I had taken might have upset my cycle. This was in the days when medicinal drugs were a completely Good Thing, when we were grateful of their miracles and ignorant of their insidious side-effects. Then I started to have really bad pains with my bleeding—so more drugs were prescribed for the pain, not just painkillers but new hormonal drugs. I entered a vicious

circle of using haphazard doses of hormones to control my already confused hormones, which in turn led to more cramps and more bleeding.

“It’ll settle down when you get older—” they said, “when you get married, and have children.” This was little consolation to a sixteen-year-old.

It was miserable. Becoming a woman seemed to be an unmitigated drag. I wanted to travel; at sixteen Nina and I hitchhiked round the south of England, and at seventeen we caught trains to Paris, to the south of France, to Italy. Everywhere we went we were harassed by men—on trains, on buses, on the street. It was awful. I hated it. It was totally impersonal and vaguely disgusting. I was still a virgin, and I felt confused and abused by the way men leered at us, tried to feel us up on the bus in Florence, tried to persuade us to come back to their place instead of to the Youth Hostel.

I wanted to be a boy really badly. My friends who were boys could hitchhike alone, could travel alone, without having to develop a steely look and fast reflexes like I did. When I was eighteen, I went to live in Paris. After several months of navigating the Metro alone, I caught a glimpse of my pursed face in the window of the speeding train and realized that I was becoming ugly in my effort to keep all these men away from me. Who were they? Have men always plagued young women in this way? This was during the early seventies, in that brief moment during the era of free love just before the rise of feminism, when sexist behavior was still overt and widespread. I couldn’t talk back—I didn’t know how to tell men to get lost in the confident way I see teenagers do today. I was vulnerable and struggling to have my adventures in a male world.

So periods were just one more inconvenient part of being female. All I knew about menstruation was that it was a mark of being a woman and meant that I could (horror of horrors) get pregnant. At

school, it was not a subject to be mentioned other than in the biology class. All the information I received was purely physical, apart from occasional crude jokes. You had a period because you weren't pregnant, and the menstrual flow was simply the discarded lining of the womb provided for a possible fetus. My friends and I discussed it and, in the absence of further information, decided that the female body was poorly evolved—all that blood and fuss for years and years when you needed only to do it once or twice in order to have children.

And then there was that lurking uncomfortable shame that was somehow mixed up with the whole experience. At home, my period was something to be kept secret from my father and brothers. If I had to mention it, I would use a hushed voice and talk to my mother when we were alone. Shortly after my periods had begun we were going on a family trip, and I had to ask my father to stop the car so that I could go to the pharmacy. Of course, he wanted to know what it was that I needed to buy. I remember this awful feeling as I told him I had to buy some sanitary pads. It was a peculiar mixture of shame, pride, and total embarrassment. He was very nice about it and, as far as I can remember, never said anything to make me feel that there was anything to be ashamed of—but somehow there was always this shame in the background of my thoughts, and it colored my whole relationship with the outside world.

The picture society gave me through advertising was a confusing one. Tampon ads showed lithe girls in bikinis running gleefully toward the ocean and girls in tight white jeans jumping onto horses. This didn't mesh very easily with my experience of lethargy and cramps. And I knew that no one in their right mind would trust a tampon so much that they would go out for the day in white jeans. Pah! It must have been men writing those ads.

Yet somehow I felt that I *should* be like the girls in the Tampax ads and that the way my body and mind behaved was somehow wrong—

that a normal girl wouldn't feel any different when she had her period. There's nothing she'd like more than to scramble onto a horse and gallop off for an adventure while that nice little tampon allowed her to forget that she was menstruating at all. The embarrassing reality was that I couldn't even get a tampon inside me. Not only was I not fitting the stereotype, I was also failing with the equipment. I felt decidedly inadequate until I eventually succeeded. Then the process of imagining I wasn't having a period at all began in earnest.

Tampons and the pill liberated me to a certain extent from the worst of menstruation. When I was eighteen I went on the pill, and taking it meant that my periods were very light and completely predictable. If there was some reason why I didn't want to have my period, I could mess about with my cycle by taking the pill straight through. My friends used to do this, and it was recommended for athletes and women whose career performance might be adversely affected by menstruation. I shudder now to think of the casual way we manipulated our bodies to fit our will.

Tampons meant that I never had to really look at my blood. I just stuffed the thing in, it took care of the mess, and then when I took it out I could sling it down the toilet without having to even look at it. My natural curiosity usually interfered with this procedure—but the possibility was there for pretty much ignoring that you were having a period at all. I could do anything with a tampon in—go swimming, wear a skimpy bikini or tight jeans. I was always sexually active. My period didn't slow me down—no sirree—I wasn't going to let something like that get in the way of my pleasure. The great thing about tampons was that they soaked up the blood that was coming out so that if you timed it right and whipped out the tampon immediately before intercourse, there was hardly any blood to be seen. Of course, being on the pill helped with that too, because there wasn't very much blood in the first place.

These attitudes—that periods were essentially a nuisance and that they should be ignored as much as possible—pervaded my thinking about my body and my femaleness. Even when I became interested in holistic medicine it was a while before I began to change my behavior when I was menstruating. I understood that I was growing up into a world where, for the first time in modern history, women could take on men in the outside world and be liberated from the drudgery of the kitchen sink and child care, and so I felt that I should make use of all the wonderful advances in medicine and hygiene that made it possible for me to pretend that, biologically, I wasn't really a woman after all. I owned my sexuality at last but at an enormous cost.

My journey out of this conditioning took over ten years. I think it will probably be a lifetime task to work through and out of the myriad of insidious negative ideas about femaleness, and at every new stage of my life I will encounter old tapes of denial and distrust in the essential nature of female experience. That is what living at this point in history is about, for me, and for many women.

THE COLLECTIVE STORY

So how has it happened that we think so little of the physiological processes of women's bodies? And that we think that the best way to relate to monthly bleeding is to ignore it as much as possible, to walk around with cramping bellies and miserable minds, as though that were the lot of woman, and best to grin and bear it. This attitude is rooted in the denial of female reality that runs through the core of the history of the past few thousand years.

The world wasn't always dominated by patriarchal attitudes. Recent archaeological findings tell us that there was a time when women

and men worshiped the Great Goddess, the Earth Mother, and when images of the creative and fecund female were carved into stone and treasured.¹ As far as we can tell, about 5,000 years ago, militaristic groups from the Middle East began invading the peaceful, agrarian, Goddess-worshipping societies, beginning a long-term swing on the pendulum of human history. As the pendulum swung away from the Goddess and toward male-oriented values, so the position of women in society became progressively worse, and aspects of life relating to the female were denigrated.

Over time this led to an association of shame with the body (associated with the female, the Goddess, the earth, feelings, and sensations) relative to the mind (associated with the male, the God, the sky, the world of ideas). Over the past few thousand years, all the mainstream religions in the world have become patriarchal (to varying degrees), and all of them value the intellect and the spirit over the body and the instincts.

Shame about the body and shame about being female—it pretty quickly adds up to shame about menstruation. There is a shame that women carry simply for being women. The shame of women was bigger than the shame of men right from the first book of the Old Testament (a guidebook for life written by men and translated and interpreted by subsequent men). In fact, in the mythic version of history presented by the tale of Adam and Eve, male shame wouldn't even exist if it weren't for women. (And we do well to take these tales seriously—for although they may not have a basis in fact, they are the cornerstones of our belief systems.)

The Book of Genesis tells us how the snake told Eve that the reason God had forbidden them to eat from the tree in the middle of the garden was not, as God had told them, because if they did they would die, but rather to prevent them from becoming Gods themselves.

“Of course you will not die,” said the serpent, “for God knows that, as soon as you eat it, your eyes will be opened and you will be like God himself, *knowing both good and evil.*”

And Eve seeing that the fruit was “*desirable for the knowledge it could give,*” picked some and ate it and then gave some to her husband, and he ate it too (Gen. 3:4–6).

In the middle ages society became increasingly patriarchal. In order to give religious support to the establishment of the patriarchy, there was some subtle—and some not-so-subtle—re-creation of the old myths. Women were cast as the corrupters, the Jezebels, to be feared and denied by the servants of a very male God. The story of Adam and Eve was distorted so that knowledge of good and evil was taken to mean knowledge of sex. Eve had, through her wicked seductive powers, tricked innocent Adam into falling from grace, and not because, as you remember, she wanted knowledge. Oh no, it now became abundantly clear that what Eve had been after was sex. The harlot! The problems of humankind became, even more clearly, all Eve’s fault. The curse that God inflicts on Eve—“I shall give you great labor in childbearing; with labor you will bear children. You will desire your husband, but he will be your master” (Gen. 3:16)—was extended to include menstruation, which became the monthly “curse” through which Eve paid for her sins.²

I was educated in a Church of England school in the early sixties, and I remember being taught that Eve was the corrupter of Adam—she was the temptress and the one that made the decision to eat the apple. And although sex wasn’t mentioned explicitly, all the pictures in the books showed Adam and Eve naked, with Eve looking seductive and sly while Adam was cast as a hapless man who was putty in a woman’s hands. That highly potent image was one of the first images of woman that I was shown, and it was used to illustrate the creation myth that lies at the basis of our cultural identity. Small wonder that

it has taken much unraveling to discover the layer upon layer of distrust and ignorance of the processes inherent in being a woman. Or that we have had our own bodily experiences so distorted that we have come to believe the distortion rather than to believe our own experiences.

The rise in power of the patriarchal religions did not happen overnight. Pagan earth-centered religious practices, based on ancient wisdom, continued to thrive, especially in Northern Europe, well into the middle ages. Then Christianity took off in a big way, aided by social and economic changes and the terrors of long-term wars and the Black Plague. The Inquisition brought about a period of unbelievable violence against heretics and an estimated nine million so-called witches were killed with great brutality. Eighty-five percent of them were women. With them died the remains of the Goddess religion and much of humankind's knowledge of midwifery, herbalism, agriculture, and spiritual practice based on natural laws.

After the takeover of European religious life by Christianity, the next big change to affect the lives of women was the Industrial Revolution. In nineteenth-century industrial Britain and North America, women were divided into two cultural stereotypes: the stoical breeder-worker and the feeble little woman. One slaved away in the mills and factories, while the other languished on a sofa clutching a phial of smelling salts to her soft and tender bosom.

For the working woman, menstruation was a nuisance that cut down on her productivity. If she was earning wages by the hour or by the piece, then resting or relaxing in any way during her period was a luxury she could not afford. The poor have always had to work whether or not they have felt like it. However, in pre-industrial rural life, workload was related to seasonal flux. At harvest time everyone worked like the dickens; in midwinter there was virtual hibernation while the land lay under frost and snow. In a matter of decades, workers in Europe and

America shifted from living in a culture that responded to the rhythm of the moon and the sun to one in which work was determined by the clock and by machines.

This had a particular effect on women, who had been used to greater autonomy in the shaping of their work day. If you are in charge of your own working environment—your home or small farm, for example—you can tailor your work to suit shifts in energy and disposition. This ability to adapt workload to inner rhythm disappeared with the industrial revolution, which tied workers to a concept of productivity based on the operation of machines. Unlike human beings, machines are not subject to seasonal and monthly fluctuations. The ideology of the industrial age adapted human reality to that of machines, rather than making machines fit the needs of humans.

For women who did not have to work outside the home, this was not immediately felt, although it soon came home in the form of exhausted husbands and sons. But the majority of working-class women did have to go out to work, and for many of them the demands of their jobs were extreme.

For middle-class women a very different lifestyle developed. Perhaps in unconscious compensation for the suddenness of the shift into machine-time as well as because idleness still represented status, middle-class women were characterized in medical and popular literature as feeble creatures, prone to TB and neurasthenia and in need of protection from the outside world and from the excessive stimulation that might be caused by reading novels or riding horses. They were encouraged to rest during menstruation. A medical book of the time advised: "We cannot too emphatically urge the importance of regarding these monthly returns as periods of ill-health, as days when the ordinary occupations are to be suspended or modified."³

The correct behavior and treatment of middle-class women during menstruation was the opposite of that considered acceptable for working women, who were expected to continue working regardless of the time of the month. Class distinctions were used by the medical profession to support this difference in treatment. While middle- and upper-class women were seen as sensitive and weak, working-class women were seen as insensitive and tough, with a tendency to laziness that justified their being whipped (sometimes literally) into productivity.

This phenomenon was most exaggerated in the southern United States, with the vast difference in lifestyle between the black slaves and the white wives and daughters of slave owners. It was easier to have two medical models in this instance, for the difference in race was used to support theories about the needs and appropriate behavior of the two types.

Nineteenth-century medical concepts of the nature of the female body and temperament laid much stress on the weakness and volatility of emotion created by hormonal shifts, and to the nineteenth-century physician, the womb and ovaries were the most important organs in a woman's body.

In 1849 Dr. Frederick Hollick wrote: "The Uterus, it must be remembered, is the controlling organ in the female body, being the most excitable of all, and so intimately connected, by the ramifications of its numerous nerves, with every other part."⁴

And in 1870 Dr. W. W. Bliss waxed lyrical on the wonders of the ovaries: "Accepting then, these views of the gigantic power and influence of the ovaries over the whole animal economy of woman, that they are the most powerful agents in all the commotions of her system; that on them rest her intellectual standing in society, her physical perfection, and all that lends beauty to those fine and delicate contours

which are constant objects of admiration, all that is great, noble and beautiful, all that is voluptuous, tender and endearing; that her fidelity, her devotedness, her perpetual vigilance, forecast, and all those qualities of mind and disposition which inspire respect and love and fit her as the safest counsellor and friend of man, spring from the ovaries.”⁵

As more and more women have gone out to work and as our society has developed in terms of sexual equality, the stereotype of the frail and dependent middle-class woman has faded. It still exists, but as the butt of derision rather than as a sign of wealth and status. We place a far higher value on productivity than on leisure, and it is no longer satisfying or economic for women to stay at home.

Modern feminism initially rejected ideas of hormonal influence on women. It is not surprising that feminists reacted against the idea that women are different during menstruation, as such ideas had played a large part in chaining middle-class Victorian women to their sofas. If women were deemed unreliable because of the changes in their hormones throughout the month, then this supposed unreliability was used as a reason to keep them from positions of power.

But our need to gain equality with men in the working world may have led us to throw some good ideas out with the bad. There is usually at least a glimmer of truth in any ideology, and the physicians of the Victorian era were not completely wrong when they emphasized the importance of menstruation in women’s overall health, the relationship between the womb and the psyche, and the wisdom of rest during the period.

We have tended to reject all of this because it reminds us of the time when the lives of women were more controlled by men and because it smacks of old arguments that kept women tied to the home and powerless in the outside world. We have also, quite rightly, rejected the idea that the natural processes of being female are a sickness. But to say that something is not a sickness is not necessarily the same

thing as ignoring it altogether. By ignoring menstruation in reaction to the ideas of the Victorian era, we have perhaps lost touch entirely with a lingering thread of awareness of its value in women's lives.

The changes that have taken place in the lives of women over the past thirty years may look like a revolution, but in many ways what has taken place has been an assimilation. Women seeking power in a male world have tended to do so by becoming pseudo-men. And, perhaps unwittingly, feminism has played a part in the suppression of menstruation. Germaine Greer in *The Female Eunuch*, her stirring tirade against the patriarchy, makes some important points about the taboos surrounding menstruation and how they reflect society's denigration of the female. But her conclusion is that menstruation is something that "we would rather do without" and that "no woman would menstruate if she did not have to."⁶ This was very much the party line of feminism in the sixties and seventies, and it was not until the rise of the women's spirituality movement that menstruation began to be seen as something sacred and meaningful.⁷

In mainstream culture though, it is this idea of menstruation as inconvenience that has stuck, as women have increasingly adapted to work schedules formed by men and to a working atmosphere that developed within the context of a patriarchal society. When I discuss ancient ideas about the spiritual power of menstruation with successful and aspiring women, one of the biggest fears I have come across is that this will in some way affect their myth of being "just as good as a man, and sometimes better." Many women don't want to go deeper into menstruation; they are scared of what they will discover. It suits them better to suppress their feelings with tranquilizers, to spray with vaginal deodorants to disguise the smell of blood, to numb their pain through painkillers, and to absorb their blood with tampons so they never have to actually see it. It's easier to be a successful woman in a man's world if you hardly recognize that you menstruate at all.

The technology of suppression—tampons, vaginal deodorants, sophisticated pain-killing and mood-altering drugs—has acted together with the myth of the superwoman to create a predominant cultural attitude that a menstruating woman is no different from one who is not bleeding. The trouble with all this is that it simply isn't true. Any woman remotely in touch with her body knows that when she is menstruating, and usually for a few days before, she feels different. And this is a fact of nature that ultimately cannot be denied.

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MOON, BLOOD, EARTH, AND SNAKE

Behind our culturally and historically determined attitudes and beliefs about menstruation lies a web of symbols and myths that is a more permanent part of the matrix of human experience. The knowledge of these symbols lies deep within our bones, a legacy passed down in our genes from all the mothers who gave birth to us and our forebears over millions of menstruating years.

No matter how we attempt to consign them to the shadow, the archetypes of the Moon, Blood, Earth, and Snake continue to pervade our unconscious life with their numinosity. They are all associated with the Goddess, and, like Her in Her most awesome and powerful expression, have held predominately negative connotations in recent history, particularly in the more patriarchal societies. These negative connotations are so powerful that it can be a stretch for us to even imagine that they are not fact but are merely a view of reality—and not the only reality there is.

The Moon has been associated with lunacy and cyclical violence as much as with inspiration; its cycles have been seen to suggest inconsistency and unreliability rather than fluidity and the ability to experience a wide range of emotions.

Blood is seen as gore; people faint at the sight of it; we hide it on tampons and throw it down the toilet; we associate it with injury and death. Yet, in older times (and still in the Tantric tradition) menstrual blood was viewed as a sacrament symbolizing the wonder of life—this most ancient of sacraments is probably the origin of the Christian sacrament of the Blood of Christ.

The Earth and nature have been seen as enemies—the Earth as a resource to be exploited and nature as a force to be tamed and governed. The collective failure to understand that the Earth is a mother to be revered and respected has resulted in the current ecological disaster that threatens all life on the planet.

The Snake has been granted the most evil place of all as the bringer of sin, the cause of the fall from grace from the Garden of Eden. It once held power as the great symbol of death and rebirth, the magical one who brought knowledge of sexuality, of life and death, whose bite sent priestesses into visionary states and whose appearance presaged mystical and powerful events.

By exploring these symbols, their unconscious effects upon us, and their more ancient meanings, we can begin to peel off the layers of cultural conditioning that keep us from an intimate, positive relationship with femaleness. We can look at menstruation as if for the first time, with a spirit of inquiry and wonder. We can begin to experience the reverence that this magical flow of rich and fertile blood inspired in our ancestors. As Elinor Gadon tells us in *The Once and Future Goddess*:

The word *ritual* comes from *rtu*, Sanskrit for menses. The earliest rituals were connected to the women's monthly bleeding. The blood from the womb that nourished the unborn child was believed to have mana, magical power. Women's periodic bleeding was a cosmic event, like the cycles of the moon and the waxing and waning of the tides. We have forgotten that women were the conduit to the sacred mystery of life and death.¹

THE MOON

I've always been fascinated by the moon. I remember as a teenager walking home late one wet night and standing in the light of the full moon and gazing up at her. I became aware of a power that I couldn't name, and I spontaneously welcomed the full moon and out of some instinct thanked her. I didn't know then what I was thanking her for, but I did it anyway. A vestigial knowledge of her effect on the rhythms of life must have lingered within me.

As a young adult I lived in the countryside in England. I used to work in a village pub three miles from my home, and the only way I could get there was on my grandmother's old bicycle. I would cycle back late at night, the dynamo noisily clicking, fairly terrified by one particularly dark and lonely stretch of tree-lined road. If the moon was full, I was comforted by her light. It mattered to me if she was full or not; it actually affected my experience of life.

Before the advent of electric light, the full moon lighting up the night sky meant a time when one could walk easily at night, visit friends, hold social events, perform outdoor ceremonies, and observe

wildlife for the hunt. The new moon, when the night is darkest, was a time of more introversion, a time to go inside oneself; in many traditions the new moon was a time of purification.

Many cultures have venerated the moon. Plutarch tells us that the priests of Ancient Egypt called the moon the Mother of the Universe, because the moon "having the light which makes moist and pregnant, is promotive of the generation of human beings and the fructification of plants."²

With the industrial age, many associations with the moon died out of everyday life. But we only have to go back one or two hundred years to find evidence of the crucial relationship between the cycles of the moon and successful farming. In the British Isles it was believed that the wise farmer should "kill fat swine for bacon about the full moon. Sheer sheep at the moon's increase: fell hand timber from the full to the change; horses and mares must be put together in the increase of the moon, for foals got in the wane are not accounted strong . . . fruit should be gathered, and cattle gelded, in the wane of the moon."³

Many cultures have understood the relationship of the cycles of the moon to the growth of plants, and this knowledge still survives. The teachings of Rudolph Steiner are used by many gardeners in Europe as a guide to the relationship between horticulture and lunar phases, and in India it is still common practice in some areas to plant by the moon.⁴

The importance of the moon to the ancients lives on in a variety of traditions. Modern birthday cakes descend from the Greek custom of honoring the monthly birthday of Artemis the Moon with lighted full moon cakes. In Gaul the crescent moon was an important symbol and the people made their communion cakes in a crescent shape. Modern France still makes these cakes and calls them *croissants*

(crescents), colloquially known as moon-teeth.⁵ In pre-Islamic Arabia the Moon Goddess was so important that her emblem came to represent the entire country and remains as the lunar crescent on Islamic flags. Today, the Arab equivalent of the Red Cross is called the Red Crescent.

The root word for both moon and mind was the Indo-European word *manas*, *mana*, or *men*, said to mean mind, and an attribute of *Ma*, the primordial mother. Mana from heaven was divine “food,” spiritual blessing that flooded the body and nourished not only the soul but also the physical being. Mana was also related to the Latin *mens*, meaning both mind and moon as well as a mysterious quality of spiritual power—nu-men. In Greek, *menos* meant both moon and power. *Men*, meaning month in Greek, is the root word for both measurement and menstruation.

The moon is associated with strong emotions—we talk of being moonstruck, of falling in love under the spell of the full moon. I’ve always found that I am deeply affected by the full moon and am much more likely to have extreme moods, from elation to melancholy. The word *lunacy* derives from lunar, and many cultures believe that the moon itself creates madness in susceptible people, such is the strength of the emotion that it generates. The full moon triggers the werewolf’s transformation, and the Moon card in the Tarot deck shows dogs howling under the moon.

In the traditional Tarot deck the Moon is linked with danger and terror, whereas the Sun represents all that is good and bright and safe and strong. This is a good example of the shift in association we have had with the moon and of the fear of night, darkness, and strong feelings that arises in a culture that fears the feminine. Once upon a time the moon was an inspiration, an aid to dreaming, and an evoker of rich emotion and poetic sensibility. Before we developed our fear of

altered states of consciousness, *mania* meant ecstatic revelation, and *lunacy* meant possession by the spirit of the moon.⁶ In patriarchal society it has become more associated with craziness and instability. The line between inspiration and mania can be a fine one, as we see in the lives of many gifted people, but the linking of genius and madness in Western society may be more a result of the cultural tendency to repress particular kinds of emotional and creative energy. This repression can lead to neurosis and hysteria. The suppression of the wisdom of menstruation and of the moon may be the root of any lunacy that they bring.

The moon governs the night and therefore the darkness—that which cannot readily be seen. The moon has a luminous beauty that pulls us into a different state of awareness. Whereas the sun lights the way for work and the round of daily life, the moon lights a different aspect of the human experience—the inner life, the imagination, the watery diffuse realms of the unconscious. The energy held within this realm is of a very different nature than the energy of the sun. It is a more sensitive, delicate, fragile light—one that can distort as much as it can illumine—and its illumination is variable. At full moon the moonlight illumines everything; at new moon there is total darkness. This sensitive, fragile, variable feeling is familiar to women. For many of us it is typical of the premenstrual phase, when we are hypersensitive and volatile.

Our society is a sun-worshipping one in that it favors the profligate use of energy and behavior that is extroverted and outer-oriented. The quiet introvert, the poet, is not highly rewarded. Dreamers lose out in a culture that favors pragmatism and materialism. For me it is heaven to sit under a full moon by the water and dream. It feeds my imagination. It nurtures my spirit. It fills me with a sense of awe for life.

The associations that astrology holds with the moon are rooted in ancient ideas about the natural world. The moon relates to the feminine, the mind (especially the memory), emotional behavior, the home, the maternal, and the generative cycle.

Lindsay River and Sally Gillespie write that “while the Sun’s light appears to have a constant and focused quality, the Moon’s light appears *cyclic and diffuse*. There is a mystery in the Moon’s soft-focused light which opens up the way to the magical illuminations of the unconscious. The wisdom attributed to the Moon throughout all cultures and ages is limitless.”⁷

I find that my mental state when I am menstruating is much more diffuse than during the rest of the month. Being on my moon makes me like the moon—dreamy, diffuse, unfocused. From this state a different form of awareness is available—less judgmental and organized than my normal way of being, more open to new information.

The Moon and the Goddess

We are at a disadvantage today in that we no longer recognize, let alone worship, female deities. We are therefore denied reassurance of the “rightness” of our feminine processes. The one female deity that is worshiped in the Western world, Mary the mother of Jesus, is traditionally depicted with a crescent moon at her feet, demonstrating the persistence of the symbolic relationship between the female and the moon. The ancient goddess Isis was always shown with the crescent moon. Diana/Artemis is the goddess of the moon, of hunting, of women and childbirth.

Many ancient cultures had a concept of the Triple Goddess—the Maiden, Bride, and Crone. The Maiden is the virgin/young girl/princess, full of purity and promise, goddess of the new moon.

During the waxing cycle of the moon she develops into the Woman, the Bride, the fertile, creative, sexual, initiating priestess and queen of the full moon, who then, as the moon wanes, becomes the Crone, the goddess of death and of endings, of the period of moon-dark before the rebirth of the new moon. The ancients understood from this cycle that death always occurs before renewal, and thus the Crone was seen as she who destroys in order to bring forth new life.

We can witness this cycle every month: the slim crescent of the new moon hangs delicately in the evening sky, and then she grows, like a pregnant belly, into the fullness of herself—an expression of abundance and fertility. Reaching a peak of roundness, lighting up the night sky almost eerily with her vibrant glow, the fullness completes itself and she begins to wane.

Slowly, slowly, she dwindles to nothing, and there is complete darkness in the sky. And then out of the empty darkness, the sliver of crystal-clear new light can be seen, and she is reborn. This is a metaphor for a literal process that takes place within the body and the psyche of every woman every month, as well as for the living and dying process of which we are all a part.

The Moon and Women

The moon affects the flow of water by governing the tides. Our body fluids are also governed by the waxing and waning of the moon. The cycle itself is fluid; it is constantly changing. And this is what a woman's body is like—a continually shifting balance of hormones resulting in an ebb and flow of fluids: the blood that flows during menstruation; the dry phase after the end of the period; the runny egg-white mucus of ovulation; the juices of lovemaking; the tears of the premenstruum. Some women even ejaculate when they have an orgasm. This ebb and flow of fluids in the woman's body is a crucial

part of her identity—it links her with the ocean and with the moon, with the waters of the planet and with the cycle of the seasons.

Native Americans call menstruation the moon-time, and traditionally, menstruating women went to a moon-lodge to rest and meditate. In most cultures throughout the world the moon has been associated with women, most obviously because the average length of the menstrual cycle is 29.5 days, which is exactly the length of time that the moon takes to orbit the earth. The average length of pregnancy is 265.8 days—almost precisely nine lunar months. This falls fourteen days short of the forty weeks that today's doctors calculate as the length of pregnancy, but that forty weeks is measured from the beginning of the last period on the basis that, theoretically at least, the woman could have conceived at any time after the onset of bleeding. In fact, she is most likely to conceive on the fourteenth day of her cycle, making the actual period of pregnancy thirty-eight weeks—or 266 days.

The moon was considered the deity of women even as comparatively recently as the Renaissance, when it was said that women should pray to the moon, rather than to God, for what they wanted.⁸

In Scotland the full moon was considered the most fortunate time for women, and Scottish girls always got married at this time. They curtsied to the moon when they saw her, saying, "It is a fine moon God bless her."⁹

The relationship between the full moon and ovulation was known in ancient cultures. Women of the Native American Yurok tribe of Northern California prayed to the moon when they suffered from menstrual irregularity. It is probable that sitting out under the full moon triggered ovulation and returned their cycles to normal.¹⁰ In her book *Lunaception*, Louise Lacey demonstrates that ovulation is triggered by exposure to light at night.

Ovulation is the signal for the release of the hormones that stimulate the build-up of the endometrium, the lining of the womb. The endometrium is shed fourteen days after ovulation—out of the whole menstrual cycle, this time period of bleeding fourteen days after ovulation is the most regular and widely experienced by women everywhere. This means that if the full moon triggers ovulation, then women will bleed fourteen days later, on the new moon. And indeed, it seems that this was generally the case in societies that did not use sources of light other than the sun and moon. When exposed only to natural light, women tend to menstruate with the new moon.

In societies with a female/earth-centered spirituality, such as that of the Native Americans, and matrifocal Mediterranean cultures, the rhythm of the women's cycle was used as the basis for the ritual life of the culture. Rites of celebration and fertility were held during the full moon, when women were ovulating, and rites of seclusion and purification were held at the new moon, when women were menstruating.

These days we no longer live under natural light, and many factors conspire to shift our periods away from a regular cycle; however, it may well be that there have always been particular women, and also times in every woman's life, when menstruation occurs on the full moon. I don't want to get too rigid about the idea that the new moon is the "right" time to menstruate. I find that when my period coincides with the full moon it can be a very strong experience.

When I bleed with the full moon I am full of energy, full of juice, raring to go, happy, excited, full of sexuality and creativity. I am a channel for the bright light of the moon, and I sense her glow all around me. I usually require a time of peacefulness, but I need less time than when my period coincides with the new moon. My body wants to move, and I find myself dancing exuberantly.

When I bleed with the new moon I go very still and slow and retreat deep inside myself. It is more of a cleansing, a purification. I experience a drawing inside, a going deep within to the inner cave, the crucible of the psyche, a downward descent into the interior world, a time of the dark.

The elements of shifting energy, introversion, and clearing out are always present for me when I am bleeding, but there is a different feeling depending on the moon's phase. I experience these differences most powerfully when my period coincides exactly with the new moon or full moon, and less so when it comes elsewhere in the moon's cycle.

Penelope Shuttle reports in her groundbreaking book *The Wise Wound* that she has found her creativity to be particularly pronounced when she menstruates on the full moon. She and her coauthor, Peter Redgrove, suggest that menstruation at the new moon is more connected to a biological creative cycle, and at the full moon more to an artistic creative cycle—or, at any rate, a creativity that is not oriented to the birth of a child, but rather to the birth of something else.¹¹ I wonder if these differences between full moon and new moon bleeding at least partly explain why some women feel energized by their period, whereas others feel like withdrawing and being very quiet.

BLOOD

Like the moon, blood is one of the oldest and central symbols for humankind, representing for us the magic of life. Blood is the primary symbol of the life force. It is found in the most ancient of art, as red ochre painted on figurines and on cave walls. Blood is one of the earliest sacraments used by humankind. In Paleolithic times, "The dead

were buried in the fetal position with their arms across their chests, their bodies marked with red ocher, the pigmented earth, symbolic of life-giving blood."¹²

Blood has the power to create an impact. How does it feel when we see our blood coming out of our bodies? Blood is one of the manifestations of the mystery of our existence. Where did we come from? How did we get here? We know we are alive because our heart beats and pumps the blood through our veins. Our blood pulses and flows; blood moves through us continually.

We speak of drawing blood, of dripping blood, of people fainting when they see their blood. This occurs because of shock and of the fear of death overcoming us suddenly as we look at our blood flowing out of the body. Instinct tells us that when our blood is running freely from the body, we may die. The blood is supposed to be inside the body at all times—except for during menstruation and childbirth.

We all have rich red blood throbbing through the veins, pulsating gently along the arteries, and coursing through every cell. Carrying nutrients, dispersing waste, blood is the carrier, the conduit that enables our life force to flow.

Kings and queens are said to have blue or purple blood. Royal blood, peasant blood, Irish blood—we still speak of lineage and ancestry in terms of blood. The concept of lineage is synonymous with the idea of shared blood. Tribal ceremonies often involve the mixing of blood to become symbolic relatives—blood brothers and sisters. At gypsy weddings in Europe, the bride and groom traditionally ate bread that held a drop of each other's blood on it, or even sometimes mingled blood directly from cuts on the hands or arms.

The color red has its own symbolism, which is related to ideas about blood. To the Chinese red means wealth and is worn at weddings and other ceremonies where wealth is desired. The Maoris thought that anything became sacred once it was colored red, and

Easter eggs were traditionally colored red. In Celtic Britain, to be stained red meant to be chosen by the Goddess as a king.¹³

In some cultures there is a belief in the mysterious healing nature of menstrual blood. Medieval physicians believed that the menstrual blood of a young girl could heal leprosy. They also thought that it acted as an aphrodisiac.¹⁴

Menstrual blood was considered sacred by many cultures. In the Tantric tradition men became spiritually powerful by ingesting menstrual blood. Still today in the group rituals of the left-handed Tantric path, menstrual blood is taken along with red wine as a ritual drink.¹⁵ The Taoists, Egyptians, Persians, and Celts all had similar beliefs.¹⁶

Menstrual blood has also been used as a fertilizer and may have been a key in women's development of agriculture. In the autumn festival of the Thesmophoria, the women of ancient Greece mixed menstrual blood with the seed corn.

The women, who according to some authorities invented agriculture, did so because only they had the secret of the strong fertility of the seed corn. The reason for this was that originally the women mixed the seed corn with menstrual blood, which was the best possible fertilizer, before planting it. Since the men had no magic blood of this kind, they could not grow corn as well as the women could, any more than they could grow babies.¹⁷

Blood as Sacrament

In the Christian church the sacrament is taken in the form of red wine, a symbol of the blood of Christ. But red wine had been used as a symbol of the blood of the Great Mother, the Holy Woman, for centuries before Christ. In many cultures, ceremonies took place in

which women and men would take the symbolic blood of life in the form of red wine—for example, in the Dionysian mysteries and the Tantric rituals. Sometimes this was consciously acknowledged as being a symbol of the menstrual blood, the magical fluid out of which human life was created.

In matrifocal cultures blood was considered a carrier of magic because it represented the mystery of the life force. Elinor Gadon suggests that “the earliest rituals may have honored the menstrual cycle, the womb blood that nurtured the new life.”¹⁸

Blood was the main symbol for the wellspring of existence and the mystery that sends us forth into this life. As such it was revered. The fact that women bled once a month meant that they were closer to this wellspring, and this power innate in the female body was a large part of why the ineffable was revered in female form.

Later, as cultures throughout the world became patriarchal, puberty rituals developed for males that also involved the shedding of blood, such as the subincision practiced by the aborigines of Australia and the breast piercing in the Sun Dance of the Lakota Sioux. These rituals are imitations of the blood loss that women experience naturally.

The custom of blood sacrifice is thought to have originated in the practice of using menstrual blood as a sacrament. As male priests gained power and the feminine perspective waned, so the power of menstruation, an exclusively female act, was set apart from the rituals of worship and reverence. Instead of honoring the Goddess and God within, religion turned to the idea of an external force that needed to be placated by the offering of the blood of an animal or young person. This can be seen as a distortion of the more ancient knowledge of blood as representing the sacred nature of life itself. Offering the menstrual blood is entirely different from offering the blood of a being who has to die in order for its blood to be offered. Offering menstrual

blood was and is an affirmation of life, a recognition of its sanctity, of its magic.

It is very likely that male envy of the blood released by women has fueled many of the negative taboos around menstruation. The concept that menstrual blood is a pollutant is a distortion of the ancient idea that it was a sacrament.

EARTH

Like many people I know, I gain a great sense of peace and connectedness from walking in the wilds or simply sitting quietly on the earth or gardening, having my hands deep in the soil. We need this sense of connection to the natural world, to the planet we inhabit. When I've been in the city too long a part of me begins to go crazy, and I long for the beach, for the woods, for the feeling of real earth beneath my feet. As a friend of mine once said after living too long in London, "I just want to rip the concrete up off the streets and find the earth beneath it."

The earth has been considered female and sacred throughout history. The Earth Mother was recognized as the source of nutrition, of shelter and clothing. Many cultures have shared a sense of the earth as Divine Parent, whose gifts extend beyond the provision of physical nurturance and include moral and spiritual guidance. In Russia, instead of touching a Bible when taking an oath, a peasant would place a clod of earth on his head, invoking the curse of the Mother if he broke his word,¹⁹ and in Native American vision quest, the behavior of the natural world around one is seen as a source of special information.

The earth, like the menstruating woman, has lost her status as sacred mother as humans have become increasingly "civilized" and

distanced from nature. We have in many ways lost our instinctual relationship with the ground beneath our feet, and as a result we are filled with fear of poverty and scarcity. Our over-anxious hustle for ever greater material wealth may in part result from this loss of connection with the source of our physical nourishment and well-being.

As described above, the women of ancient Greece, and doubtless many other cultures, used their menstrual blood to fertilize the fields and had an intense and intimate relationship with the land because they bled onto it. As women, we are of the earth in a powerful way: She and we are the nurturers, the givers of life. We have an instinctive relationship of similarity with her, and giving our blood back onto the earth strengthens this relationship. (See chapter 10 for rituals regarding blood and the earth.)

SNAKE

I used to be terrified of snakes. I couldn't imagine why people would have them as pets. I remember once walking in a park and seeing a man carrying a huge python. I wouldn't go too close, but I stood and stared for a long time—there was intense fascination intermingled with my fear and revulsion. From the story of the serpent in the Garden of Eden onward, we have been conditioned to be repulsed by snakes.

In contrast, many of the earth-centered cultures of the world have had a reverence for the snake. They have seen in its cyclical shedding of the skin a metaphor for the birth/life/death cycle of humankind. It has also been used to illustrate the little deaths that we undergo during our life—the shedding of childhood at puberty, the shedding of

fertility at menopause, the shedding of relationships with the death of loved ones. That the snake lives on in a new and purified form after the skin has been shed has been universally used as a metaphor for the cleansing power of change and transformation as well as a symbol of everlasting life.

In matrifocal societies the snake was a friend, ally, and helper of the Goddess and of her priestesses and priests. In Ancient Egypt the hieroglyph for snake also meant Goddess. Priestesses used snake venom to induce trance, and would often have a snake familiar who lived with them, coiled in trance itself much of the time.

One of the main reasons for the association of women and snakes is that we share a pattern of cyclical shedding. For the snake it is a skin that is shed, for the woman the lining of the womb when she menstruates. The skin is shed, the death of the potential babe gives rise to the rebirth of the woman. The snake as a universal symbol of renewal gives us a vital clue into the menstrual mysteries. Our monthly shedding is the key to our own renewal, it is the key to our health. Every month we have the opportunity to renew and refresh our whole beings—physically, psychologically, and spiritually.

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HER BLOOD IS GOLD

In my twenties I spent a lot of time studying Chinese medicine, and the discovery that the Chinese have a very different attitude toward menstruation stimulated me to rethink my beliefs and practices. I learned that traditionally the Chinese recommend resting during menstruation and that they consider the cause of many gynecological complaints to be faulty behavior during menstruation, for example getting cold, lifting heavy objects, overworking, and eating inappropriate food.

Up until this point I hadn't really thought about my period very much other than to consider it a nuisance. I had been raised to grin and bear it and carry on as normal and to suppress my desire to lie around in a dream for a couple of days a month. I also suffered from bad cramps, which I usually treated with painkillers, although I knew that rest and a hot water bottle would soothe them—it was just that I couldn't allow myself to rest.

My Chinese teachers encouraged me to honor my body feelings, because they had a medical model that supported the idea of rest during menses. It was wonderful to discover a whole body of medical knowledge and folklore that recommended that I do exactly what I felt like doing when I had my period. Suddenly I found that it was okay to indulge myself and to spend the first day or so of my period lying down and spacing out in a comfortable and quiet environment, sipping hot herb tea and allowing my body to have a rest. As I experienced the healing that began to take place in my whole body, I realized that the menstrual period is a natural time for women to rest, a time in every month when the body requests a time, a few hours at least, of relaxation. By cutting through this natural tendency and attempting to fit into a male-dominated work schedule, I had begun to make myself sick.

Beginning to follow my body rather than ordering it around after me was a major shift. But that wasn't all—the discovery that not everyone thought the same way about menstruation opened up my own thinking. I began to realize that there was a wisdom inherent in the body itself and that my own culture didn't necessarily have a very wise or useful attitude to the processes of being female. The recognition that my attitude to menstruation had developed in the context of a society that has diminished the female for several thousand years was a major step in the development of my understanding.

I realized that not everybody everywhere thinks that menstruation is an inconvenient event to be ignored and not everyone everywhere thinks that it is yet more proof that women are inferior to men.

However, the Chinese model only went so far. It never approached issues of power and spirituality, and although the emphasis on rest was very useful, it kept me locked in a mind-set that said

menstruation was weakness rather than strength. It was when I came across the teachings of the Native American tradition a few years later that I began to understand that something very profound was going on while I was lying about and spacing out—it wasn't simply that I was resting a tired body and rebuilding lost red blood cells.

In the Native American tradition a woman is considered to be at her most powerful, psychically and spiritually, when she is menstruating. Resting during menstruation is seen in the context of one's attention being elsewhere—on the spiritual planes, gathering wisdom.

The different feelings that women have when they menstruate are understood to be part of something very meaningful about the cycles of the woman's body. In many Native American societies, before their traditional practices were suppressed, the women would go to a menstrual hut (a moon-lodge) to pass the time of their bleeding.

Most of the women would bleed at the same time, usually coinciding with the new moon. In *Daughters of Copper Woman*, Anne Cameron describes the lives of women of the Nootka people of the Pacific Northwest, and reports that the atmosphere in the moon-lodge was one of a holiday or party. The women would play games and talk and rub each other's backs to ease cramps. They would sit on special moss padding and give their blood back to the Earth Mother.¹

It wasn't only a time for rest and relaxation, but also a time for gathering spiritual wisdom. In the tale of Tem Eyos Ki, a woman living at the time when the men of the tribe began to assume dominance over the women, it is during her seclusion during menstruation that she comes to an awakening. As a result of the wisdom she finds in the moon-lodge (called the waiting house by the Nootka), she emerges after four days and sings a song of great beauty and love that awakens the tribe to the imbalance between the men

and the women.² This story echoes the Cherokee belief that the menstruating woman is performing a function of cleansing and of gathering wisdom that is beneficial not only for the woman herself but also for the whole tribe.

One of the most inspiring accounts of menstrual beliefs and practices that I have read comes from a woman of the Yurok people of Northern California, paraphrased by Thomas Buckley:

A menstruating woman should isolate herself because this is the time when she is at the height of her powers. Thus the time should not be wasted in mundane tasks and social distractions, nor should one's concentration be broken by concerns with the opposite sex. Rather, all of one's energies should be applied in concentrated meditation "to find out the purpose of your life" and toward the "accumulation" of spiritual energy. The menstrual shelter, or room, is "like the men's sweathouse," a place where you "go into yourself and make yourself stronger." The blood that flows serves to "purify" the woman, preparing her for spiritual accomplishment. A woman must use a scratching implement, instead of scratching absent-mindedly with her fingers, as an aid in focusing her full attention on her body by making even the most natural and spontaneous of actions fully conscious and intentional: "You should feel all of your body exactly as it is, and pay attention."³

It was usual for most Native American groups to hold puberty rituals for the young women, and for many, including the Apache, these were the most elaborate and beloved of all their ceremonies. The puberty rituals of the Nootka graphically demonstrate the respect and

reverence that they had for women. After a girl had her first moon-time there would be a big party for her. Then she would undergo a ritual of endurance, in which she would be taken far out to sea and left to make her own way home by swimming back to land. On arriving back at the shore she would be greeted by the whole village, and from that moment on she would be recognized as a woman and seen as ready for the responsibilities of marriage and children.⁴

The description of the training for this rite of passage emphasizes both physical strength and the development of character. It was considered important that a woman be able to demonstrate her capacity for patience and perseverance.⁵

This teaching seems so apt, and so lacking in our modern world. Our initiation of girls into womanhood is superficial in comparison—learning to put on make-up, wearing a first bra, using a tampon for the first time. Many women get married and get pregnant without having any sense of their own capacity for endurance, physically or psychologically. Small wonder then that so many girl-women elect to give birth with the aid of pain-killers and a technology that robs them of the experience of their own strength. This lack of challenge and strengthening at puberty may also contribute to the self-hate that afflicts so many young women and leads to eating disorders and addictions.

The puberty rituals of the Pygmies of the Congo, described by Colin Turnbull in *The Forest People*, also depict a culture with a positive view of women and of their power. Unlike the Pygmies, the nearby African villagers view the arrival of a girl's first menstrual blood as an evil omen, "something best concealed and not talked about in public. The girl is an object of suspicion, scorn, repulsion, and anger." In contrast, the Pygmies greet menstrual blood as a symbol of life, and when a Pygmy girl has her first blood it is considered a gift. The whole

group joins in a puberty festival called the *elima*, and as Turnbull notes, “the *elima* is one of the happiest, most joyful occasions in their lives.”

The *elima* involves all kinds of physical activities and much playing and running in the forest, as well as training by the older women in the *elima* house. The girls learn the songs of the women and they sing loudly through the forest, “so that everyone should know that they were the *Bamelina*, the people of the *elima*, girls who had been blessed with the blood and were now women.”⁶

Turnbull notes that the Pygmies, unlike their village-dwelling neighbors, have a benign worldview—that is, they think of the forest in which they live as a place that will readily meet their needs for food and shelter as well as their needs for spiritual protection. They are completely at home in the forest, and they have a relationship of love and respect with their environment. This seems to be intricately related to their positive attitude to the feminine.

The Yurok and the Nootka also had a good relationship with their environment. They were well adapted to it, and the ocean and rivers and forests nearby gave them ample food. Like the Pygmies, they saw menstruation as a time of power and the puberty of girls a time of strength and celebration.

It seems that a benign worldview is a prerequisite for a positive attitude toward one’s own world—one’s own body—and most specifically, toward the female body, as that is a microcosm of the larger female body, the earth.

This is clearly reflected in the attitudes of these two cultures to menstruation. It is interesting to note that as Euro-Western culture becomes more earth-conscious and awakened to the ecological damage that our lack of respect for the earth is creating, the female is also becoming more respected.

Menstruation beliefs and rituals have fascinated anthropologists for years, and there is a growing body of research on the subject. If you are interested and want to find out more about different cultures and their perspectives on menstruation, I strongly recommend the book *Blood Magic*, edited by Thomas Buckley and Alma Gottlieb. There are also several other books mentioned in the bibliography at the back of this book.

PART TWO

RECLAIMING
THE CYCLE

4

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THE WOUNDED WOMAN

When I was growing up I swore that I would not turn out like my female forebears. My mother and grandmothers seemed to have a much more restricted life than the men of the family, and I could see that they commanded less respect as soon as the conversation veered from the personal to the world of ideas and opinions. I was a well-read, opinionated girl who placed a high value on intellectual respect, and I didn't see any reason why my opinion should have less weight than a man's. My parents supported me in this; they wanted me to have a good education and to have confidence in myself. I was smart, and I knew it.

In the outside world it was clear that it was the fathers who had the money and the power and the freedom and the control. I never saw any women who had a level of autonomy and control to match that of the men. The only women I knew who worked were the teachers at school. All other women were mothers. I promised myself that I

would not have a life like that, where I had to subordinate myself to a husband and family.

The problem with breaking tradition in this way, albeit aided and abetted by my family, was that I tended to see everything about my mother's and grandmothers' priorities, skills, and worldviews as somehow old hat, backward-looking, emotional rather than intellectual. In rebelling against the image of womanhood as the supporter of men and the nurturer of the family, I threw out much of the value of the feminine. It took a conscious wish and deep inner work to begin loving myself as a woman and to stop running away from my female nature.

At school and university I was trained in an analytical model of perception that I valued above feelings and intuition. Growing up in the sixties and seventies meant that I was part of a generation that experimented with drugs to help shift our consciousness into an awareness of the value of the nonrational. This had the effect of somewhat compensating for the one-sidedness of my education. (These days I would recommend other ways to escape from the prisons of over-analytical minds.) But despite my explorations of different states of consciousness, as a teenager I had already made certain decisions about myself and my life based on an abhorrence of the female and the diminished role she was forced to carry in the society in which I was raised.

These decisions carried on into my twenties, often translated into an unconscious awkwardness with the female aspect of myself. I had no role models of the kind of woman I wanted to be. I was making it up as I went along, and sometimes the only way I could do what I wanted appeared to be by dispensing with the female within altogether. And in a subtle way, that translated into my sense of my body. I wore jeans most of the time, and I eschewed much of what would be considered female. I kept my home in good shape and I was sympathetic with my friends—but I valued my work in the outside world

more than anything else, because that appeared to be what society placed most value upon.

By the time I was twenty I had been taking the Great Liberator (the pill) for about two years. I noticed that I was getting increasingly emotional and upset during my so-called period and these temporary bursts of hysteria felt very strange, as if I really wasn't myself. I decided to stop taking the pill and see if that had anything to do with it. I was also beginning to have fantasies about getting pregnant although that was, to my conscious mind, an impossibility. I was much too young, unmarried, and aware that my friends who had kids young seemed to have a very difficult time. No, that was a Bad Idea, only entered into by irresponsible women who didn't know what to do with their lives and who resorted to their biological functions. Well I was going to have a career and be a useful member of society, not a mere breeder.

The split in me between the instincts of my inner woman and my masculine-oriented social conditioning was severe. And I didn't realize it. I thought I was a feminist. It didn't occur to me, at that age, that the reason my less organized friends with babies had such a hard time was because society was arranged in such a way that young women had very little power. And no one seemed to be very interested in helping them. I really did think, and it is very painful to admit this, that it was their fault, that they had been stupid to get pregnant. I was going to be very careful that it didn't happen to me.

That was one part of me—the other side was flirting with the idea of pregnancy. So I came off the pill, partly because I suspected that it was messing me up and also because there was the glimmer of a reproductive drive stirring in my being.

After a couple of months I felt like "myself" again, and I realized that despite the convenience of the pill, I had actually felt cheated because my periods were so light. This was when I began to realize that menstruating was an important part of my life, a rhythm that I

depended on for my psychic and physical health, and that I ignored or suppressed it at my peril.

I became interested in the whole cycle, and investigated natural birth control. My bedroom was plastered with charts as I attempted to track my mucus flow. I never was very good about taking my temperature, and I've always disliked thermometers. But I did begin to realize that if I took the time to tune in, I actually had a lot of awareness about what was happening in my body. I could feel a twinge over my ovary when I ovulated. I could track the subtle shifts in my sexuality, the levels of introversion and extroversion throughout the month. I began to understand that it was possible to befriend this mysterious cycle that had always seemed a burden to me. I liked knowing what my body was up to.

Despite the glimmers of awareness that this awakening brought, when I became pregnant a few years later I still had an attitude of neglect toward my body when its needs interfered with my work. I remember being extremely hungry but putting other things before eating. I miscarried, and the grief that I felt in my body for the lost baby and the frustration of a pregnancy cut short awakened me to my body and its essential femaleness in a shocking way.

This was an experience that set me apart from the world of men, and the intellect, in a stark and thorough way. I had no conscious resources within me to deal with the feelings that overwhelmed me. I was full of loss for a being that had at most been six weeks old. It didn't make any sense. But I could feel my body grieving in a powerful way. I cried endlessly and was depressed throughout the rest of what would have been the pregnancy. All I wanted was to get pregnant again, but I didn't conceive. My husband didn't understand my pain, and I didn't understand or accept it enough to be able to explain it to him. I was lost in an unprepared-for sea of hormonal anguish. Being a woman was taking me into regions of feeling that were vast

and uncontrollable. Why had no one prepared me for this? Why didn't anyone talk about the fact that a woman's physiology had such a powerful effect on her mental and emotional state? Was I some kind of aberration—or was this another of the facets of female experience consigned to the secret compartment of life?

One day an acupuncture client of mine said, "I had three miscarriages you know, and every time I felt the most terrible grief. No one understands the pain of it who hasn't been through it."

I felt a bit better after that, and I realized that I didn't have a single woman in my family or circle of friends who had had a miscarriage and who could have reassured me from her own experience. But many of them had been through pregnancy and childbirth—if miscarriage could provoke such a flood of feeling, what on earth was giving birth like? I began talking to women and reading on the subject, and I began to see that there was still a folkloric tradition that understood mood swings and hyper-emotionality but that this traditional knowledge didn't fit into the modern world. It seemed to be being taken less and less into account. Were women becoming less emotional, or was society refusing to acknowledge the relationship between cycles and mood? It seemed to me that much of the richness of female experience was being cauterized by the machine age, by the linear mind that works in weeks rather than moon cycles and talks of pregnancy as forty weeks rather than nine moons; that calls a woman's blood-time her "period" rather than any of the more beautiful names that have been used in other times and cultures—the most often heard being the term used by the Native Americans, *moon-time*.

After the miscarriage my moon-time became extremely painful. I had truly terrible cramps, and atrocious premenstrual rages. My marriage was falling apart, and the chief reason seemed to be our inability to understand each other's maleness and femaleness. We used to joke about men and women needing to live apart for their own sanity. But

really, we each didn't understand or respect the needs and rhythms of our own gender. I would become enraged every month in order to send my husband away, instead of being able to say gracefully "I would like some time alone when I am bleeding."

THE WOUND MAKES ITSELF KNOWN

In my late twenties I discovered that I had cervical dysplasia (abnormal cells on the surface of the cervix), and the gynecologist wanted to cauterize my cervix. I was horror-struck, and my body recoiled from such a brutal procedure. I knew that this was not going to be healing for me, and it would just further damage an area already wounded by a clumsy D&C after the miscarriage.

It wasn't only the procedure that appeared brutal to me—the gynecologist had a brutal manner. For one thing, he was a man, which I initially accepted; I later realized that my true reaction was intense discomfort. It was incongruous to have a man coldly and clinically discussing the condition of my cervix. I hated the way he winked at me when he told me to "Take your bottom half things off." I hated having an unknown man inserting cold metal instruments inside me and demonstrating the results of his tests to spotty male students. They all stood around, three of them, all male, staring into a microscope that was inserted into my vagina, as I lay with my feet wide apart in stirrups, like some kind of captive animal. I was deeply offended by this. He was treating a very dear and sensitive part of my body as if he temporarily owned it. And I was outraged when he took a biopsy from my cervix without telling me first what he was going to do. The most piercing pain I have ever felt shot through the interior of my body. I screamed, and asked, shocked and terrified, "What have you done to me?"

“Oh be quiet,” he said. “It doesn’t hurt. There aren’t enough nerve endings there for it to hurt.”

After that I didn’t trust him to do anything else to me, and I told him that I felt that there was a psychological reason for my illness, and that I preferred to use gentle methods to heal it. He exploded and told me I was a foolish woman and would undoubtedly die as a result of refusing his surgery. I burst into tears and ran out of his office. How dare he talk to me like that, as if I was nothing, just a body for his skills to work on. I knew that his threat was an attempt to bully me, and one that had no justifiable foundation—the level of dysplasia I had was mild and had a good chance of getting better without surgical treatment.

I had little faith in the procedures of modern medicine because they paid no attention to factors that I was sure were involved in my dis-ease, such as my recent divorce, and the way my periods had been recently, and various other factors of which I had only a glimmering awareness. All they looked at was my cervix—and I knew very well that all of me was involved in this aberration from the norm. It seemed poor medicine not to take the other factors into account.

My lack of faith made me very uncomfortable whenever I went for a doctor’s visit. It had been several years since I had been near a doctor, and in the interim I had been practicing acupuncture and living a lifestyle around naturopathic principles. I was shocked when I rediscovered the mind-set that accompanies modern medicine. I would try and talk about my state of mind and how I knew that it was affecting my health and that I was sure that there were less invasive methods of healing that I could use. After all, this was a long way from being a threatening condition. I could afford to take the time I needed to heal more naturally without cutting and cauterizing and traumatizing my body.¹

No one wanted to listen. They just wanted to do invasive and unpleasant things to me, as fast as possible please, without, it seemed to

me, due consideration of the possible outcome. They wanted a quiet compliant patient with no self-awareness. They had stolen my right to my own process of illness and recovery. It seemed obvious to me that if I didn't get the meaning from the message my cervix was giving me, then my body would try again, and I would become sick, perhaps in a different way. It didn't make sense to go ahead and permanently scar my cervix, possibly affecting my ability to carry a child to full term, without trying to understand why my body was behaving in this way.

Each time I had to have a biopsy (I had changed to a different doctor and hospital by this point), the doctor showed no interest in my distaste for the procedure or for my sense that it might be traumatizing an already upset area.

I knew that the whole thing was tied in with my periods, which had been strange recently. My cycle had shortened to twenty-one days, and I had a very different blood flow. I knew instinctively that something was going on with my womb and that the dysplasia was a symptom of an imbalance that was deeper. I suspected there was an important issue for me to get hold of.

I realized after a while that I really wanted to heal myself. It just didn't feel right to me to go through this surgical business. But I decided I would have to, so I opted for the least invasive remedy—laser treatment. Then a series of interesting synchronicities prevented me from having the treatment. It was delayed and delayed, and before the rescheduled date for the treatment, I went to a workshop led by a man who teaches the Native American tradition.

He told me that in the Native American teachings a menstruating woman has the potential to be more psychically and spiritually powerful than anyone, male or female, at any other time. That turned my conditioned pictures of reality upside down. I'd always experienced my period as a time of weakness and difficulty—what on earth was the man talking about?

When I asked him specifically about my wounded cervix he asked me a lot of questions and then said that he thought that my problem was rooted in a denial of my femaleness and that he saw that I had negative ideas deep in my unconscious about what it meant to be a woman. He told me to dig a hole in my garden every now and then and speak all the negative thoughts I could think of about the state of being female into the hole, then cover it up so that the earth could transform the energy (just as it transforms waste matter into compost, so it has the capacity to transform our thoughts).

When I went home I tried this technique. I felt pretty silly, and I was glad that no one could see into my tiny garden. I didn't know that I had so many bad feelings about being a woman lurking in my highly educated feminist mind until I did this exercise. It was painful, and it was very effective.

I started looking at how I behaved when I had my period, and the first thing I saw was that I used tampons. I tuned in to my body and in my imagination asked my vagina and cervix what they thought of tampons. "Ugh," they said, unequivocally. "Horrible things." And I thought about it and realized that maybe there was something important about the blood flowing freely out of the vagina. It occurred to me that the tampons might be irritating my cervix, and I wondered if my initial difficulty with them in my teens hadn't in fact been a wise instinct of my body. I had used tampons without ever thinking about the effect they might be having on me—they were a source of liberation, I thought, one that allowed me to act as if I didn't really have a period.

"Aha!" I thought. "One that allowed me to pretend I wasn't really having a period." And I watched that thought, and the thoughts behind it, and I began to realize that I had a background belief that my period was something to be ignored and suppressed as much as possible. Suppression was, I knew, one of the main causes of illness and

imbalance. Maybe my periods wanted to have a more central place in my life and in my awareness. I began to experiment with that.

If my bleeding started at the weekend, I stopped driving and stayed home, relaxing in my garden. I remember that it was summer and I lay in the sunshine, just experiencing my bleeding. It was interesting to me—I felt so much better if I just lay about and did nothing. If my period started during the working week it was more of a problem, but I would try and rest as much as I could. It was a couple of years before I had the space to really go into what was happening when I was bleeding, but in the beginning it was a major step to allow my period into my life just that much. To sit through the pain instead of reaching automatically for a pain-killer, to wear pads instead of tampons and look at my blood and feel the blood coming out of me, to just sit and begin to tune in to my bleeding body, to get the first glimmers of a sense of peace that came from just Being, letting go of Doing.

At last I began to feel that I was getting in touch with the root of my problems, but the way forward seemed blurry to me. It was clear that in order to heal myself, to become at ease with myself and comfortable in my skin, I had to love my womanliness to a depth that I had not yet plumbed. And in order to do this I had to realize that once again, I had no role models.

I felt very alone. I had a good friend who paid attention to her periods, and her friendship helped me enormously at this time—but I also wanted an older woman as a guide, someone who understood the wholeness of being female in a way that no one around me did. I felt tantalizingly close to this wholeness at times, usually when I was bleeding, but then I would return to my accustomed state of underlying confusion about what it meant to be a woman. In what way was it different from being a man? And how did the menstrual cycle relate to that? I began to wonder about the effect that menstruation had on

me not only physically, now that I had realized that it was a time for rest and renewal, but also psychologically and spiritually. What was the meaning of this bleeding time in my overall development, my individuation, and my place in society?

During this time I repeatedly dreamed of a woman who had been bruised and battered. She was very sad, and I would take her in my arms and comfort her. In the dreams I felt shocked at the extent of the cruelty that had been perpetrated on her, and I also saw that she had somehow allowed this damage to take place. I didn't understand why the damage had occurred, but I could hold her in my arms and love her. So I did that, night after night. Sometimes I made love to her. Sometimes I simply held her. Sometimes I just looked at her bruises. I didn't relate to her personally at this time—I had never been beaten like that. Now it is clear that she was a symbol of my wounded woman within, but at the time she was a visitor to my dream-life, and not really a part of "me." Usually she was blonde, which made it harder for me to identify with her personally because I have dark hair. And maybe she was a visitor, as well as a representation of a part of myself. What was clear was that I loved her and I wanted to heal her.

For me the wound of being female was a literal wound on the surface of my cervix, and it became clear to me through my dreams and fantasies that my work was to heal the wounded woman within. Doing the exercise of digging the hole in the ground had made me very aware of the largely unconscious negativity that I had toward so much of female reality. I began to look more closely than ever at what had created that wounding, at what "female reality" actually meant, and at how our society rejected or belittled so much of that. Recovering the beauty and majesty and joy of being female became my task in life.

By allowing my body to be my teacher—by really listening to myself while I was bleeding, I began to understand what the Native

Americans were talking about when they stressed the potential power of menstruation.

I began to look at my blood with a tinge of awe rather than fear, disgust, or indifference. By this time I no longer used tampons, so I got to look at my blood properly every month. I saw that sometimes it was clear and red and sometimes darker and clotted. If I really freed up my vision, I could see that it was full of life, full of magic, full of potential. I began to experience a frisson of joy when I thought about bleeding, about being a woman, that there was something, after all, extraordinarily magical and mysterious about inhabiting a female body. The resentment about being female that I had held in my teens and early twenties, the feelings that boys had a better deal, faded away and were replaced by a growing sense of wonder at the intricacies and depths and possibilities offered by the monthly cycle.

I began to take time not only to rest but also to meditate and just be with myself when I had my period. I found out that it was a time when I was particularly able to find insight and that this insight was of a timeless nature. I noticed that my dreams were often very strong, especially toward the end of my period—clear and prophetic. I felt I was tapping into some ancient and vast wellspring of female wisdom—simply by sitting still and listening when I was bleeding. Taking this time out when I was bleeding created a very different relationship with my body. My health improved, my cervix healed, and gradually the bad cramps I had experienced for most of my menstruating life eased up. My period became a time of pleasure rather than pain.

I was beginning to really love myself. Of course, you can't make yourself do this, just as you can't make yourself love another person. It began to happen very gradually, and many people came into my life who helped me see more clearly. But the revelation at the beginning was that menstruation is a source of power. This priceless

piece of information, coupled with a strong instinct I had about the power of the womb, transformed my deep and largely unconscious lack of self-respect.

This was the information I had needed to give me the confidence to set about healing my own gynecological problems. It inspired me to see if I could feel the power of menstruation if I paid enough attention when I was bleeding. To think of menstruation as a source of power for women completely went against my conditioning, and yet I knew in my heart that it was true. I realized that in the dichotomy between what our culture teaches us, and my gut reaction of "Yes! Of course!" to this ancient wisdom, there was a lot of energy. When you find the places where a culture splits from a natural truth you have found a key—a way inside the diseases of the culture. I began to understand that the split between the wisdom and power of bleeding that I was perceiving and modern society's attitudes to the womb lay at the heart of the subjugation and denial of female reality and experience.

One of the gifts of being female is the access to other worlds that comes during the premenstruum and the time of bleeding. This liminal time opens a woman up to her psychic abilities. Euro-Western mechanistic culture prizes the rational and is suspicious of the nonrational—of the intuition, the unseen realms, and the world of the spirit. The Christian church has encouraged us to think of ourselves as separate from God and in need of the intermediary of a priest in order to connect with spiritual realms. This emphasis on rationalism and the severance from an autonomous relationship with Spirit has served to cut women off from a deep relationship with their menstrual cycle. A great part of women's psychic strength is tied up with the cycles of their bodies, and if we ignore this time and fail to recognize its enormous value then we lose touch with the richness of female experience.

For many women, the root of their unhappiness lies in a painful relationship with the processes of being female. Women are trained to

hide the fact that they are menstruating at all costs. Blood stains on clothing are a hideous embarrassment. No one ever says, "I don't want to come to work or go to the party because I've got my period" unless they are feeling ill with it, and then they usually say they have a headache or a digestive problem.

When the womb and menstruation are seen merely as uncomfortable biological necessity, women's self-esteem is correspondingly low. We are our bodies—and we can't really love ourselves deep down in the bottom of our hearts if we don't wholeheartedly love our bodies. And you don't love your body if you catch yourself saying, "Oh no, I've got my period."

Of course, one of the reasons that we say such things is because our lives are planned out in advance. The altered state that menstruation can take one into is not compatible with late twentieth-century action-packed industrial life, with running around in the world performing our scheduled and organized tasks. Menstruation is predictably unpredictable. You never know exactly when it is going to come, and sometimes it completely surprises you. Not only is it inconsiderate of timetables and schedules, it is also messy. Hooray! We try to sanitize and order modern life to the degree that we run into danger of there being no life left in us. Periods save us from this doom—they are a wild and basic, raw and instinctual, bloody and eternal aspect of the female—and no amount of "civilization" will change that. My period is a monthly occurrence in my life that I have in common with all women who have ever lived. Women living in caves twenty thousand years ago, priestesses in palaces in ancient Egypt, seers in temples in Sumeria, all bled with the moon. The first woman who made fire might well have had her period at the time. Now that's a thought. If menstruation is a highly creative time for women psychically and spiritually, who knows what gifts humankind has been brought by women during their menses.

The value we place on menstruation has a direct correlation with the value we place on ourselves as women. If we look at the attitudes of matrifocal, earth-centered societies, we see a very different relationship with the menstrual cycle. As we saw in chapter 3, some cultures prize the onset of menstruation and mark it with celebration. In some Native American societies a menstruating woman's dreams are taken very seriously for their oracular wisdom. In the Tantric tradition a menstruating woman is considered to be at the height of her power, "a true transmitter of the life force, able to act and respond with power and wisdom."²

It is the loss of contact with this innate wisdom that has led to the distortion of menstrual power into menstrual symptoms.

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WORKING WITH MENSTRUAL SYMPTOMS

Anthropological literature abounds with tales of menstrual taboos based on fear and terror of the polluting and dangerous nature of the menstruating woman. When the bodily processes of women and the innate power of menstruation are denied and suppressed, what could be a highly creative energy gets twisted into something “evil.” The many taboos about menstruating women show a recognition of power—but usually with negative interpretation. If a menstruating woman can, as the Talmud warns, cause the death of a man by her mere presence,¹ or, as Pliny tells us, by her touch “blast the fruits of the field, sour wine, cloud mirrors, rust iron, and blunt the edges of knives,”² then there can be little doubt that something pretty powerful is going on.

Even if we find these beliefs laughable in our rational age, they do show a primitive recognition of the power of menstruation, albeit

interpreted from a misogynist perspective. Although these superstitions were part of the weaponry of anti-female propaganda, and were used to restrict and penalize women for their natural bodily functions, at least they did acknowledge that women have power. These days, by ignoring menstruation and suppressing it, we have lost and forgotten this ancient knowledge and have come to believe that our monthly cycle is merely a biological phenomenon.

J. G. Frazer notes in *The Golden Bough* that the same taboos are used for the cloths of menstruating women as for those of holy men and kings.

The uncleanness, as it is called, of girls at puberty and the sanctity of holy men do not, to the primitive mind, differ materially from each other. They are only different manifestations of the same mysterious energy which, like energy in general, is in itself neither good nor bad, but becomes beneficent or maleficent according to its application.³

The sacredness and specialness of puberty arises from it being considered a limen—a liminal stage in development where the individual is neither child nor adult, a stage in which the veil between the worlds thins and the adolescent is vulnerable to the world of the spirit. In cultures with a benign worldview this vulnerability is seen as a blessing with the potential for wisdom and transformation. The transition from child to adult is respected and taken seriously. It is considered fundamental to the health of both the individual and the group. The teaching given to a young Native American during the adolescent vision quest is seen as useful not only for the individual but also for the tribe. In cultures with a negative worldview, the limen is seen more as a time during which both the tribe and the individual need protection. Both of these beliefs constitute the root of many of the

puberty rituals that take the child away from the rest of the group until he or she is considered to have gone through the limen and emerged as an adult. Usually this emergence is marked by some kind of ceremony. As noted in chapter 3, in societies with a benign worldview, the rites of puberty are greeted with joy and celebration, whereas in those with an emphasis on sin and evil and anxiety about bad spirits, the ceremony focuses on casting out demons. In patriarchal societies in particular, a girl's first blood is viewed with fear, suspicion, and even with dread.

Menstruation itself can be viewed as a liminal phase. The woman is in between: not pregnant, and not yet fertile again. She is in a sacred interlude during which she is shedding the past and being renewed before the next opportunity to create human life.

Whether the powerful menstrual energy is used in a positive way, as with the Nootka and the Yurok, or whether it is uncontrolled and random and ruins the curing of hams, as with Portuguese villagers,⁴ it is nonetheless Power. Power is strong energy, and whenever strong energy is not focused and utilized, it will go somewhere unpredictable and have an unpredictable effect. Energy is information, it will always surface somewhere, and if it is not allowed out through the life-force, the creative drive, then it will surface in the body as symptoms or in one's emotional life as relationship problems.⁵

If women were to access and work with the power of menstruation instead of suppressing it, then perhaps the power that at the moment expresses itself in the form of symptoms would be free to work in a more harmonious and less disturbing way.

Symptoms arise to wake us up. They make us put our attention on the part of the body where they occur. We can't escape our wombs if they are making pain, and we can't ignore the menstrual cycle if it makes us behave differently for a week every month. This is part, if not the whole, of the meaning of symptoms. And it

is important to remember that they are *symptoms*—that is, the surface manifestation of a deeper disturbance. They are messages from the body. You could say they are simply messages of a hormone imbalance or a nutritional deficiency—but that begs a further set of questions. Why is there a hormone imbalance? Why is there a nutritional deficiency? Many women correct their diet and take vitamins, and still have menstrual symptoms.

The very aspects of menstruation that we loathe have within them the seeds of much information. Every time you have a period you are put in touch with the unconscious through your body. So a heavier or lighter flow, more or less pain, or other symptoms all carry information. Extrapolating the meaning from your period is an individual matter and involves getting to know yourself and spending time while you are bleeding tuning in to whatever is going on.

PREMENSTRUAL SYNDROME

PMS should actually stand for Pre-Menstrual Strength, because that is what it really is: our female power turned in on itself because patriarchal culture fails to nurture and honor women's reality and women's gifts.⁶ When that power is recognized and developed, it becomes clear that what the premenstruum brings is emotional clarity and courage.

During my twenties I was married for several years. It was not a successful marriage—we didn't have enough in common to sustain a long-term relationship. After a couple of years I began to suffer from bad PMS and would become really impossible to live with for about a week every month. I found myself hating my husband and finding everything he did irritating. Sometimes I couldn't understand why I was with him, I found him so loathsome. Of course, he wasn't—he

was far from loathsome—but the suppression of my unhappiness the rest of the month resulted in this outrageous swing into total intolerance during the premenstruum.

He and I colluded together to see this rage as a biological quirk that had nothing to do with the fact that I was chronically angry with the lack of communication in our marriage. I simply saw it as something that was wrong with me, and I never thought that it might have something useful behind it. After we divorced and I experienced the relief of being out of a relationship that was profoundly wrong for me, I began to see the role my premenstrual anguish had taken in destroying the relationship, and a funny little thought crept in—the PMS was actually a helper; it had helped me to get out.

My premenstrual anguish eased up and I began to see that it was indeed a friend and ally. If I had a lot of premenstrual symptoms it was a sign to check into my life—what did I really want to be doing, or saying, or experiencing?

Although PMS does involve physical symptoms, for the vast majority of women it is the psychological symptoms that are the most troublesome. Such symptoms include irritability, anxiety, mood swings, depression, hostility, and in severe cases, suicidal or murderous feelings. Eighty percent of women experiencing PMS report that they have increased anxiety and irritability in the days leading up to the onset of bleeding. It is estimated that between one-third and one-half of all women between the ages of eighteen and thirty-five suffer from PMS, so the incidence of premenstrually related psychological symptoms affects millions of women.⁷

Let's turn the normal way of looking at these symptoms on its head and instead of seeing them as something unpleasant that should be changed, seeing them as something potentially useful. What could be useful about being hostile? About being very emotional? About crying and shouting and screaming?

Women are more likely to suffer from PMS if they have children and if they are married.⁸ In fact, the harder it is for them to have time alone, the more likely it is that they will experience difficulty with PMS. So it may be that one of the functions of PMS is that through hostility, women repel those around them, and therefore are able to have a little time to themselves. Before I became conscious of my need to spend time alone during the premenstruum I often experienced a feeling of deep relief when the man in my life took himself out of the house rather than stay around my bad mood. It's not quite that simple—I have also been very emotional when alone, and that leads us into the second useful aspect of PMS.

In order to keep the peace around us, we hold in many of our feelings. And in order to comply with a social norm of unemotional behavior, we even deny those feelings to ourselves. I have no information on the incidence of PMS in cultures that allow and accept emotional expression, but it is interesting to speculate that a woman in Naples who is freer with her feelings during the month might have less need to explode premenstrually than a woman in England where there is a strong taboo against the outward manifestation of feelings. PMS has the wonderful effect of releasing feelings and opinions that have been locked up in the prison of conventional behavior.

I found that when I began to pick up this pattern consciously, I stopped needing to have crazy fights and wild outbursts just before my period—what I actually wanted to do was clear up any relationship difficulties that remained hanging around in my life. There were things I needed to say to my partner, to the friend I had that difficult phone call with, to my mother who I felt I had not given enough time to, and so on. Using this time to work on unfinished material and then to express it can be very healing for our relationships and can take them into a new realm of connectedness and honesty.

The cleansing aspect of menstruation also takes place at a psychological level in terms of clarifying and resolving relationships. And not only in the arena of relationships with other people. It is also a perfect opportunity for clearing up one's relationship with oneself. The tears you didn't cry two weeks ago because you didn't let yourself, come trickling out premenstrually. One of the main causes of illness is unexpressed emotion that needs to be expressed somewhere, and so it comes out through the body. Thus PMS is a saving grace for many women in that the lid comes off for a day or two every month and suppressed emotions are released, lessening the likelihood of them being expressed later through a body symptom.

It also makes sense, given the infinite wisdom and inherent balancing capacity of our bodies, that we would have a time of cleansing and emptying before and as we bleed. It all works together, the body and the psyche are one, not separate. As the body releases toxins through the blood, so the psyche releases mental and emotional toxins through the expression of feelings. Often these feelings tend to manifest as anger simply because they have been blocked. Witness the anxious mother whose child disappears—her relief soon shifts to anger as the intense feelings she has been holding onto come tumbling out. If feelings are processed as they arise, anger is merely one of a whole range. The issue is whether we allow ourselves the whole range. Most families and most cultures have certain emotions that are less favored and so tend not to be expressed because the individual doesn't identify with them. So we find men who are sure that they are never afraid, women who are convinced that they never feel angry, and many people who think that they are never sad. One of the taboos in my own family when I was growing up was jealousy. My brother and I were discouraged from expressing jealousy at all, and consequently I had to learn in later life that I even felt it. Because I was convinced

that I was above such low feelings, I would suppress it the minute it came remotely into view.

Having a bias against a particular emotion means that emotion is the one that is likely to come out when the defenses are down—during illness, in times of stress, and to varying degrees, in the premenstruum. This is why we don't recognize ourselves and instead say, "I turn into a monster just before my period," and seek a physiological reason and a physical remedy. Often there is a physiological reason, and diet and other remedies can be very helpful, but the mind and the body are not separate, and working at a psychological level can do wonders for the health of the whole organism.

Cleansing emotionally always means expression of some type (which does not necessarily involve interaction with others). Many women do this unconsciously because the normal controls fail to operate when they are menstruating. Those who do not may be more likely to break down after childbirth or at menopause (or at other times of change and stress), when the lid can no longer be kept on the accumulated tensions of the years.

The connection between the womb and strong outbursts of emotion has long been known. The root of our word *hysteria* is the Greek *hysteria*, meaning "womb." Becoming conscious of the role of menstruation in opening us to the expression of emotion allows us to respect the process and work with it, rather than deny it and then have the feelings erupt violently and painfully in ways that can be damaging to ourselves and to our relationships.

I have found that my menstrual symptoms have abated considerably since I started paying attention to my menstrual cycle. I still occasionally get cramps, but nothing like the crippling, debilitating pain that I used to get. I never take a pain-killer. Lying down with a hot water-bottle and entering a relaxed and meditative state of mind eases any discomfort, and it passes quickly. Likewise I still get some mild

premenstrual symptoms: a little water retention that I experience as slight breast tenderness, and a tendency to moodiness—depression and elation. This moodiness is actually a sign of the emotional richness of the premenstruum. One is alive to the full range of one's feeling life, and within that contact with the breadth and depth of the emotions is the potential for great creativity.

I find that any symptoms I do experience are a great source of insight into emotional issues that I need to pay attention to. During a time when I went through a good deal of emotional upheaval I found that my periods were a rich time for processing the different feelings that naturally arose during a time of instability and rapid change. Since then I have been learning to trust the process enough to allow these feelings their space when they come up, and during times of change and loss it is not unusual for me to have a spate of weeping at some point during the first day or two of my bleeding. Afterward I feel lightened, and I know that this emotional release is a part of the gift of the moon-time.

Change always brings loss as well as the excitement of the new. It is important to allow grief its place in one's life and not skate over it. Grief lays the mineral deposits in the psyche that we later mine—it is part of the foundation of our wisdom. Most people growing up in the Western world are trained to suppress grief—we have no useful rituals for the dead, no mourning period, no keening. We have tried to erase grief from our emotional repertoire and have substituted the expectation of happiness in its place as if to feel grief were somehow a failing and to always be happy were the goal of a well-spent life. But that type of happiness is merely bland. It is the so-called happiness of a TV dinner, a beige sofa, muzak piped into supermarkets. True happiness is a joy that wells up from inside the being and is only partly related to external events, and it cannot thrive unless all of its companions—grief and rage and disappointment—are allowed their

expression too. Allowing oneself a wide range of emotional expression is the way to be whole.

So women are lucky in this regard, because their period opens them up to their emotional life and makes it harder for them to suppress their feelings. It is the attempt to override this natural mechanism that creates so much disharmony at menstruation and that lies behind many of the symptoms that women endure.

PMS and Individuation

It is interesting that the symptoms of PMS are most severe in women in their thirties and forties.⁹ There are many possible explanations for this. An intriguing possibility is its relationship to individuation. The process of individuation gets going in most people in their thirties and forties, after they have learned to survive in the primary culture. Their psychic energy is then freed up to develop a true individuality. If there is not enough opportunity for this, then the symptoms of “mid-life crisis” may emerge, and one of the ways this manifests is in a desire to get away from the confines of everyday life.

This is not dissimilar to the panic and anxiety and overwhelming feelings of PMS. It may be that PMS is a way of allowing a woman to have her individual time for inner work and self-exploration. It may also be a signal from her body-mind that it requires some attention that it is not getting in the busy round of daily life.

MENSTRUATION AND BODY AWARENESS

Menstrual pain has several functions—one of the most obvious is that it shifts our attention to our bodies. It increases our experience of our

bodies and awakens the ability to be aware of the different parts of the body and of bodily sensations. Body consciousness is an undervalued skill in this culture. We are trained in school to think and see and hear—but rarely are we encouraged to feel, with our emotions or our bodies.

As a culture we value stoicism and the overriding of the body. We have schedules, appointments, and timetables that are based on industrial efficiency rather than the moment-to-moment needs of the body. We wait until the end of the meeting to empty our bladders, until the end of the day to eat our main meal. We go to work when we have colds, when we have menstrual cramps, when we have headaches. “Not feeling like it” is seen as a pretty lame excuse.

One of the skills of being a woman lies in being very aware of moment-to-moment bodily needs. Being deeply in touch with her body enables a woman to best nurture her unborn and nursing children. A woman needs to be able to know, and to say, “I need this type of food Now,” “I need to rest Now,” “I need to drink Now.”

The cyclical physiology of women means that their nutritional and rest requirements fluctuate during the month far more than a man’s in the equivalent time period. She cannot establish a norm and stick to it come what may. She is a cyclical being, with an ebb and flow of energy.

Getting in touch with that rhythm and finding ways to honor it is a challenge in today’s world. Menstrual symptoms pull us back in touch with ourselves. When we have cramps we can’t ignore the fact that we are menstruating, and when the pain is really bad it’s hard to focus on anything other than the body part that is screaming.

This might sound a bit odd, but this is actually another of the benefits of menstruation. Menstrual symptoms, especially pain, encourage body consciousness by forcing one to experience physical sensations. Women in later life frequently have an easier time than

men in coping with their bodies, with illness, aging, and pain. One of the reasons may be that they have more of a relationship with their bodies—they are forced into their bodies by the experience of menstruation and child-bearing. So when their bodies begin to change through the aging process, they are more in touch and psychologically more accustomed to the fact that bodies change. In many tribes, for example among the Aborigines of Australia, puberty rituals for boys focus on the endurance of pain, whereas this is not considered necessary for girls because nature itself initiates them into their bodies, the experience of physical pain, and the mysteries of life.

There is a connection between body awareness and intuition. We talk of having “gut feelings” that give us intuitive information. We say, “I knew it wouldn’t work, it just didn’t *feel* right.” Being in touch with our bodies gives us the opportunity to access information that is nonrational—things that we ordinarily couldn’t have known.

MENSTRUAL PAIN

Menstrual cramping is often idiopathic—that is, arising from no known organic dysfunction. It is simply a part of menstruation and, in Western medical opinion, doesn’t mean that there is anything wrong with the woman. Most women have experienced menstrual pain and many have it every month.

In Chinese medicine, menstrual cramps are seen as always being indicative of an imbalance that could be corrected by changes in lifestyle and diet, and/or by taking herbs and having acupuncture. Catching cold is seen as a particular danger for the womb, and that is one of the reasons why heat is often relieving for cramps. The Chinese also recognize that emotional difficulties can give rise to menstrual cramps. Western medicine does not differentiate menstrual pain to this

extent and generally prescribes pain-killers only, unless symptoms are severe. Psychologists have begun to develop ways of using psychotherapy to cure body symptoms such as cramps.¹⁰ Bodywork, such as massage, can also be very helpful during an attack, and certain yoga poses are also very effective.

During one menstrual period, I had a lot of pain for several hours in the middle of the first night of bleeding. I knew it wasn't caused by a physical problem. When I let go of hating it and wishing it would go away and of giving myself a hard time for having it in the first place (and feeling guilty because I'm supposed to be so tuned in to my periods now that it's all bliss and certainly not painful . . . ha!), I realized that it was pain, that I hurt, and that relief came when I consciously picked up on the feeling of hurt and began to wail and moan. I let all the times when I had felt hurt emotionally in recent weeks come up, and I expressed the hurt by yelling and moaning in my bed. I began to feel better and after acknowledging to myself what it was that I was hurt about and telling myself that it was okay for me to be sensitive and have feelings, I fell asleep.

My period demands emotional honesty and clarity from me. This includes clearing up the last month's emotional difficulties. We always have relationship issues in our lives, and there are always instances occurring when we are hurt or slighted in some way. Sometimes these are well within the bounds that we can handle and our resiliency prevents wounds from going deep. But there are times when we do feel vulnerable. Usually we protect ourselves from this by deciding that it doesn't really matter, we don't care anyway, and it's no good going through life being so sensitive.

But the point is that there is a part of us that does care, that cares very deeply about our own pain and the pain of others. And if we block off from our own pain then ultimately we block off from the pain of others.

One of the reasons menstrual pain arises is to put us in touch with our feelings of being hurt, and by really expressing it we can release it by acknowledging it. Life is a process of gaining self-knowledge. Symptoms arise to give us information. If you don't express your pain verbally or in some other conscious and creative way then it may be expressed unconsciously through the body as pain. Menstruation is a wonderful opportunity for women to process hurt feelings, rage, and frustration.

Menstrual pain can be really awful. As with labor pains, it is obscuring reality to imagine that it doesn't really hurt; sometimes, for some women, the pain that comes with menstruation has an excruciating and seemingly unbearable intensity.

There is a similarity between the pain of labor and the pain of menstruation—both are caused by uterine contractions (unless there is a physical problem causing the menstrual pain, such as endometriosis). When a woman menstruates she is laboring to give birth to herself. Menstruation is the rebirth of the woman; it occurs instead of the onset of pregnancy and means that she is free, for the next month at least, of sharing her body with another—free of the responsibility of motherhood and the weight (literally) of the unborn child.

PHYSICAL RENEWAL

Many women, when left to their own devices, report that they like to take it easy on the first day or two of their periods.¹¹ The natural inclination to rest and be still during menstruation is an opportunity for physical renewal. Physically, bleeding is a form of elimination and is therefore a cleansing for the body. Through cleansing and retreat the woman becomes revitalized. The debilitating symptoms that arise at the time of menstruation might in some cases be a message from the

body to *stop!* Lie down and rest and listen to the body wisdom that is trying to come through you. Let your body take this natural break in the month to rest and rebuild. We need to relearn the ancient knowledge that menstruation is an important juncture in the month. It is a built-in time for rest, retreat, and renewal.

Often our long-term, deep healing comes through the very simple—more rest, more love, doing the work we love—going back to basics. It is this level of healing that I address in this book. What have I found out about the healing of the womb? That women want to be alone, to be quiet and undisturbed, to rest and retreat for at least a few hours while they are bleeding and often for a day or two before the bleeding starts. That's all—it is really very simple. We need to be supported in following the wisdom of the body, which slows down and beckons us to focus internally during the bleeding time. We need not to work, not to relate, not to be under any pressure to be anything other than ourselves. We need to allow the natural wisdom and creativity to emerge in this quiet space in the month, to emerge in its own time, in its own way. The wisdom of women is linked to the womb and the power of the womb is the power of cycles and of gestation. Allowing time, allowing emptiness, allowing not-doing—these are all keys to health for women.

It's very healthy to shed a skin—it allows the detritus of the past to be sloughed off, and then the new, clean smooth skin shows up on the surface and we are renewed. The blood that was a part of us is now gone, leaving the womb cleaned out and ready for the next month. This cycle is beneficial to our overall health. A friend of mine once said that he always thought that women lived longer than men because they menstruate, and some tribes share this belief.

Developing a love for and a connection with the power of menstruation also means developing a love for and connection with the process. It won't work if the relationship you have with your bleeding

is a theoretical one. It has to be actualized in terms of behavior in order for the power to begin manifesting in a positive way. The power backfires on us if we don't honor our bleeding and develop a conscious relationship with it, if we don't pick up the messages our bodies send us. Cultivating a loving attitude toward your whole cycle is very important—this attitude is the metaskill behind menstruating with awareness.

At times, and especially at the beginning, negative feelings will surface and want to be expressed. Don't hold back on them. You may need to scream with rage at the inconvenience of it, at the messiness, at the pain. But keep behind that an attitude of loving yourself, loving your body, loving the reality of being female, and gradually the balance will begin to shift. It is fundamental in developing the skills of being a woman to *trust the process* that is inherent within us and that has been denied us because we have been indoctrinated into a male reality.

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THE SABBATH OF WOMEN

Women give, and in order to give they have to take in. They do this by first emptying and cleansing, and then renewing their connection to the source. This is the function of menstruation.

About three years after I began taking menstruation seriously and changing my behavior during my periods (which coincided with a time of emotional upheaval, spiritual searching, psychological work, and shamanic practice), I had an experience that gave me some crucial information about the nature of menstrual traditions in ancient matri-focal societies.

It was part of a transformation of my life that had begun a year earlier with a letting go of virtually everything I owned and connected with, including my career, my home, and my country of origin. I felt driven by some huge force to clear myself of everything that contributed to my conditioned view of life and of myself.

I then entered a period of bliss. I was in love with everyone and everything and experienced life as an ever-opening kaleidoscope of magic and beauty. I had many wonderful experiences of being at-one with everything, of merging with my lover totally, of experiencing the universe as pure love.

After six months of this I entered the territory of the shadow—I became very sick while traveling in Nepal, and along with the illness came a descent into a deep depression. I was physically blasted by the illness and stayed in bed at first and then chiefly indoors and in a safe place for several months. I was beset by intense and uncontrollable fear and shaken to the core by the whole experience. Several times I completely lost faith in the flow of my life and in my spiritual connection. I felt abandoned and close to destroyed—and by what? I hadn't a clue. The ideas that I was holding onto about who I was and was not were preventing me from really being myself. I knew that I wanted to write, that it was vitally important for me to allow my creativity to have expression, but I lacked confidence, and was fighting demons of self-criticism and distrust.

The recovery period was slow. When feeling optimistic I perceived the illness as a major purification, and it felt as if my body had been rewired in order to handle a new frequency of energy. When feeling that I would never fully recover (my energy level was unpredictable for a year after the initial onslaught), I worried that my nervous system had been permanently damaged and feared for the health of my heart, which raced at the slightest opportunity.

While I was putting myself back together, feeling like a newborn puppy on wobbly legs and gradually finding that I could cope with the world again, I had, out of the blue, the strongest experience of the whole transformation period.

I awoke at about 4 A.M. from a dream that propelled me into a series of experiences of a woman named Hathor living in Ancient

Egypt. I was used to having past-life experiences, but this had a different quality. It was as if I was allowed to enter Hathor's reality and as if she and I were (and are) intimately and intricately and eternally connected, although we are also clearly different people. She is startlingly alive to me, and as a result of "feeling" her, I no longer experience time in only a linear framework.

Hathor lived (or lives) at a time when patriarchal ideas were just beginning, a time when the Goddess was still revered, a time when women had their own temples and their own rituals, a time when women's wisdom was respected and encouraged.

I was astonished by the experience of making this connection with her but also settled by it. I began to calm down, to have a sense of my direction, and, at last, to take my writing seriously. I began a dialogue with her that I usually wrote down as it came through, and one day, several months later, I asked her what the women of her time did when they menstruated.

When a woman felt her time coming, she would bake food for the family, put some in a bag for herself, and then walk up to the moon house. This house was outside the town on the top of a hillside that had on one side been eroded into a cliff by the river. The house overlooked the town to the north, the river to the east, and the gentle slope of the hills to the west, and then the desert beyond and behind, on the far side of the fertile plain.

During the walk up the hillside the woman would begin to let go of her attachment to her family and her life and its obligations down in the town. She would already be entering the dreaminess of her moon-time when she arrived at the top of the hill and walked down the path through the simple garden. She was greeted by the housekeeper, an older woman

past menstruating age who kept the hearth of the house. She would give the housekeeper a small amount of money and go inside and take a bed in the dormitory.

She would speak quiet words of greeting to the other women, but this was not a time for gossip or chat, or even serious talk. This was a time to go inside, to be alone, even when amidst others. Occasionally, when a woman felt particularly moved to seek the wisdom within, or in need of great cleansing, she would go off alone into the desert for her moon.

The moon house was very simple. One large room full of beds, a shrine room for contemplation, and a platform overlooking the river on which they ate the simple meals they had brought with them. From the bedroom the windows faced east and had beautiful views of the river and of the mountains beyond. There were no windows to the north and west and therefore no view of the town or the fields. The walls were built of a light-colored stone, and the beds were spaced well apart from each other. The shrine room was dark, in the center of the house, and in it was a statue of Isis and black cushions on which to comfortably sit.

The atmosphere in the house was restful, peaceful, uncluttered. A place to let go. Often women would be heard weeping to themselves, or some other release. This was accepted as part of the moon and was not interfered with in any way by the other women. If a woman became particularly distressed she could go to the housekeeper, but it was taboo to disturb others. Each respected the others' going inside, a time when women had no responsibility to care for others—the necessary balance to the role of care giver.

THE SABBATH OF WOMEN

Six months later, while meditating on the first day of my period, I found myself in a deep trance in which I received the following advice, entitled "Guidelines for Menstruating Women":

Stay still inside and let the blood flow out.

See your womb as an opening flower, full of fierce pink light, sending out a special sweet rosy energy into the world, which cleans and nourishes.

Let the beauty blood spill onto the earth.

Trust the wisdom of the body's cycle. Honor it. Go with what your body wants to do.

Take gentle peaceful exercise in quiet places. Listen to slow flowing water, the tinkle of a fountain in a stone-flagged square.

Take a slow look and a slow movement. Turn your head gently. Stroke yourself. Let all your movements be soft and serene.

Speak with gentleness. No fights.

Eat simple food: grains and vegetables and broth. Nothing too rich or sweet or milky.

Drink pure water, savoring the taste and clearness.

Go inside, deep inside, and allow any murkiness to be seen and to flow out. A time of clearing out and of taking in.

Be alert to information for the coming month.

Relax. Be soft. Slow down.

Open your womb, your thighs, your knees, your ankles, your toes. Open your heart. By opening, let go, let the blood flow.

This advice profoundly affected me and sent me deeper into my experience of the menstrual mysteries. I found that following these

guidelines took me into my center and put me in touch with a well-spring of wisdom and knowledge. This affirmation of the concept that menstruation is a time of power gave me the confidence to question more intently our contemporary attitudes, not only to menstruation, but to cycles in general.

Feeling this new sense of personal power and wholeness set me thinking about the nature of late twentieth-century life and how difficult it is for us to live in such a centered and healing way, how hard it is for us to honor the natural cycles of our bodies, and just how far we have gone from the wisdom of these ancient voices.

MENSTRUATION AS SABBATH

The ancient Babylonian word for Sabbath, *sabbatu*, comes from *Sabat*, and means heart-rest. In Babylon it was a day of rest, when the goddess Ishtar was said to be menstruating. Travel, work, and eating cooked food were prohibited for everyone on this day—as they were for menstruating women in many cultures.¹ Cuneiform tablets of the fourth dynasty of Ur, dating from the third millennium B.C.E., tell us that in Sumer the times of the new moon and the full moon were devoted to ritual observance. Likewise, the Jewish sabbath originally occurred at the new moon and full moon; it was later extended to each quarter of the moon.² These far-distant days of rest, linked to the moon and to menstruation, were the origin of the modern Jewish sabbath and Christian Sunday.

These days few people take even one day a month to really rest. In general, Euro-Western culture is obsessed with the Doing mode of living. We only value ourselves if we are doing something, and we think that people who don't do very much are less valid members of society. We are oriented toward productivity and the accumulation of

wealth and possessions rather than toward the accumulation of wisdom, spiritual strength, and self-knowledge.

This continual doing does not lead to happiness or well-being, and we all know the relief of being on holiday and not having to Do anything. Now, obviously, it would be unbalancing in the other direction if we all laid down our tools and decided to just Be, but maybe we could use a little bit more stillness and unpressured hanging-out times in our lives, and I don't mean sitting in front of the television watching people kill each other and cheat on their spouses. I'm thinking more of sitting in front of a tree, or a lake, or the sea, and just Being.

There was a good deal of value in the old idea of the Sabbath—empty time with no labor, devoted to prayer and contemplation. As the industrial age built up steam, powered by the Protestant work ethic, the Sabbath fell out of favor and the old taboos against working on one day of the week disappeared. This can only be adding to the stress and pressure of modern life. Our bodies and our minds need to take time out, they need a periodic rest, and our spirits need to be nurtured—they need some time devoted purely to the spiritual life. The lack of Sabbath may be why so many people get colds and flu—that is the only way they can have a Sabbath, a rest from continual Doing.

In many parts of America, the only way you can tell it's Sunday is that the beaches are more crowded, the Sunday paper is on sale, and there is less traffic in the downtown areas. Other than that, everything is the same. All the shops are open, and most services are available. And the television never sleeps.

If you are always racing about, doing this and that, always running behind yourself, when do you have time to really feel your feelings? When do you have time to reflect upon why you reacted so strongly when a colleague said he hated animals in the house, why your husband

is annoying you so much at the moment, why you hate wearing red, why the thought of your mother coming over for lunch fills you with dread. You might have quick ideas about what these things mean, you may just push them aside and keep running, but you won't understand them and heal the difficulties in your life if you don't have some quiet time.

A woman's moon-time is the obvious time in her cycle to take a break from Doing and to just sit and be, to sit and bleed. It is a natural time for opening to the spiritual realms, and for doing the work of knowing and understanding the self that can only happen in empty, still, quiet time.

In the Jewish tradition, the first day of each month (which would have been the day of the new moon before we went to the solar calendar, traditionally the time of menstruation) is a women's holiday, called Rosh Chodesh (head of the month). This holiday is being reclaimed by some Jewish women. This was a ritualized acceptance of the desire of women to have a break when they are bleeding.

Peaceful time is very useful for relationship problems, and sitting quietly for a few hours can do wonders for restoring perspective. Many squabbles and fights arise from our over-stimulated adrenal glands, which are for many people continually fired up on all cylinders, fighting through the traffic to get to work, dealing with work pressures and deadlines, coping with a family as well as a job—and then the television is on all evening screaming away at you, and there is No Peace.

We have become so used to this pressurized existence in the Euro-Western world that many people have forgotten how to sit still. It seems boring because we have grown accustomed to continual external stimulus. But there is an inner life as well as an outer life, and that inner life, the life of the psyche, is very precious and is the well-spring of our creativity, of our gift to the world. Ultimately we may

not give anything of great value without nurturing this inner life. And it needs quiet time to grow and develop.

We can relearn how to be in the rhythm of stillness again—we knew how to once, when we were babies and small children and went from bursts of rapid activity to moments of stillness and sleep and then back into activity again. We need to give ourselves time: time to absorb change, time to let ourselves take in everything around us—not taking life as a whistle-stop tour in which we have to grab as much as we can before we are thrown off the train. We have to give ourselves time to get in touch with stillness again, by practicing sitting still. Many people have the experience of going on holiday and not knowing what to do with themselves for the first few days with all that open and unstructured time. And then after three or four days they remember how to just be, and by the time they are really loving it it's time to come home again. If we had more time like this in the regular routine, perhaps life would become less of a pressure and more of a pleasure.

By taking menstruation as the natural time for stillness and quiet in a woman's life we can begin to relearn the rhythm of sitting in peace with ourselves, and then we can begin to reap the benefits of a closer relationship with our inner beings.

Menstruation can be a deeply grounding and centering time in which a woman is naturally put directly in touch with her center of gravity—her womb. Thus there is actually a greater capacity for stillness at this time—for listening, for receiving from the cosmos. The awareness that is available to us during menstruation cannot come into our consciousness if we are rushing about fulfilling the exterior demands of our everyday lives.

Sitting still and being centered are prerequisites in all spiritual traditions for the development of wisdom. Menstruation is a natural time for women to meditate and make contact with the divine, within and

without. When the body is still the mind also becomes still and then the spiritual wisdom that exists at a deeper level of consciousness is free to come to the surface of awareness.

*FINDING OUT WHO YOU REALLY ARE
AND WHAT YOU REALLY WANT*

Menstruation is a door into oneself. Traditionally, girls entering puberty knew to watch for a vision of their future when they had their first period. It was recognized that menarche is a door into adulthood, where visions of one's life are available so that correct choices can be made in order to follow one's heart's desire and fulfill one's destiny and deepest dream. Likewise, the monthly bleeding is a doorway into the forthcoming month, and sometimes, when the energy is very strong, into a longer period of one's life.

By tuning in to yourself during bleeding and allowing for the existence of this gateway, you allow information in the psyche to emerge into consciousness—information about what you truly want and need. This is so valuable, and yet it is an ability of ours that we tend to dismiss. We go to career counselors and psychotherapists for the very information that we alone possess. A skilled helper will work to enable you to unravel the knotted skein of desire within you—but it is also possible to do this alone by connecting with your body rhythms in a deep way.

When you have your period, if you allow yourself some quiet time, you will find that ideas and knowledge and information will begin to come to you. It will usually come in the form of a knowing, that can slip away if not caught and held onto. Watch out in the early morning when you first wake up. There is often juicy information

around then. Keep paper and a pen next to your bed to jot ideas down.

You may also find that you begin to get information about other people coming in. My experience has been that in opening up to the menstrual mysteries, I have also opened up to an ability to be intuitive in a way that appears to take me into a group mind—a place where information about anyone and anything is available to anyone with the psychic awareness to pick it up. This is close to, and maybe the same as, what is today called channeling.

From what I have read about cultures in which the time of menstruation was regarded as a time of power for women, I suspect that women have a particularly strong capacity to enter this level of universal information. Either this capacity is strongest during menstruation, or menstruation is the best time to develop this awareness, perhaps because then the body and mind are relatively still. It may be that anyone who enters contemplative mode long enough would begin to manifest this ability to “channel,” and that it is simply because menstruation offers such a perfect opportunity to be still and within that it produces this effect. However, there is such a dominant archetype of the medium as female in today’s culture, that for now, at any rate, it appears that mediumistic abilities are more the domain of women than of men.

THE DEVELOPMENT OF WISDOM IN WOMEN

A woman who uses her time of bleeding to develop her inner life, and therefore her self-knowledge, begins, over time, to become wise. Life is a teacher of wisdom, and it is life experienced with awareness that creates wisdom in the elderly. But children can also be wise. I think

there is a level of awareness that is available to all humans that is simply wise, and I believe one can foster an ability to enter that level. One of the keys to this seems to be to really know oneself in the moment, and to act without inhibition—this is why children are more open to wisdom than most adults. We develop inhibitions for many reasons, some of them good ones.

Living is, in part, a quest to understand how to be oneself, a truly differentiated individual, within a society that demands certain inhibitions in order to maintain harmony in the whole. Navigating through this terrain of personal desire versus collective demand is the task of the adult, and the ideal is for the mature years to be an expression of all that is best about both: to be a developed individual—to “know thyself”—and at the same time to be a worthy citizen of the world who is able to give wisdom and knowledge back into the soup of the collective.

MENOPAUSE AND THE ARCHETYPE OF THE CRONE

In later life the urgency of fulfilling personal desire decreases. For men and women, changes in hormones and the completion of certain life tasks, such as raising a family and becoming established in the world, allow the desire nature to subside. Without the monthly surge and wane in hormones a woman’s sexual longing and desire to reproduce calm down, and the desire mechanism in general becomes less strident. As a society we need post-menopausal women whose main attention is no longer focused on getting what they want but has moved on toward giving the accumulated wisdom of the years back to the world.

The Celts said that a post-menopausal woman was wise because she now kept the precious blood within her—I speculate that a post-menopausal woman is wise because she has menstruated for thirty or forty years, and during that time she was a gatherer of wisdom. Now, having gathered it in, she sits on it and lets it build, fortified by the experience of her lifetime. A lifetime of garnering wisdom every month leads to a wise old age. The perpetual round of the menstrual cycle tunes a woman in to the pulse of the earth and the rays of the moon. It gives her the knowing, in her body, of the cyclical nature of all life. Now that women can realistically expect to live for at least twenty to thirty years past menopause, as a culture we have a potentially vast resource of wise women, if we would only use it.

The current obsession with staving off menopause through the use of hormone replacement therapy misses the point that there is an inherent value in ceasing to menstruate. I wonder if women need to prolong their menstrual experience because they never really had it—because they spent their periods pretending that nothing was happening. Perhaps the desire to continue to bleed is actually an unconscious attempt to complete that part of life.

Menopausal women speak of their sense of loss of a cycle never properly lived. Their periods end and then they realize, too late, what a gift was held in their monthly bleeding. As with any grief, it is the unacknowledged and unlived aspect that is often the most painful. When someone dies with whom you have a lot of unresolved or unexpressed feelings, things you wanted to say but didn't, love or anger never clearly expressed, there is often a very deep pain. Likewise with menstruation—it is the unacknowledged part of it that causes the most painful aspect of the grief of menopause. If you have given yourself time to enjoy bleeding and to reap the benefits of conscious menstruation, then the menopause becomes more a welcomed passage

than the loss of a womanhood you never really had. This is, in part, why women crave their youthfulness in contemporary Euro-Western culture and why they spend billions of dollars to avoid looking like who they really are—post-menopausal women.

The other and perhaps stronger reason for this, is that the crone is not valued in Euro-Western society. In traditional Breton weddings the three phases of the bride's life were celebrated—she was impersonated first by a little girl, then by the mistress of the home, *and* by an old grandmother. In modern weddings we still have the flower girl or bridesmaid, and the matron-of-honor, but the crone figure is no longer present.³

We see the maiden everywhere—she is the archetype of female splendor paraded across magazines and movie screens. The mother has some value and is even, in a limited aspect, revered in contemporary religion. But the crone appears nowhere. She is the hidden archetype of this culture, all her power hidden in the underbelly of our lives. A culture that reveres youth over the wisdom of age is an immature culture, and it is therefore no wonder that our supposedly civilized society is not in the least bit mature, but is in fact riddled with addictions, with the widespread misuse of resources, and with endemic violence toward women and children.

ALTERED STATES OF CONSCIOUSNESS

For women involved in spiritual practice and creative work, menstruation gives an opportunity for increased access to nonordinary states of awareness. Many women experience difficulty in thinking in a focused way during or just before their periods (as they also do after giving birth, often for several months). The energy that is usually

available for focused thought is diverted into other areas, and the woman experiences a more diffuse state of awareness.

This is the state in which creative insights can sneak in, when lateral thinking is easiest, when we can let go of our accustomed perceptions and attitudes. Input from other dimensions is more readily available. Activities of a visionary and intuitive nature have added energy and possibility at this time—dreaming, receiving information about the coming month, gaining awareness of psychological patterns, receiving teachings from spiritual guides, experiencing psychic connections with others. I have had many experiences of prophetic dreams during menstruation. I have found that the last couple of days of my period tend to be the strongest for precognition. It seems that the premenstruum and the first couple of days are mainly occupied with cleansing and processing, and then the way is open to receive wisdom and insight. Just as at menarche girls seek visions for their adult lives, so one can look for information about the coming month during one's period.

Monica Sjöö says that "shamanism, an ecstatic lunar technology, relies on the natural psychic descent into body-consciousness that menstruation brings each month to women."⁴ The descent of the shaman is so similar to the monthly descent of the woman into herself, that it seems likely that the moon-time is a natural opportunity to do shamanic practices and seek altered states of consciousness. "At menstruation, when the body passes its blood-food, a woman often feels an ingathering of her energy and feelings to a deeper center below the threshold of consciousness."⁵ The shamanic journey may have its origins in the psychic journeys of menstruating women; Alaskan and Siberian shamans talk of going to the moon.

The death and rebirth motif of menstruation parallels shamanic experience. The feeling of death at the onset of menstruation; the

sense, particularly during the premenstruum, of going down into the mire and the darkness of oneself—this descent is an essential part of shamanic transformation. The shaman descends, faces death, and through courage and determination, returns to his or her people with special gifts of healing and wisdom.

The fear of death in our nonspiritual culture is linked to the denial of menstruation. In pre-industrial society women menstruated together around the time of the new moon. Moon-dark is a two-day period of time before the new moon when there is no moonlight at all. Before we see the light of the new moon we experience a temporary death, a darkness. Menstruation coincides with this—it marks the death of a potential life. It is a release of the layers built up during the month, the layers of physical blood, and also the psychic debris and emotional clutter of the previous four weeks.

Like the shaman, the menstruating woman has been seen as somehow mysteriously closer to the sacred aspect of nature than other human beings. In the Indian cult of Shakti-worshippers the yoni and its red flow are prized and adored. "In Shaktism the menstrual taboo is broken down and the menstrual fluid is regarded as sacred and becomes the object of veneration. A menstruating woman is placed in a special category during ritual practice. Her energy at this time is said to be different in quality, and the rhythm that occurs in her body appears to be related in a mysterious way to the processes of nature. . . . The monthly efflorescence of woman in her cycle in rhythm with the lunar cycle creates a body consciousness which is related to the processes of the universe."⁶

Imagine how it would be if we were raised to think of our blood as divine, as magical, as precious. Experiencing the beauty and intense spirituality of bleeding can dramatically change a woman's relationship with herself. While meditating during my period I have seen my

womb as a golden chalice spilling forth a constant stream of white light, intermingled with the red blood of life. Visions such as this can have the effect of permanently altering and healing the negative images of the female that we have been fed—this heals us, body and soul, from the wounds of ignorance and misogyny.

PART THREE

WAKING UP
TO THE
POWER

*The Stories
of Three Women*

During the winter of 1990–1991 I interviewed three women who have had strong experiences with menstruation. In the following chapters they tell their stories.

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THE SCIENTIST WENDY ALTER

Wendy Alter was only thirty-four when she found a lump in her breast. It was cancer. Since graduating from college she had been a high-flyer with NASA—literally. Her ambition was to become an astronaut. As a chemist she had been exposed to toxic chemicals frequently during her adult life. But exposure to toxicity was only one of the causes that Wendy suspected had laid her open to cancer—another, equally insidious one, was her relationship to her femaleness.

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I started in a research position at NASA and gradually got more responsibility until I was managing large projects. I was in a very masculine-dominated world and had been ever since I could remember. In engineering classes there were very few women. I got an undergraduate degree in chemistry, and then I went back to school and

studied electrical engineering and computer science. After school, I went to work for NASA, and when I'd been there for a few years I started doing graduate work in materials engineering. I was always around men. In my younger years I wished that I were a man. I hated being female; I hated it; I hated it.

My mother was a very, very confident woman who didn't want to be at home, didn't want to have anything to do with housework and children. She was professionally successful but she was of a generation where that wasn't quite respected and—well, she was respected, but people weren't quite sure if it was all right. She was a supervisor nurse, very successful in her work.

When I was a child I spent a lot more time with my father than I did with my mother. He spent a lot of time explaining things to me—he was very mechanically inclined and that was fun for me, and I think that's why I eventually ended up in engineering. I had a younger sister, and I have an older brother who is autistic.

When I reached my teens and I started to become noticeably female, my father stopped having anything to do with me, and this was painful for me. He started giving me some strange messages that boys don't like girls who are too successful and win races and things like that; it was a really painful, traumatic time. I was having my periods and I had terrible dysmenorrhea. My mother and sister had it too. I had very heavy flow, practically a hemorrhage, to the point where I would throw up—too much of a flow to wear a pad. It was terrible. And it was embarrassing because the school system completely denied that sort of thing—you were allowed to go and lie down at the nurse's station for one class period only, and other than that they just had no tolerance. I remember one time my sister had to be carried out by two guys, just as white as a sheet—and yet no one could talk about it.

It still annoys me that this is not a subject that can be discussed in mixed company, and often not among women either. When your

friend gets a cold, you usually get the whole story of how it developed and every minute of it, but when you're having your period, even if you're having terrible cramps, you have to pretend that everything's normal because you can't let anyone know. It's shameful to have your period. We all have a million stories about embarrassing incidents or mortifying experiences. And of course the doctors at that time all took the position that the shame was a psychosomatic problem caused by the fact that a female didn't feel good about being a female—that was the explanation that was given to me, and it was hard to refute because indeed I didn't feel good about being a woman. When I got old enough to talk back, I started asking these doctors if it had ever occurred to them that maybe they had the cause and effect the wrong way round—if you had to go through that much pain every single month because of your gender wouldn't you come to resent your gender? It seems to me that their explanation was really weak.

I was so resentful when I was young, really resentful, because I was unusually intelligent and that was problematic, as a female. Advisers were always telling me that I should become a librarian or a teacher. I really resented that. I did have a lot of dates and boyfriends, but I resented that things seemed to be easy for them. But at that time, I was an early feminist. I'm 38 now. My understanding of feminism was kind of wacky because what I wanted was the right to be treated like a man.

I had to come to the realization that there is something inherently valuable in the female by going all the way into the masculine, and I did that successfully. I had to prove to myself and to everyone around me that I could do it. And I was very successful, but I became aware that there was something seriously wrong. The working schedule is not natural—the idea that you work for the same amount of hours all the time, and you're supposed to be equally productive all the time, and you schedule your vacation three months in advance. It was so cut off from the real world.

My periods were a real bane to me when I was working. They were very, very irregular for many years and it seemed that my body had a mind of its own. It seemed to be trying to sabotage me; my periods would come early or late so that they happened during some major event. For example, I got to participate in NASA's weightless program—weightlessness by freefall in an aircraft. This was something I really wanted to do because I wanted to be an astronaut and this was a big step in the right direction. I was very ambitious from a young age. But the physiological training you take through the air force is very physically demanding. I had to go through the altitude chamber, where they pump out the atmosphere so I got to feel what it's like to be at twenty-six thousand feet without air, and they also put me through an explosive decompression. And of course, my period came during the training session. I was worried about whether it would have an adverse effect on me—to be menstruating at twenty-six thousand feet. But I didn't ask anyone about it; I just went ahead with the exercise.

There was one older woman that I had sort of latched onto as a mentor—she was a very male-identified woman also. I mentioned to her that I had my period, and she laughed and said that the same thing had happened to her and indicated that she had had some fears about what might happen going in and being depressurized. She hadn't said anything to anyone either.

Then I had my period again the very first time I flew a zero gravity mission. When I have my period I become a little bit faint and light-headed—you know, things change—so to be in a very physically demanding situation like that and to have my period was awful. And every time, it was guaranteed to coincide with a physically demanding event. But my attitude was that it was essential never to let on to anybody that there would be anything wrong with me and to go on, to be able to give a peak performance.

The years went by and I just started to feel kind of dead. The more successful I became, the more out of touch I felt. I felt like I was living a two-dimensional life somehow, as if I was some kind of cartoon character. Nothing seemed real any more. But it was really difficult to tear myself away because I had a big salary and everyone thought I was great and I was winning awards. But I wasn't happy. I became more and more unhappy and I couldn't even talk to anyone about it—what did I have to be unhappy about? It was a difficult time.

I had very few female friends. I worked around men. I got married during that time and we had a role-reversal marriage. My husband didn't work, he stayed home and he did all the cooking and shopping and house cleaning. After a while I did make a good female friend, and one day in a conversation with her and another woman, they mentioned how much they enjoyed having their periods. I was flabbergasted. It was so far from anything I had imagined. It had never occurred to me that there could be anything enjoyable about menstruating. That got me thinking. These were two very unusual, very thoughtful women who had done a lot of inner work. I really respected them, and what they said caught my attention.

It took getting cancer to finally get me out of that situation. When I went through the ordeal with cancer I never even cried. In fact, when I received the diagnosis, my husband and I immediately went to the library and did a lot of research and found out everything there was to know and made decision trees. It was all very rational, and I had no feelings; I couldn't feel.

I was so used to not acknowledging feelings or giving them any attention or honoring them. All I could feel was this strange heaviness. That was the only way I could contact my feelings. I knew that wasn't helping, and I felt that it had to do with how I got cancer. There were plenty of other reasons too—I have a family history of breast cancer, and I had been working with carcinogenic substances for years.

The breast cancer was one of a series of illnesses I had that were all in my female organs—starting small and getting worse, I had cervical dysplasia a few months before the cancer was diagnosed. I had had a couple of surgeries for endometriosis a few years before. I finally sat down and said, “My body’s trying to get my attention.” It was as if I was trying to amputate anything of myself that was female.

I went ahead and did all the standard medical things that were recommended, even though I was pretty uncomfortable with it. I didn’t feel I was in a position to explore any other options at that point. I carried on with work. I was in Alabama; there was no alternative medicine there. And I didn’t know anything about alternative methods of treatment anyway. I had various people write to me and say drink wheatgrass juice or something like that, but at that point I wasn’t prepared to do something like that. So I had the traditional treatments, but I wasn’t entirely happy about it. I still suffer the side effects of the treatments. The chemotherapy is poison; you inject yourself with poison bad enough to kill the cancer but not quite bad enough to kill you. But your body knows, and when that poison goes in, you feel poisoned and you feel weak. I still don’t feel like I have my full strength back, and that’s not from the cancer, it’s from the treatment. Psychologically I had a very negative response to that treatment, and I know that attitude has a lot to do with one’s health. Anyway I did what I felt I had to do at the time, and then I left my job.

My husband and I moved back to Washington—his home state. I pretty much spent the first year in shock. I didn’t know what I was looking for; all I knew was that I wanted to get back in touch with my feelings. I started taking music lessons and art lessons. It was very difficult for me to do this. I started taking yoga; that was a revelation. I had no idea—I had completely underestimated what yoga was all about. I started to learn things about my body that I had never known.

My days now are very free of responsibilities. When we moved to Washington, my husband's desk-top publishing business was becoming successful, and we did a turn-about since he hadn't worked in Alabama. He works at home, which has been a thorn in my side because I like to have a lot of completely quiet alone time, especially when I have my period. I never get that because he's always there; even when he's in another room in the house it's not the same—I still feel compelled to think about him and what he's doing and whether it's time for lunch yet. He's really worked hard to let me do what I've needed to do, and this has been a struggle for him too, but we both recognize that it is really obvious that around the time of my period strange things happen, and he is just as happy to avoid me at that time. So it hasn't been hard at all to work into a routine whereby I keep him posted and he gives me a wide berth—respectfully—he's always very compassionate. It's difficult to spend as much time alone as I want though because he feels threatened and neglected by this—I need a lot more time alone than he does and it's hard for him to understand sometimes. I need to find a retreat. I really want to be alone, but I want to stay at home, I don't want to go away. At home I have the things around me that I need for my creativity—my books, my computer. I don't feel domestic, I don't think about cooking much when I have my period—I'm not very hungry then.

I still have a lot of trouble with cramps, and I have a medication that I take for it, but I've arrived at the point where I don't want to take it any more than I have to. I feel that I want to go ahead and have my period—even though there is pain associated with it. I don't want to just put chemicals into my body to deal with it. After the cancer treatments, I developed a real distaste for putting chemicals into my body, and I don't like the state that the pain medication puts me into.

I use that time as an excuse to do what I really want to do, which is usually just to go to bed. I love to read, so I take a stack of books, ideas that I'm working on, things that I want to mull over and sort of germinate. Our bedroom is in a tower room that has windows all around and we have a water bed, so it's really cozy. I just go up there and spend two days in bed and write and read.

At first I did it as an excuse—any excuse to read rather than to do chores around the house, which I hate, but it didn't take long at all for me to realize that as soon as I made a little room at that time amazing things were happening. I would just write prolifically and ideas would flood into my head, strong insights into things, and it would be a very positive experience. I realized that the negativity that I expressed sometimes was not inherent in having my period—it had to do with having to interact with people at that time. It was more annoyance at being taken away from what I really wanted to be doing rather than something inherent in the experience.

I decided about a year ago that I wanted to do a strict detoxification, and I went to a nutritionist who put me on a very strict diet. After a month or so I had my period and I was out of my pain medication. I thought oh no, I'll just have to dig in and wait this one out—but I never did get cramps that month. It was the first time I was really able to recognize that there is some kind of dietary factor. But that diet was so restricted that I was getting weak and losing a lot of weight. I was unhappy with it, so I decided to discontinue it.

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I suggested some other things she could try, such as thinking about eliminating toxins psychologically as well as physically. I suggested that perhaps her cramps are a strength that isn't being manifested. They might also be from pain that is not otherwise expressed, feelings of hurt that are being suppressed.

Cramps also have the function of making us focus on the womb—on our creative center. There may be a need for the uterus to express itself—through having children or through other forms of creativity. I told her to remember the need for patience in healing long-term abuse of the body. Wendy felt she had abused her body all through her life.

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My poor body has really borne the brunt of whatever I wanted to do. When I had the chemotherapy they warned me that there was a 50 percent chance of being thrown into a premature menopause, and at the time I was disappointed that this didn't happen—I would have been relieved. When I had endometriosis, I took a very powerful male hormone for a year during which I had no periods; it was wonderful in terms of my career. But I realize now that even though I still have estrogen in my body, which increases the risk of breast cancer, I am really glad I haven't stopped menstruating because I never would have come to learn what a positive experience it can be.

Yesterday, I was thinking about this and I thought, yes, I have estrogen just coursing through my body and medically speaking it's dangerous to me—I decided to reject that whole idea. How can it be dangerous to me? I thought about all the wonderful things that estrogen does for me and how good it feels, and at that moment I could feel it in my body. I ended up doing this spontaneous meditation of gratitude toward my estrogen. It was a very good feeling. And I think if I took the time to do this on a regular basis a lot of my problems would go away. The illnesses I have had might never have happened if I had respected my body.

Although NASA is a good equal opportunity employer, it is still run from a male perspective. There is a male way of making decisions, and it wasn't until I had been there for ten years that I finally realized

that I am different from these people. I can do that little logical thing that they do, but it doesn't feel right. There are some important things that they are leaving out.

There is another way of looking at and solving problems that's maybe more a female way. Take in a lot of information and then leave it alone—don't work on it, don't analyze it, don't try and draw a logical conclusion, but let it all ferment—and the answer will come on its own. That's what women have to offer, and I find, from my personal experience, that it's a far superior way of coming to conclusions.

If you use the analytical model, you can come to any conclusion you want, depending on what assumptions you choose to use, and that's one reason why so many bad decisions are made.

I have been really working on concepts of darkness and light—I had a dream and I woke up with this tremendous conviction that the light was suffocating the darkness, choking it off, and everything was terribly skewed and wrong because of that. This was a strange conclusion to come to, because in all the spiritual work I've been trying to do, light is always the good part. But I've come to realize that the darkness is equally good, and I wrote some things about the idea of the darkness; I think that is where the fermentation happens. There's a certain violence and strangeness that comes from this extreme worship of the light without any darkness to balance it.

This year more than ever before I've been struck by ideas that are incredibly exciting to me and have then come across other people having the same idea. Of course, this happens all the time in science—it's well documented—the same idea arises in different places simultaneously. Sometimes it comes in with such a force that it totally overwhelms me, some kind of outside force that takes over.

I have wanted to set up my life so that there are very few constraints on my time, so that when the inspiration comes I can be fully

available for it. Now I'm becoming interested in going back out into the world again. It will be a creative work in itself to find a way of working that isn't excessively scheduled; we are so obsessed with that in this culture. A few months ago I had to do something during my period that I had committed to, and I was miserable all the way through it. I was just so mad that I was there. My periods are regular now, so I plan in advance as much as I can. I have a chart and keep track so I can pretty well predict when it will come. And I suppose if it can schedule itself to come at inconvenient times, then there's no reason it shouldn't come at convenient times too.

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THE EDUCATOR TAMARA SLAYTON

Tamara Slayton is the woman behind the Menstrual Health Foundation, a nonprofit organization dedicated to providing education about the positive and powerful aspects of menstruation. I interviewed her at her home in Sebastopol, California, which then served as the headquarters for the MHF. (The MHF has since relocated to an office in downtown Sebastopol.) Her living room showed the evidence of her work—baskets overflowing with cloth menstrual pads in different sizes and colors ranging from white to pink floral to bright red; bulletin boards covered with organizational data for classes and workshops; books on menstruation and related subjects.

*As we talked it became clear that Tamara is a woman with a mission who has been thinking deeply about menstruation all her adult life. She first became aware of the deeper meaning of menstruation in 1974 when she was working with Jeannine Parvati Baker on the book *Hygiea—A Woman's Herbal*.*

She went on to establish the MHF in 1983, as it became increasingly clear to her that work in this area is vitally important.

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My mother is a hairdresser and has spent all her life around women, listening to women, counseling them, supporting them, being with them. So that was what I grew up with, that was my model of how women are in the world, and my mother really demonstrated the care of women. She didn't take care of herself in the process, and that's the part I have to undo, but she really was a model of a woman who listened to and cared deeply for other women.

I had a total lack of initiation into menstruation. I remember standing in the closet with my mother, and I had to be the adult because she was so embarrassed. I was scared but she was more so. After that came sexual activity that was totally unconscious, with no information, no support, and no one to talk to, resulting in pregnancy at the age of fifteen. I think that propelled me into working with women of all ages and helping them to become conscious. I was driven to do it because of the pain that was unintegrated. I've been working on integrating that pain, trying to find my son, who was adopted, and really getting conscious of what happened and of what I lost. My grandmother got pregnant when she was seventeen, and they whisked her out of the East to California. When I was fifteen and I got pregnant, my mother whisked me out of the town we were living in to another one, and so it was a secret thing.

When I was twenty-three I met Jeannine and began to become more conscious. It was toward the end of the back-to-the-earth hippie movement. I did a lot of primal therapy, tearing down ways of looking at things, and using psychedelics. There was a lot of breaking down to do. And I'm a survivor of sexual abuse, which is something

that I'm working through now. This shows up in my classes all the time; at least seven of the current class have been abused. It comes up as soon as we begin to look at issues related to caring for ourselves. It's very powerful work, and it's beautiful to watch someone reclaim her inner child, and see how that shows up premenstrually, how that vulnerability comes up very strongly. It's powerful to start working with it from that point, and using it as part of the overall recovery.

I first began to think of menstruation as something powerful after spending time with Jeannine and teaching classes on fertility awareness with her and really starting to develop a whole new concept of what it meant to cycle. For Jeannine it was a little bit like second nature, it wasn't that she studied—she just came in with some information about menstruation. I lived with her for three or four years in community, and we talked about menstruation regularly and shared our dreams and discussed what happened for us each cycle.

I started changing my thoughts and the ways I spoke about myself, particularly premenstrually, and then I started just observing. I became a witness, rather than judge or evaluator. I was very much into meditating, so I had developed that skill of watching. I also started teaching a class on fertility awareness at the local junior college, and in that class it became clear to me that most women did not like the fact that they bled, did not have a positive experience when they first started their menstruation, and were actually relieved when they got pregnant. I was trying to teach them about fertility awareness and how to choose pregnancy consciously, and in some ways they were opting for an unconscious pregnancy because it relieved them of many things, including menstruation. I began to see that there was something missing, and that if I was going to successfully teach fertility awareness I needed to include something about menstrual awareness.

The more I looked, the more I saw that the negativity is cultural. The entire culture is shame-based and dysfunctional regarding menstruation. Around that time toxic shock syndrome began appearing, and, realizing how dangerous tampons could be, I became inspired to make natural pads.

A friend and I started thinking about what really needed to happen if women were going to become conscious of what they were wearing to absorb their blood and the deeper issues associated with that. So we created a nonprofit educational corporation with profit-oriented activities in pad production. That was how the Menstrual Health Foundation started.

For me, part of this consciousness came out of struggling with what kind of birth control to use. I had changed my diet and lifestyle, but I was still using an IUD. I thought, “this is crazy”—I had almost died from the IUD. I wanted a way to relate to my fertility that didn’t risk my life, so I began to track my cycle, and I began to see how it is punctuated by different hormone shifts.

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In her work, Tamara emphasizes the premenstruum as a useful time. Usually it is the actual time of bleeding that’s talked about as being the time of power, but Tamara really stresses the premenstruum.

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It’s my experience and the experience of the women I work with that the shift in consciousness arises when the shift in hormones occurs in the premenstrual time. In a healthy woman, this will hit three or four days before she begins to bleed, and it typically results in a desire to withdraw into solitude or to communicate about ways she wants to restructure her life or relationships.

I don't see that as much during the bleeding time. When I hit my bleeding time I've usually settled into it, and there's a release of the tension that's been building up concerning that aspect of the creative dynamic. Before the bleeding I am really looking at things in fragments and pulling them apart, and then when it starts I begin to pull them all together.

It got emphasized for me because I came into this work with PMS. For women who are highly symptomatic, from day fourteen they are already beginning to experience the premenstrual time and starting what we call the Kali period, starting to experience things falling apart and going out of control, in part because they are nutritionally deficient and suffer from a lack of exercise and excess stress. In healthy women it probably hits three to four days before they bleed.

It's a critically significant aspect of the female matrix and it takes one down into the darkness. Once you begin to bleed you begin to come back out. During the premenstruum the dream life is different. Childhood issues, rage, archetypes of Kali, the Black Madonna, dark goddesses, snakes, images of the dark—all that dark material that women have access to appears in dreams, and if we can claim that dark side, we can work with it. It tends to show up in dress too—women prefer to wear darker colors in the premenstruum.

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We live in a culture that suppresses female experience in general. Perhaps if women didn't have so much cause to feel anger and rage, the premenstruum might then have a different quality.

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To me it's a process of sorting through what am I being told is real about this time and then what is real to me. When you are able

to express rage in a safe and nurturing environment, then it does begin to slough off, and you get down to the next level of communication. There's a very ancient body of information available there. The first thing I work with is for women to be okay with this rage. There is a distinction between the crisis stage when one fears losing control—focusing on what is wrong with being female, attacked by one's own body, isolated and despairing—and then moving into the observation stage of noticing that those are the cultural distinctions of a much deeper phenomenon.

The nutritional aspect of PMS is also very important. It's very hard to gather wisdom if your B vitamins are depleted and if you are strung out on sugar and caffeine. Then you are dealing with the breakdown every month rather than the integration of the wisdom. We eat too much fragmented food that has been overprocessed. But it's very hard to get whole foods in a convenient way. Women are on the run, on the go—it's hard to get our hands on something that is quick, nutritious, and affordable.

Our soil is very depleted, which is really another metaphor of what's happened to the feminine. So we're faced with poor quality food and the fact that we can't get healthful food quickly, and then when we do get something that is good for us, we eat it so fast we can't assimilate it. With the amount of stress we experience in our lives, we need better nutrition to help us face that stress. I think that most people would benefit from vitamin supplements, but many women can't afford them.

The gathering of wisdom is available not only during the premenstruum and the period but also at fertility. There's a whole wisdom that's being generated with each cycle—the creation and the destruction aspect each balancing the other—and to be able to listen to that inward conversation about how I'm living and how I'm conducting my life, I have to be healthy enough to be able to get to it,

otherwise I'm just repairing all the time. And that may be where the woman needs to be, but if you can get her to lie down and really take care of herself, she may be able to get to that deeper understanding of her life that her cycle will give her if she'll just start listening. Ignoring that inner conversation is basically a dishonoring of the feminine in the culture—not just of women but of the whole need to go inward and gestate and be in darkness. So the one who carries that the most, the female, suffers.

There is a rhythm to the feminine cycle, and if you watch, you notice the rhythm, and then you can begin to trust it. Through witnessing every cycle and seeing that rhythm in your psychology, your spirituality, your physicality, you begin to really see: Ah yes, I do go inward; things do get dark; I really need to feel safe in order to let things fall apart, and then I know I'll pull through. I'll be on top of the mountain and full of fertility and life will be bright and shiny again, and I'll want to socialize and I'll want to be close to people—and then I'll want to go back down again. The more I observe, the more I trust, and the more I gather the fruits of both.

During my premenstruum and my period I tend to do a lot more journal writing and a lot more assessing of what am I doing in my life now: Is this really what I want to be doing? What do I want to complete? What is it that I am avoiding completing? I usually make a list of who I need to say something to, who I need to communicate with, and what I am afraid to say to them, and then I go about doing those things.

So I'm doing a lot of processing, a lot of grieving, a lot of letting go work. All this tends to be premenstrual. After I bleed I'm usually in my room, doing some kind of artistic process: meditating, praying, writing. I try to get in here at least one night and sleep in here on my own, which is challenging with the kids and my boyfriend, but more and more it's where I find myself. I tend to do more artwork, to create more work around the transformational Goddess—Kali dolls,

witch dolls, things like that. I soak my pads in a bowl or a teapot, and the whole pad thing is a ceremony in itself—taking care of my blood, finding my pads, putting them back afterward. For me that's very important; I had no rhythm as a child. I try to water my plants with my blood. And sometimes I don't do any of that stuff, sometimes it's all I can do to bleed and keep my life going. It's such a conflict now for women, with all the responsibilities that we have as single mothers, to really incorporate that kind of life. It's very challenging. We don't want to create a whole new set of things we have to do. So I avoid beating myself up because I don't withdraw every month. It is also a good time to think about how I earn a living. If a woman starts listening premenstrually, she usually runs into her heart's desire and then she has to figure out how to get it. This is a good part of the goodies that are available in menstrual and premenstrual consciousness.

I assert that what we are working with here is a matrix. With menarche you meet your wisdom, and with your monthly bleeding you practice your wisdom, and then at menopause you become the wisdom.

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THE PRIESTESS

HALLIE IGLEHART AUSTEN

*Hallie Iglehart Austen is a priestess. One of the early leaders of the women's spirituality movement, she has dedicated her life to the return of the sacred feminine to modern life. She teaches the techniques of earth-centered ritual to groups of women and leads celebrations at equinoxes and solstices and other holy days for women, men, and children. Her first book, *Womanspirit*, came out in 1983 and influenced a generation of feminists hungry for a sense of woman-as-divine, whose spiritual yearnings could find only male gods and leaders in the established religions. Her latest book is *The Heart of the Goddess: Art, Myth and Meditations of the World's Sacred Feminine*.*

Hallie lives in the hills above Point Reyes in northern California, in a round house that sits in a hollow in the land, surrounded by tall fir trees. She migrated here from Berkeley in 1986 to write and teach and live close to the earth. She writes in a small, cozy room at the top of a spiral staircase, with

windows on three sides that look out at the swaying treetops and the blue blur of the ocean in the distance. It seems fitting that she live and work here, in this beautiful, still wild part of the planet, surrounded by earth and water, trees and sky.

After graduating from Brown University in the late sixties, Hallie traveled to Asia and was very attracted to the Tibetan Buddhists she met in Dharamsala in the northern Indian Himalaya. She studied with them, wintering in the high mountains and learning their ritual and meditation practices. In between visits to India she returned to the States where she became involved with the growing feminist movement.

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It was a split time for me. On the one hand I was very involved with the feminist movement, and then I would spend time in India studying what was in many ways a male-dominated spiritual tradition.

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Eventually the split became overwhelming, and she moved back to the United States to see if she could discover a sense of the spiritual that enhanced rather than contradicted feminism.

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I decided to move to San Francisco, where so many exciting things were happening, and I continued my work with the Feminist Health Center. There the relationship between the patriarchy and women's health became very clear to me. I didn't have my period for a year and a half after taking birth control pills. Now it is something that I really guard and treasure because of having lived without it, and I felt that it was really something that the patriarchy robbed me of.

It was quite a revelation to start working at the Feminist Health Center and to see what these pills had done to my body. When I was

taking them in the mid to late sixties, it was just considered wonderful if you could get them—huge doses of hormones and no one was questioning it at all.

The first time I bled after that year and a half was very dramatic. I was cross-country skiing up in Yosemite. I was off by myself and I squatted to pee in the snow and this red fell on the snow. It was the first time I'd seen my menstrual blood in a year and a half. It was very beautiful. I remember that moment, even though it was seventeen years ago—it was so visual. I was very happy because I'd been doing several things to try to get my period back. At the same time I had cervical dysplasia, so it was even more of a sign that my health was better, because I got rid of the dysplasia and got my period back. Because of that experience I've really treasured my period.

I remember in 1969 being furious with a lover, a man. We'd been lovers for quite a while, and he wouldn't make love with me when I had my period. I felt good about my menstrual blood but I don't remember thinking of it as sacred until I started getting into women's spirituality and the Goddess.

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In 1975 Hallie and several copriestesses created a menstruation ritual in Oregon for two hundred women.

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We did the blood ritual in a big meadow under a full moon. The main point was painting ourselves with menstrual blood and saying really affirmative things about menstruation. When we created the ritual, the idea was to counteract the negative ideas about menstruation. Doing that ritual was wonderful and celebratory—I'm sure in retrospect that it really grounded me in my body in a way that I wouldn't have been otherwise—that's always an ongoing process of

course. [See appendix 2 for recommendations regarding HIV and the use of menstrual blood in ceremony.]

I've been through various stages in my relationship with my bleeding. I tried using sponges but they didn't hold enough for me. I can't remember when the shift of not using tampons came—probably when toxic shock syndrome first appeared.

I don't always know enough to be able to plan around my bleeding—sometimes I have a workshop scheduled months in advance. I feel like I've gone through many phases with my bleeding. Certainly there was a phase of really loving it and honoring it and opening up with wonder to something that had been denied for so long. After it became regular, I had severe cramps, so that was a whole other teaching and journey—learning to deal with the pain that demanded that I pay attention to it. I honor my period as best I can.

I try to bleed on the ground at some point. It was a way for me to connect with the earth even when I lived in Berkeley. If I could go out and bleed onto a little plot of earth it was a way to ground myself even when I was living in concrete. That felt like a very important link, and it's something I recommend to women who live in cities. If you can, just take a moment to bleed onto the ground. Your cells are blending with the earth; you are connected to the earth by your blood being there. Here I'm surrounded by the earth so it's not so much of an issue. For me bleeding on the earth is an opportunity to experience it in a natural way. Sanitary pads aren't too natural but they are convenient—whereas bleeding on the earth, that's real. It's important for me to tap back into how people lived in another time. That may sound romanticized but when you live outdoors you don't have to worry about bleeding on things—Native Americans bled on moss.

What's changed for me more recently is allowing myself to do whatever I want to do on the first day of my period—whether it's going

off on a big hike, hanging around, or working. I'm allowing myself to be spontaneous, and if I don't do that I get cramps. I know why so many women in offices get menstrual cramps—it's because they are sitting at desks. If you can lie down or walk or whatever it really helps a lot.

I think of the first day as the strongest time, I think of it as a transitional time, the time between bleeding and not bleeding. I feel something beginning the day before, a lot of things are going on in my body at a cellular level. Sometimes the second day is also very powerful. I feel most respectful whenever the flow is heaviest. When you're sitting there bleeding, bleeding, bleeding, it's hard to keep a normal schedule because this thing is happening that is quite miraculous and also requires attention.

A friend of mine told me of a woman she knew who, when she was menstruating, could always tell when blood was about to come. I was very struck by that. It made me want to be more aware, and now, when I start to feel the blood come, I go outside. It's partly environmental—I use fewer pads—but it's also paying attention to the fact that blood is coming out of my body. I stop what I am doing and let it happen. I see menstruation as a Zen practice, as a monthly practice. Again, because I didn't have my period for so long, I learned to watch it more because it was important—watching it, asking myself what it was doing, watching it do its dance like the birds or the sky. This watching may have begun as a way to check in with my health, but now it's almost like this being enters my body, and I watch it do its dance for those five days. Attention can be a key thing for women reclaiming their cycles.

The last few years I have noticed extreme sexual energy around ovulation and menstruation. I feel myself particularly a priestess when I'm bleeding—it reminds me of my connection with all my sisters and all our mothers. It is something so basic and yet so big, so dramatic. It's

amazing. Small wonder that whole ceremonies are based around it. For the Apache and several other Native American tribes the most important ceremony is the girls' puberty rite. In India, there is a spring that flows with iron oxide after the monsoon rains. People from all over make pilgrimages to this spring in Kamakhya, Assam, and drink the red water as the menstrual blood of the Earth Mother, the Goddess.

One of the most profound things for us Euro-Westerners to comprehend is that for some traditional peoples, menses is a time of power. If we could just get that, a lot of things would change—the work schedule, our attitudes toward women, sicknesses, more conscious birthing. Everything would change.

The alchemical process that takes place within us means that our spirituality is internalized and that perhaps it comes more naturally, that we understand transformative processes. We know that it's true, we know that it's possible, we know that we can create this miracle in our bodies—birth, lactation, menstruation. That connects women up with the life force, more in the sense that we know that this happens in our bodies, so it enables us to be more life-affirming because we create life. I think we have more acceptance through our bodily processes that things happen without our controlling them. We are more accepting of mystery. Menstruation just happens, it happens through us, we don't do anything to make it happen.

What we've lost in this culture is a sense of awe. I think that when we reclaim our sense of awe about menstruation, about blood, about the cycles of the moon, of our fertility, of the incredible changes that go on in our bodies, then we will be able to reclaim our sense of awe about the universe, because to me the menstrual cycle is a microcosm of the universe. So instead of one's lover being turned off by menstruation, one's lover can bow to it from every cell, with deep feeling.

We can re-create that sense of awe in the natural world by doing rituals, either alone or together. I think that because we don't have

puberty rituals, we stay adolescents in some way. There has to be a reason why cultures have puberty rites. I see rituals and cycles as opportunities for letting go, for renewal and purification. Rituals are all about letting go of the old and making space for the new because we live on a planet of cycles. That's why menstruation is so important as we reclaim the true cyclical nature of life on this planet.

PART FOUR

RITUALS AND
RECOMMEN-
DATIONS

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RITUALS OF THE MOON-TIME

A few years ago I had the opportunity to spend extended periods of time alone in a beautiful spot in the Sierras on the shore of Lake Tahoe, a vast blueness sacred to the Native Americans. I began to fully retreat when I had my period, being quiet and alone, sitting on the earth in the sunshine with lizards and blue jays for company, with the wind and the moon and the sun, the ripples and the colors on the lake as my guides and entertainers. I would journey inside my psyche and find myself suddenly in tears at something long forgotten, an event from my childhood or adolescence. My period became a time when I found I was particularly able to open up to my inner life and release emotions. I noticed that after the first few days of bleeding I would go very still and quiet for a day or so and seemingly nothing would be happening—an empty space after the weeping and remembering.

Then as my period ended there would be several hours of clarity in which I would be particularly creative and open to information about the future—usually the coming month, but sometimes further reaching than that.

This pattern continues, although usually it is less intense these days. Much of the deeply held psychological clutter appears to have been released—probably as much as my psyche wants to deal with at this stage in my life. Now I feel more up-to-date with myself so there is less to let go of, usually just anything I have held onto from the preceding month. I still struggle with the empty time and often start to do things, imagining that nothing is happening internally so I might as well get back to business in the outer world. Often this backfires and I find that I accomplish little and use up a lot of energy. It's hard to sit still when nothing is coming up to work on, it's hard for me to honor that emptiness even though I know it precedes creativity, inspiration, and insight. It is all part of the process but it is an undramatic part, and I still have a tendency to ride roughshod over it.

I don't have a daily meditation practice. I prefer to adjust my inner and contemplative time to my own impulses. Often when I have my period I go into a quiet, solitary, and meditative space for three or four days; I'm then much less solitary the rest of the month. This feels like a very natural rhythm to me, and that's why I think of the bleeding time as the Sabbath of women.

I plan ahead for when I think my period will come. My periods are not precisely regular—I have a twenty-six to twenty-eight day cycle, and so I mentally circle those days in my calendar. I don't plan anything for that time or for at least three days after it, meaning that about five or six days will be set aside even though only three or four of these will actually be a time when I don't want to go out. I work mainly at home, so this is relatively easy for me to do.

As I have a month's warning of when my bleeding time is likely to be, I can plan my social life, meetings, appointments, and so on around it.

Often I will find myself entering a different state of awareness about two days before the bleeding starts—but not always. And I don't usually feel the strong need to withdraw until I begin to bleed. Women really differ in this and for some women it is during the week before their period that they want to withdraw, and then when they begin to bleed they feel like being out in the world again. You have to tune in to what is right for you.

In the day or two before I begin to bleed, I find that I stop wanting to drive. I often find myself in the kitchen cooking a big stew or soup. This is what I will eat on the first couple of days of bleeding, when I will not want to cook. I also often get an urge to clean my home just before I begin to bleed. This appears to be very similar to the urge women get before giving birth—preparing the nest. I have talked to many women who share this sudden impulse to clean, clean, clean. This is a very useful biological pull for those of us who do not usually enjoy domestic tasks; it means that you have a nice, clean, and tidy space in which to retreat. I also make sure I go shopping to buy plenty of food before my period starts, and get in the firewood, so that I am free to go wherever my period wants to take me without having to be pulled out of that precious state by the demands of everyday life.

When the first blood comes, I look at it, and always there is a spark of pleasure—of recognition—ah! there you are again. I get out my cloth pads from their place in the bathroom closet. Sometimes I have a cup of tea to celebrate the return of my blood, and to warm my body—blood temperature drops as we begin to bleed.

The extent of my retreat varies from month to month. Some months are particularly powerful. I remember one month when an

image of myself in isolation and silence had persistently crept into my thoughts. When my blood came the urge for complete silence became very strong. So I turned off the phones and made an agreement with myself not to turn the television or radio on if I got bored but just to sit with it. I called a couple of friends and told them that I would be incommunicado for a few days. For five days I spoke to no one, had no external stimulus, no contact with the media in any form. It was bliss.

I wrote and meditated for long periods of time, finding it easy to go into a strong still place in myself. In the afternoons I went for gentle walks in the park behind my home. I wore no makeup and barely looked in the mirror.

When I began coming out of this state, I looked in the mirror and saw that I looked like someone who was ill—and I realized that illness is partly a retreat into the interior world. I wasn't ill, I felt fine, but my personality wasn't present on my face—I didn't have a face for the outside world. All my energy was focused on something that was happening inside. It took a couple of days for my face to return, for the energy to come back to the surface.

During this time I had several big dreams, and I made a leap forward in my understanding of this book and the shape it needed to take. It felt necessary and healing and loving to give myself this time. I felt more centered than I had for a while, and wrote several important letters that represented the completion of two significant relationship problems that had been ongoing in my life. I felt so good during this time it is hard to find words to describe the state. It's not simply that I was happy—it was more than that. I was deeply at home with myself and in touch with the spirit, with a power that is gentle, loving, and vast. I felt that spirit, that energy, suffusing me, filling me up, loving and nurturing me.

But I don't need or want to do such a strong retreat every month. Sometimes it's simply a question of sleeping alone for a night or two and spending some quiet time in meditation during the first couple of days. If I *have* to do something, some event that was planned months in advance, I have found that I can enlist the help of my cycle. As Wendy Alter noted in chapter 7, when she was working at NASA and aspiring to be an astronaut, her period always came at the most inconvenient time. Nowadays she is paying attention to her cycle and says, "I suppose if it can schedule itself to come at inconvenient times then there's no reason it shouldn't come at convenient times too."

I have found over the past couple of years that my period has really become my friend. Once I inadvertently planned to run a seminar on the second day of my period. I talked to my body about it the night before, and asked if it would be okay for me to go, as I didn't want to let people down. When I woke up that morning my blood flow was very heavy and I felt rather distraught about having to drive to the venue and then teach—but miraculously, as soon as I left the house I stopped bleeding. After the teaching ended, the bleeding started again. It seemed that the heavy flow in the early morning had been my body going into action to take care of the day's bleeding while I was able to be still and be in touch with myself. When I needed to be present for the outside world, the bleeding stopped. I don't recommend abusing the good nature of one's body—but it is certainly possible to have a relationship of cooperation and goodwill between the instinctive drive and the conscious will. The instincts have to feel deeply respected, though, otherwise they will rebel against being ignored, and illness or dis-ease of some type will result.

Most of us have ignored our instincts and, under social pressure, carried on as normal when we have our period. I suspect that this results in a backlog, so that when one first starts to allow the natural

rhythm to emerge, the body-mind has a need for intensive retreat to mend the damage of all the years of ignoring the bleeding. I also think that I may be an extreme case—it is clearly part of my life's work to deeply investigate the mystery and meaning of the menstrual cycle, and this may mean that I have a particularly strong need for retreat at this time. Everyone has to find her own rhythm, her own need for silence, for withdrawal, for healing.

RESENTING MY PERIOD

Sometimes my period feels like an unwanted intruder into my life. Even though I have been focusing on it for several years and have discovered what richness it can hold, sometimes I wish I could just suppress it. Do I really need to go through this mess and cramps and inconvenience and grumpiness and not feeling like going out *every* month? Wouldn't once or twice a year be enough?

This feeling tends to come on when I am waiting for my period to begin. There is a heaviness to my body and I just wish it would start and get on with its thing. At moments like that I feel distant from my body and its processes and somewhat repulsed. And old thoughts drift through my mind like, "why don't I have a convenient noncyclical nonbleeding body like a man?"

My breasts are tender and so is my heart. Everything hurts more—I watch a movie on the television and weep, I cry myself to sleep, I worry about the world. I feel colder than normal, and vulnerable in a raw and aching seemingly never-ending way. I have felt this feeling so many times in my life—and yet here I am, warm and dry, with food in my kitchen, clothes on my back, in a better situation for survival than most people on this planet. Yet nonetheless, in the time immediately before I begin to bleed, I am weak and anxious and I

want someone, a big cosmic momma, to give me a cuddle and tell me that everything will be all right.

I find myself in more self-doubt at this time. Am I making a great big mess of my life? Can I write this book? I battle the demons of self-doubt with all the weapons I have gathered over the years. I just get on with my work, and tell them, kindly, to please leave me alone. I know that they are just picking on me because I feel vulnerable today. I light a fire to warm the room and my heart. I call a friend. I cook a nourishing, filling meal full of carbohydrates and comfort. I go easy on myself.

MUNDANE RITUALS

The choices we make at a mundane everyday level are very important. Being mindful about the details of how and where and onto what we bleed all adds up to an increasingly harmonious relationship with our practical, political, and spiritual selves.

Tampons are convenient but can be a health hazard. Paper disposable pads use up trees and add to the mountains of garbage we plow into the earth. All the arguments against disposable diapers hold true for menstrual pads. The obvious alternative is to go back to using cloth. The idea has echoes of “rags” and pre-war poverty, but in practice I’ve found that cloth menstrual pads work very well.

I’ve been using them for several years now and I love them. It sounds gruesome and messy but in practice it’s a breeze. They are made of soft, cozy, absorbent 100 percent cotton flannel that fits snugly against the body—they are much more comfortable than paper disposable pads. They don’t slide around inside your underwear and you don’t need to use a belt or pins. I’ve not had a single accident. In fact I used to have more leakage and spillage with paper pads, and a

friend of mine who bleeds very heavily at night has found that the flannel pads are far superior to throwaways.

Once used, I sling them in a bucket of cold water to soak (with a lid on it, to keep the smells in and not offend other members of the household), use the water to feed my plants (you should have seen my bean crop this year), and then put the whole lot in the washing machine on a hot wash when my period's over. The total job takes five minutes. Although there is an initial outlay to purchase cloth pads, they last several years, and over time save you money.

They cause significantly less damage to the environment, and I'm relieved to know that my period isn't contributing to marine pollution or landfills. I also enjoy a wonderful feeling of autonomy at not having to rush to the pharmacy at the first sight of blood. There is no danger of exposure to carcinogens like dioxin, which can be found in bleached paper products, including pads and tampons, and no danger of toxic shock syndrome. I am also free from the possibility of contracting any of the nefarious infections caused by tampons and by the lack of circulation that results from the plastic backing of the paper pads. All in all, it's a much better deal. And I like the fact that I get to see my blood—it looks much nicer on a piece of floral flannel than it ever did on a grungy old tampon or a white paper pad.

As Tamara Slayton commented in chapter 8, using cloth pads is a ritual in and of itself. Getting my pads out marks the beginning of my period. I keep them in a pretty bag in a closet. Soaking them and washing them emphasize for me the cleansing, clearing up aspect of my period. Giving the soaking water to my plants and to nearby trees reminds me of my connection to nature, to the earth and her cycles. And then folding them up and putting them away when my bleeding has finished marks the end of the sacred pause in the month that is my moon-time.

For women working outside the home it is often simply impractical to use cloth pads during the day. You can use them at night and

use disposables at work. I really don't like using paper pads any more and so I usually try and think of a way to use my cloth pads whatever the circumstances. One solution that I have used is to carry a plastic lined pouch with me. I quickly rinse out the used pad, pop it in the pouch, and then wash it out properly when I get home. I have also successfully used cloth pads while on vacation—I just take three or four pads with me, and wash them out and hang them to dry in the hotel bathroom.

BLEEDING ONTO THE EARTH

When I was first introduced to the idea of bleeding onto the earth by a friend of mine, I thought it sounded a little silly, a little pretentious. But I started doing it tentatively, and began to feel a flicker of connection to something very old. One of the problems I had was figuring out how to do it. Native American women traditionally bled onto moss while sitting on the earthen floor of the moon-lodge. Where was I supposed to sit and bleed? Even if I went and found a nice piece of earth to sit on, I didn't want to stay there for the whole time. Then I started using cloth pads to absorb my blood and soaking them in water before I washed them. I realized that I could pour the soaking water onto the earth. So now that's what I do. The water is a beautiful red, and I pour it onto the ground around plants. The act of doing this fills me with a feeling of connection, of rightness, of being at peace with something that is often neglected in modern life. Simple acts of value, simple knowledge.

It's like chopping wood, rocking a baby, baking bread, or drinking from a fast-flowing mountain stream. It's one of those acts of being human that is timeless, of eternal value, part of the steady round of life and death. The cells that die in my body, that are carried in the

menstrual blood, are food for the earth. What dies gives birth. What dies feeds those who live and will live.

If I ignore my blood, I get distanced from this knowledge. I fear and dislike my blood—for without the knowledge that it too is food, that it too is a gift I bear, then I see it as purely loss. A waste of blood, a waste of time, a baby that wasn't conceived. Whether I desire pregnancy or not, my blood is always a gift. And it is a gift in a literal sense, as well as a psychic gift to myself. It is a gift from my body back to the earth: the mother that has fed and nurtured me every day of my life.

Women's blood is not waste. It is fertilizer for the earth. This was known by all the earth-centered peoples, by those who revered the Goddess and who recognized the female and her body as the conduit through which life comes, and therefore sacred. This life comes not only in the form of offspring, but also in the form of precious blood, given every month to feed the earth, the plants and insects, and all the beings of the planet. This is another aspect of the miraculous interplay between woman and life. We waste this precious resource, just as we waste the rich placenta after birth, because we fail to recognize the value of the female. We look on this blood, full of iron and other minerals, and all we see is waste matter, and so we pour it into our sewage systems instead of doing the obvious and pouring it onto the earth.

This is simple knowledge. You don't have to study hard, you don't have to read any books at all, you don't take any exams or pick up any diplomas. No one will pat you on the back and say how clever you are or how hard you have worked. The reward is purely internal—in the feeling of being in harmony with something so essential to human life, something that we have taken for granted for the last few hundred years.

One of the most effective ways to ground yourself when you move house is to shed your menstrual blood upon the land of your new home. Then your cells are literally on the land, the land is fed

and recognized by you, and you have created a psychic and cellular link with the earth. This can have a powerful effect on your relationship with your home territory. It is like an animal making its mark perhaps, and it is also an act of love—to give a part of yourself to the land creates a two-way relationship to replace the one-way attitude that we normally have toward the land that we live upon. As Hallie Iglehart Austen recommended in chapter 9, you can do this even if you live in town—take an hour or so to visit a park or sit in your back garden and let a few drops of your blood embrace the ground. Bleed at the foot of a tree that you particularly like, and watch your relationship with that tree develop. You will notice the tree in a new way and feel a bond that is not often experienced by people who do not live close to nature.

THE PULSE OF THE EARTH

The earth emits a pulse to which we are all attuned. This pulse regulates our heartbeat and the cycles within our bodies, from the steady round of the blood pulsing through the veins to the monthly emission of blood from the menstruating woman. This pulse emanating from the earth is very, very subtle. Few people can actually feel it, but that does not mean that it isn't there.

The Indians of the Amazon rainforest recognize the existence of this pulse, and they listen for it when they go in search of the climbing vine that is one of the chief constituents in their sacred tea—ayahuasca. “By listening for a drumbeat that emanates from the vines on the astral plane, talented feitores can locate those sites in the rainforest where the greatest concentration of vines will be found.”¹

Mountains are strong places to feel the pulse. The sacred mountains of the world send out this sound, this rhythm, such as Uluru

(Ayers Rock) in Australia and Mount Shasta in California. Lakes and rivers are also good places to tune in to the energy of the earth, especially the large lakes like Lake Tahoe and Lake Baikal.

Listening to this pulse comes most easily to the woman in her bleeding time. Then she is open to the mystery of the pulse and the wisdom it contains. When you are in the pulse and can feel it, then you are in the hands of the Goddess—of the great mysterious force from the inside of the planet. Your body is healed and strengthened by the direct contact and knowledge of this pulse. This is what women are listening to in their bodies when they sit still during menstruation, when they sit still and they bleed upon the land. This is the deeper meaning behind sitting on the land and bleeding directly onto it.

BLOOD VISIONS

The red dot that Hindu women paint on the third eye is a symbol of the menstrual blood. Originally women would have painted their third eye with their actual blood. The magic of the blood opens the sixth chakra (the energy center associated with spiritual and psychic vision). The visionary aspect of menstruation is clearly invoked by this practice. The blood carries in it the cells of the body, and therefore it contains the knowledge of the DNA. The genetic code, the lineage, is contained within the bloodstream. It may exist at a level that cannot be detected by modern science, but it is there. Every cell in the body is a microcosm of the whole. By painting the third eye with the blood, we open ourselves to the knowledge hidden in the genetic code. This knowledge includes deep ancestral awareness and can bring understanding of our own family patterns and of those of the human family. We are all one family, ultimately descended from the same mother.

We all have within us the knowledge of every generation of human beings that has ever lived. Locked into that coding is a mass of information gathered throughout history. At times the information sleeps; at times it wants to come alive again. We are living at a time when the knowledge of the earth, of the female, is surging back into the collective awareness, and through our blood we can tap into it. Next time you bleed, try connecting consciously with your blood. Try painting a gentle red dot on your forehead, and see what knowledge from the earth and from our ancestors flows into your consciousness.

FINDING YOUR OWN WAYS OF HONORING YOUR BLEEDING

The challenge here is to discover your own rhythm and your own needs and desires within the structure of the monthly cycle, and then to stay fluid with the information that comes. Every month is different. I have found keeping a journal very helpful. I record the day of my cycle, the phase of the moon, and any dreams, thoughts, fantasies, and synchronicities that attract my attention and seem to hold information. This process has led me to develop my own rituals around my periods. These are very simple, like wearing a particular pair of earrings that live on my altar for the rest of the month. They have an important role in reminding me of the sacredness of bleeding. Rituals help to counter the ignorance and denial of the power and beauty of menstruation (and, therefore, of being a woman) that is all around us in our culture.

None of these ideas and observations about menstruation should be taken as absolutes. Like every process, menstruation is an individual experience, for each woman, each month. For me, menstruation

is the time when I can least get away with activities that are not in harmony with my deepest self. Traveling may bring on pain and feelings of disharmony because travel is sometimes a distraction in my life and usually goes against the inward-turning stillness of menstruation. But if the travel is appropriate and necessary, then I can do it with reasonable grace. Thus the period is a great teacher, and the information it gives us can be used in less aware times of the month. Sometimes it is good to be around male energy when I menstruate, sometimes it is wonderful to make love. Sometimes it is anathema and feels completely wrong. By making rules about what is and is not permissible in menstruation we lose our connection to the essential knowledge of our unique and ever-changing, ever-staying-the-same, individual reality, and thereby lose one of the greatest gifts of being in a female body.

IDEAS AND SUGGESTIONS FOR MENSTRUAL RITUALS

It is essential to begin to get in touch with yourself. Keep a journal and record daily the day of your cycle and the stage of the moon, and make notes about your energy level, impulses, emotions, and so on. By doing this you always know what day of your cycle you are in and how that relates to the moon's cycle, and you begin to learn what your own rhythms are. It is important to record impulses even if they are not followed. Here is an example of one day's entry: "January 9, Day 4, Full moon. Woke up feeling very dreamy, it was hard to concentrate on my work but I persisted." This exercise is more difficult to do if you are on the pill as it distorts the cycle completely. IUDs affect the menses too. However it is still helpful to keep a journal and see what is going on.

Honor what your body wants. Learn to identify your conditioning and then question it. When you have a strong feeling to do or not do something when you are menstruating then follow the impulse and see what happens internally as a result. If you are a meditator, notice what your meditation is like when you are bleeding and at other times in the cycle. Record this information in your journal. Experiment with your dreaming by asking questions of your dreams before going to sleep and by making a special effort to remember and record them. Sometimes it helps to focus your attention by putting a crystal under your pillow.

Experiment with making up your own rituals. The Native American tradition is a good one to borrow from, because Native Americans have a strong understanding of ritual and a respect for menstruation. You can make the moon the focus of your ritual. Some Native American women pray to the moon for the healing of irregular cycles, and I have found that it is particularly connecting and enriching for me to meditate on the moon and make her in some way a part of my menstrual rituals. You can also use your blood itself—paint it on your third eye before you go to sleep to enhance dreaming; make a ritual painting of yourself menstruating, and incorporate your blood into it. Reclaim the blood as a sacred fluid, honor your body as the body of the Goddess.

It's a good idea to make a space in your home that is your own sacred place—a room where you can dream, doze, paint, draw, sew, write. If not a whole room, then at least you can make an altar—a special little shelf or table that acts as a focus for ritual activity and for centering and strengthening of the spirit. Most women have some kind of altar in their home without necessarily ever calling it that: a shelf that holds precious items and photographs of loved ones is actually an altar. It is just another step in reclaiming our own connection

to Spirit to add a candle or two and some sage or incense, perhaps a bowl of water and some earth, and there you have a sacred space before which to sit and center yourself.

As Hallie Iglehart Austen said in chapter 9, rituals are important because they focus our attention. “Honoring one’s period is really a powerful way to develop these abilities.”

Rituals change and develop to suit the nature of the times. Now is a time when women are reclaiming the power and value of menstruation, and we are all the cocreators of a new way of celebrating being female. In her teaching about ritual creation, Hallie emphasizes the necessity of courage and experimentation. “We can take something from a tradition and make it our own—or maybe take it back to its original meaning. The tradition of the blood of Christ and the wine is I’m sure taken from the menstrual blood.”

Tamara Slayton encourages women to use their period as a time of creativity: “In one class we make dolls—menstrual dolls, fertility dolls. This is a big part of the work with the younger girls. Art is the access to the imagination. We make little beeswax uteruses; we make greeting cards congratulating each other. During advent we made lanterns, and last time we made golden crowns to honor the Madonna in us—that was really awesome seeing all these women sitting in this room wearing golden crowns—very powerful.”

We can heal the wound of our lack of formal initiation into womanhood by remembering just what it was like when we began to menstruate. Once we have remembered, we can begin to undo the negativity that was programmed into us. Then perhaps a group of women could get together and create a post-facto puberty ritual.

Using the natural creativity of the period to get in touch with yourself through writing and painting can be very beneficial. Often understanding of deep processes comes easier through painting and writing than it does through trying to tackle the problem directly. The

diffuse state of awareness that comes with menstruation makes this an ideal time for letting go into what Castaneda's Don Juan called the *nagual* and Australian aborigines call the *Dreamtime*—the unknown of ourselves where there is wisdom and knowledge—and allowing information to come through creative channels. Try writing about your own experiences of menstruation and of puberty. You may learn unexpected things about yourself. This is also a great way to access information about the future.

In the Tibetan Dzog Chen tradition, there is a purification practice every dark of the moon. This involves visualizations and chanting, which clean out all your chakras, and a bathing ritual. It's possible that this practice originated because women menstruated at the new moon. I usually have at least one very long bath during my period, often toward the end, in which I am mindful of purifying my body, and of letting go of whatever needs to leave.

This purification can be focused on in meditation by asking "what don't I want to carry around any more?" Think of yourself as a snake shedding its skin, leaving behind the past and being free to move on to the next month.

You can also incorporate the invocation of goddesses associated with the menstrual cycle into your rituals—examples are Artemis/Diana (goddess of the moon, the wilds, and the protector of women), Aphrodite and Isis (associated with the full moon, sexuality, and fertility), Hecate (crone goddess of the dark of the moon), Kali, and the Tibetan *dakinis* and their skull bowls of blood.

THE SACRED BELLY

If we aren't soft with ourselves in our bellies then we may have menstrual problems from tensing up that area. Letting the belly go soft is

a challenge in today's culture. The violence of our times makes us tense up the belly region to protect ourselves, this is an instinctive reaction, and the idea that women aren't really women and shouldn't have bellies also means that women tighten unnaturally there.

Our current cultural preference in the Western world for flat and androgynous teenage bellies has several causes. One is our denial of the power of the womb. In cultures where the feminine is more respected and honored, such as India, the roundness of women is considered beautiful, and in fact women strive for curves and flesh.

When we take back the reality of being women and the power contained within the generative cycles of our beings, then the belly comes back into its own as the home of the womb and ovaries. The belly is also, of course, the home of the digestive process, another part of life that we culturally ignore. We tend to eat food fast and without ceremony, without saying thank you or grace, without allowing restful time for digestion to lovingly and fully take place. Instead we jump up the minute we have eaten so we can get back to Doing Things.

Fear of the aging process and overidentification with youth also promotes a denial of the belly. Men and women don't develop bellies until maturity, and usually not until after pregnancy for women or middle-age in men. Thus the belly is a signal that youth is gone forever, and in a culture that venerates youth above sagacity, there is little to be gained in the eyes of one's peers from having a belly. This is not to support laziness and lack of fitness. Having healthy stomach muscles and a generally trim and fit physique is always to be lauded, but it is natural for women to have more rounded stomachs than men—look at old paintings or photographs of women from other cultures. It is a twentieth-century phenomenon to expect women to have flat stomachs, just as it is a twentieth-century phenomenon to rush away from the table once you have eaten and to pretend that nothing is happening when you have your period.

SOFT BELLY—A MENSTRUAL MEDITATION

I learned a meditation called “Soft Belly” from Stephen Levine at a lecture he gave some years ago. It was very effective, and I went round for days afterward incanting soft belly, soft belly gently under my breath and being aware of the many subtle ways I would hold and tense my belly as I went through my day. Soft belly, soft belly. That’s all it is really—just focus on your belly and allow it to soften. You may want to go into the tension first—feel how tense it can get, make it really tense and experience that and then say softly to yourself “soft belly” and allow the tension to float away; feel the release and the happiness, the peace and easiness of having a soft unjudgmental happy little belly full of love and compassion and tenderness for the world and everything around you.

Let go into that softness and allow it to spread all over your body and feel the luscious loveliness of your whole being and the juicy delicious femaleness of having a soft and pliable, a warm and comforting belly. A place for babies to grow, a place for feelings to develop, for ideas to gestate, for food to be digested and fully absorbed, a place for all your feelings to be worked on and out and through, a place for cozy late night suppers and happy active early morning breakfasts, a place for comfort, for solitude, for lying on the earth feeling the hot sun on your warm back as your soft and tender loving belly caresses your mother, the earth.

Relax more deeply into your belly now. Feel the goddess within you. She loves your round and full belly; she loves the femaleness of you, the fecund weightiness of that full soft belly. Let it go even more. Softly, softly, your belly is rounding out, letting go, and you are coming home, more and more at home with yourself, as you release the images of a flat and masculine teenage nonbelly—for now you are a woman who has given or who can give birth to another being, and

to do that you need a belly. So let your belly be, be proud of it, wear it in the world along with your big heart and your shiny eyes; wear your round soft tender loving belly out into the world and soften all around you with the power of your soft and tender loving belly. And when a child is crying pull him onto your lap and let him sit on your belly, and when your inner child is crying put your hands on your belly and rub it softly saying, "it's okay, I'm here, and here is our soft and tender, loving belly, the center of our being, the home of our womb, the center of gravity, the deepest place within." And nurture that belly space, for within it is the treasure trove of your creativity and your gift for the world.

MENSTRUATION AS ALCHEMY

The whole menstrual cycle is an alchemical process in itself, during which every woman who bleeds goes through a transformation inside herself. To menstruate means to live through a cyclical transmutation in which the past is shed and the new is embraced. Experiencing this transformation through conscious ritual awakens us to our connection with the cycles taking place all around us and to our relationship with all life.

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BLEEDING WITH THE WORLD

Just as our ancestors honored woman's ability to create humans from her womb and feed them from her breast, they also honored the Earth as the Great Mother who nourishes us and from whose body we are all created. It is clear that in order to save ourselves—not to mention fulfill our true potential—we must honor Nature, the Goddess, and women.

Hallie Iglehart Austen, *The Heart of the Goddess*

MENSTRUATION AND RELATIONSHIPS

Deciding to have a deeper relationship with your bleeding means not only changing your relationship with yourself, but also shifting the ways in which you relate with others. It's one thing to sidle off alone into some quiet time, and it's another step to say to someone else, "I need to be alone now to be with myself; I have my period."

You don't have to do it all at once. If you are concerned that you will meet opposition from your partner and family, try working first

with yourself and identifying the parts in you that are against your experiencing your bleeding, that are against the idea of it being a powerful time. You may well find an inner voice that tells you that you are wasting your time, that it is merely a biological function, that being a woman is simply a messy business, and that you should just get on with it and experience it as little as possible. Get to know your conditioning and your biases. If it feels right, try engaging the conflicting voices in a dialogue and see how they interact. Encourage them to come out with their worst, and then see if there is a natural tendency for them to begin relating a little easier. Compromise may begin to emerge. The conventional voice may say, "Well, it's okay for you to meditate more but just don't think about bringing those cloth pads into the house." In time, as you experience the sense of wholeness that comes from living your bleeding time more fully, these conflicts will iron out, and the conventional part will be increasingly prepared to change.

When you feel you know your inner conflicts a little more, it will be easier to risk being unusual with other people. It will also be much more likely that they will feel at ease with what you are doing. Our friends and loved ones are generally sensitive to our inner conflicts. Many arguments and relationship difficulties are the result of unrecognized inner battles.

The Role of the Menstrual Cycle in Exposing Relationship Conflicts

Underlying tensions in your relationship will tend to be exposed during the premenstruum and during menstruation. If you and your partner are open to working through difficulties and dedicated to working on an honest, open, equal relationship, you can both come to deeply value the natural tendency of the menstrual cycle to cut

through politeness and convention and to reveal problems early—before they become major relationship messes.

Desiring to Be Alone

As Wendy Alter said in chapter 7, what she wants most is to be left entirely alone when she is bleeding. Susun Weed, a well-known herbalist, said, "Visionary states of consciousness are more accessible when I am menstruating, if I provide myself with that intention and the place where I can freely experience that. I need privacy and quiet and not to feel compelled to respond to anyone else's needs but my own. If I have the safe space of the moon-lodge, then I find that it's easier for me to shift my consciousness."¹ I have had the same experience—that if I can spend some time alone in peace and quiet, insight comes.

Desiring Closeness

Some women find that rather than desiring time alone when they bleed, they have a greater need for reassurance and closeness. They feel vulnerable and in need of cuddles. Women may be more susceptible to feeling rejected at this time—particularly in the light of a culture that has rejected the bodily processes of the female in so many ways.

RELATIONSHIPS WITH MEN

Many women live with a man—a father, husband, son, or boyfriend. It's unusual in this culture to be completely apart from men when we are bleeding. So how can the sexes cohabit at a time when, in many traditions, women have gone apart from men? One way is by the sexes picking up some of each others' process. This is what is happening in

our contemporary world—the roles that define men and women have blurred significantly in the twentieth century. A man who is in touch with his “female” side is much easier to be with when you are bleeding than a man who is very “masculine.” I use these terms with caution. Another way of saying this would be that a man who values the rhythm of his body and is able to articulate and experience his feelings is going to be easier to be around when you yourself are in a deep menstrual feeling state. A man who lives more in the traditional mold of the male—stoic, cut off from feeling, linear, literal—will be much harder to live with if you decide to go further into your menstrual experience.

Many women find that when they delve deeper into the menstrual mysteries, they become uninterested in household chores while they are bleeding or shortly before. If this is the case with you, then it’s going to be crucial how much your partner can pick up your share of the cooking and cleaning and child care.

He needs to be able to take care of himself and also to accept that for a few days every month you are taking care of yourself and may not be so available. This demands more sensitivity than men have traditionally given women in our culture—to be less demanding in terms of food, empathy, sex, and social activities.

This whole business of men picking up a wider range of feeling and women going out more into the world may be part of an overall shift in human consciousness away from a rigid experience of the self through gender. However, we have to be careful that technology and the rapid pace of modern life don’t take us away from our centers—away from the knowledge of our bodies. In a male-dominated world, women’s reality and experience suffers, and the loss of tribal identity and pride in gender manifests itself in the home as much as anywhere.

How well you, your partner, and your bleeding get along together depends a good deal on the level of intimacy in the relationship. If you are able to talk deeply together about your feelings then you stand a good chance of being able to incorporate conscious menstruation into your domestic life. Some men enjoy the deepening of relationship and awareness that comes from the woman being able to really go into herself during her period. One couple I talked to told me that they have experienced very spiritual times together during her period in which insight has come to both of them.

Unconscious Misogyny

If your partner is an unconscious misogynist, this may well show up more at menstruation than at any other time because this is a time when the woman is most obviously female (and during pregnancy of course). Ignoring or despising menstruation is one of the ways that misogyny manifests itself. And it's not only women who create fights around menstruation—men do as well. They will do this especially if they have a bias against slowed-down dreamy energy, altered states, intuition, the release and expression of feelings, and the other states that constellate around menstruation.

Practical Matters

In my experience, using cloth pads appeals to the practical side of men, especially men who are environmentally awake. If your partner is repulsed by blood, he may find a pail of bloody cloths soaking in the bathroom a little hard to take. There are ways around this of course: put them somewhere where he won't have to step over them, use a lid on the pail, and so on.

Healing the Battle of the Sexes

We think of the sexes as being separate and in a way they are. But in another way we are all part of the same big human soup, and how women view themselves and are viewed affects men too. It might look, on the face of it, that men have had the upper hand for the past few thousand years, but that is only true from a certain perspective. Both men and women have gained and suffered from the imbalances of patriarchal society. Men have also been separated from their bodies and from their feelings and from the pleasure and healing made possible by relationships based on cooperation rather than hierarchy and dominance.

Imagine a world in which men and women worked together to develop the sense of inner peace that comes from sitting still for a couple of days once a month, in which men supported women to spend a few days in peaceful quiet. Imagine a world in which menstrual blood was once again a magical fluid with a power to nurture new life, a world in which menstruation was understood to be the Sabbath of women—a natural space within one moon's cycle for retreat, introversion, and inner work, from which women emerge like the new-born moon itself, renewed, the old skin shed.

RELATIONSHIPS WITH WOMEN

There are many instances in cultural lore of women menstruating together in synchrony, and many women that I have spoken with have reported strange experiences of cycles changing to fit with co-workers, friends, and lovers. Current research indicates that it is through smell—through sensing pheromones—that women pick up on each

other's cycles and adjust accordingly. This phenomenon has particularly been observed in female dorms and in women's offices, and some women notice it in their family too.

The first time I experienced menstrual synchrony was on a school trip to Bavaria. I was fifteen and assigned to a small group of six other fifteen- and sixteen-year-olds. For two weeks we traveled in the same train compartment and slept in the same hotel room. We were rarely out of each other's sight. We all began our period on the same day, about ten days into the trip, and at a time that was off cycle for four of us.

Women often remark on the seeming strangeness of menstruating together. We are taught to think of ourselves as individuals, and menstrual synchrony is a powerful reminder of our tribal and animal nature. Menstruating together can be a very bonding experience for women, creating an intimacy of being in the same altered state at the same time. The knowledge that our bodies shift cycle so that we are in harmony creates a feeling of sisterhood that can run deeper than our conscious sense of relationship with one another. The idea of the menstrual hut, a place where women go to menstruate, is very attractive to many women. The thought of having some company and being "in it together" is appealing.

Menstruation and Lesbian Relationships

From talking with women who are in relationships with women, I have learned that there are several aspects to menstruating together. All the lesbian couples I spoke with have experienced a significant level of synchrony—one couple I know begin menstruating within an hour of one another. This gives a great feeling of being understood by your partner and can be powerfully bonding. On the down side, it

can also mean that, as the closely synchronous couple told me, "the week before is hell," as both women have PMS at the same time. Of course, this also makes it a potentially powerful time for experiencing altered states together and for processing the relationship.

MENSTRUATION AND THE FAMILY

A woman's reproductive years are often dominated by the needs of others. Having a time of solitude apart from the demands of the family is a necessary balance. It is a time when the giver can reinforce her sense of self and get to know herself away from the needs of the family or workplace.

Many women find that they become significantly less interested in domestic chores, particularly cooking, when they have their period. The old taboos that women should not touch food when they were bleeding may have had their roots in an earlier awareness that women simply don't want to cook then and from a recognition that this is not a time for domestic work but a time for one's own work.

For the Deese family of Springfield, Oregon, becoming aware of menstrual power has led them to change their family life:

About two years ago we began to establish a moon-time practice of relieving my wife from most domestic chores, mostly from food preparation. This brought moon-time into the working realities of everyone in the family, by requiring some mutual responsibilities that our young ones enjoy. The "inconvenience" requires adjustments which are beautiful openings for teaching and discussion.²

For many women, especially mothers, time alone is hard to come by. Creating a family pattern whereby mother gets a break when she

has her period allows a crucial rebalancing to occur. This doesn't mean that menstruating is always about resting, sometimes it's about working and activity too. It is a great time for working creatively on what you love best, going for a hike in the woods, writing letters, watching the sky. It's a time for yourself—whatever you want to do. Sometimes it is hard for women to get in touch with what they need and want for themselves, as so much of their attention is bound up with the needs of others, particularly if they have children. Your period is a great time to practice getting in touch with your own needs.

MENSTRUATION AND THE WORLD

The Importance of Inner Work for the World

Why work on yourself? First, if it is in your nature to live the examined life, then you will be doing it anyway, and making that examination more conscious will enhance your life; your experiences will be richer and your sense of self more complete. Second, as the great spiritual traditions teach, even one awake individual can create harmony and awareness in the world around her or him. Our inner work is also work for the world. Women menstruating with insight feed that knowledge into the collective of humankind. This insight can also come from nonfocused thinking, and the natural tendency of menstruation to provoke a diffused state of awareness means that it is an excellent time for dreaming and receiving guidance—guidance that can inspire and inform the world around us.

The World Needs Strong Women

Women need to be tough these days—it is no longer enough to be a lady. We have to drive our own cars, earn our own money, take out

our own garbage, raise children alone. This toughness and independence has become part of our survival, and it is also something that we choose, because it brings us more autonomy in our private lives and more power in the world. But in order to survive, and to live our power more fully, we don't have to become tough in the way that men are tough. We can use our toughness to draw our own boundaries, state our own needs, create lifestyles that respect our cyclical body patterns. We can create a world in which it is a pleasure to have a period, in which each is free to menstruate in her own way, a world in which the first blood of young women is greeted with joy and pride. The world needs our strength—but it needs the strength of Women, not the pseudo-strength of pseudo-men.

Gentling the Workplace

In general I recommend taking time out from work if you can, especially on the first day or two when the bleeding is heaviest. If you have to go to work, then take your menstrual energy consciously into the workplace. Allow more spaciness, intuition, and slowness in your attitude at work. Our workspaces have been too dominated by linear thinking, by a striving mentality. Take pride in the state that your period takes you into and change the office—don't let the office change you and create inner anguish, PMS, and cramps. Don't let people rush you; do inner work on your tendency to hurry yourself.

The world needs the wholeness of women. It needs women with healthy wombs who know their own needs and can express their feelings and their wisdom. One of the ways women keep healthy is by taking time out and by honoring their natural rhythms. There is growing evidence that working women are hit hard by the stress of modern life. There is most probably a link between overwork and

premature menopause. Under long-term stress the adrenals burn out, in turn affecting the pituitary and the thyroid glands and the production of estrogen. When estrogen stops being produced, women go into menopause. This is why shock and sudden grief can create premature menopause overnight.

With women suffering from work-related stress, menopause doesn't happen overnight, but it is coming on earlier and earlier. A woman working in a high-powered job, in a male reality that doesn't allow for the cyclical nature of female physiology, is under additional stress for the few days every month when she would rather be resting or puttering about. Instead she carries on just the same, tearing around Manhattan or London or Chicago, and as she rushes around while the blood drips down, her adrenal glands attempt gamely to cope with the stress put on her system by this lifestyle. Chronic fatigue syndrome is an illness also caused by adrenal burnout, and the classic patient is a woman in her thirties or forties with a demanding lifestyle.

Is it worth burning ourselves out and going through premature menopause in order to fit in with a way of life that is insane as far as the female body is concerned?

The Return of the Feminine and the Healing of the Planet

We live at a time of increasing awareness of the female, when feminine values are being returned to the world. The world needs the creativity and compassion of women as it may never have needed it before. It needs women's particular and peculiar abilities in drawing down of the energy of the universe and manifesting it on the planet. Women, by virtue of their biology, have an automatic link to the Great Mother. If they choose to tune in to her through their wombs, they can access knowledge for the good of all.

This increased capacity for self-reflection and insight is not only of significance in the life of the individual woman but also for her partner and family and the larger community around her. Society as a whole unconsciously benefits (and could benefit a lot more) from the wisdom garnered by women experiencing their bleeding with awareness. By becoming aware of this power and potential, we could stabilize our social fabric to a far greater degree. Who knows how much disharmony in family life is caused by women not paying attention to their natural rhythms? The Cherokee recognize that the menstruating woman is performing a function of cleansing and centering not only for herself but also for her family and, therefore, for the whole tribe.

The changing status of women in society offers great hope for the reintegration of female perspectives into mainstream thinking. The influence of women is already being felt politically in the ecology and peace movements. Menstruation is an integral part of the development of women's spirituality, both at the individual and collective levels. For women as individuals, the acceptance of the value and power of menstruation is a key to our ability to access the Goddess within. Collectively, all aspects of womanhood need now to be acknowledged for their highest potential. The denial of female wisdom has contributed to our present state of hanging on the cliff of potential annihilation through nuclear warfare, and the threat of destruction not only of our own species through nothing short of self-poisoning, but also the death of many other species living on the planet.

It is only a short hypothetical leap to come to the conclusion that the denigration of menstruation and the denial of its power arose out of fear and envy of that power by male priests and rulers who wanted all the power to themselves. Where the battle between the sexes originated is open to speculation, and I don't want to go into that

discussion here. I prefer to assume that there has been a long-term purpose for the evolution of the planet, that it and its inhabitants experience patriarchy and the optimal development of culture from a male perspective. And it appears likely that before this patriarchal period there flowered a matrifocal culture, which died just as this present culture will die.

Rather than look back with longing at an imagined golden age of Goddess worship, we can look forward to a future where the whole of the Feminine and the whole of the Masculine are given the opportunity to flourish. This is a utopian dream, but that doesn't mean it isn't a good place to aim our sights as a culture. Sometimes we get caught in the nightmare of the collective, swept up in horrendous news reports of atrocities perpetrated all over the globe, made anxious by the knowledge of nuclear weapons testing, the destruction of the rain forests, the heartless mutilation of our fellow creatures in the name of science. It pays to have a strong positive dream to counterbalance this horror, and to be ceaselessly pouring one's energy toward that dream of hope in the future, borne out of the knowledge of the essential magnificence of the dance of life and death.

The return of the feminine and the healing of the planet are intricately intertwined. We cannot have the change in the macrocosm that we know is essential for survival of life on the earth without a parallel shift in the microcosm. This has been well understood in the issue of recycling, and much of the focus of the environmental movement has been toward the individual. There is a strong relationship between our attitudes to our bodies, and our attitude to the larger body—the planet Earth. It is not simply our behavior toward literal waste that needs to change, but also our attitude toward our bodies and their “waste.” When menstruation is called a curse and suppressed or ignored as much as possible, then we are wasting a precious aspect

of life. We are missing the point that the experiences inherent in the female have a value, a value that goes beyond the limits that twentieth-century Euro-Western society has allowed.

Menstruation and the Wisdom Not to Fight War

The political and social impact of our collective denial of the power of the menstrual cycle should not be underestimated. Discovering the levels of our disgust at our bodies and at the nature of femaleness is unpleasant, but this is vital to unraveling the threads that the patriarchal culture and belief system have wound around our freedom as women, as human beings. Our throats have been strangled by these cords of self-disgust, as we stand by in horror and watch unnecessary wars fought; watch our sons killed and our daughters left without husbands; watch innocent people killed by bombing and by other horrendous means.

Behind this madness is the fact that women don't believe in themselves, and don't trust their own instincts enough to stand up and say, "No. My children will not die in this carnage. You will *not* destroy my family, my home, my town, my city, my country."

The essential nature of the female is not valued in this culture, and so we lack the confidence to stand up and exercise our power because we have largely forgotten what female power truly is. It has been debased into manipulation and acting behind the scenes, usually to aggrandize the husband (for example, Nancy Reagan) or acting more like men than men do (Margaret Thatcher).

What Is Female Power and How Could It Manifest in the World?

One of the ways that female power develops is by the careful gathering of self-knowledge and awareness through monthly meditation and

retreat at the time of the bleeding. Female power is patience borne out of the experiences of gestation and child-rearing: nurturing an unseen embryo for nine months, sitting for hours nursing, rocking a restless baby in the middle of the night. Female power is female wisdom, and female wisdom resides in the body and is manifested as a result of the experiences of the female body.

In a society that does not respect such qualities as awareness, sensitivity, patience, and ability to nurture, women don't respect these qualities either. They tend to skate with resentment over those times in their lives when those qualities could be ingrained into them, if they were available to receive them. If all women honored their bleeding and went into retreat every month, practicing rituals designed to increase self-awareness and self-love, the world would be a better place.

Men would discover their nurturing side as they took over the responsibility of child care and the home for those few days a month; children would be relieved the burden of an irritable and tired mother who really would much rather be putting her feet up with a good book, and they would also benefit from relating with other adults. Above all, the processes of the woman would once again be recognized as having an intrinsic value. Just as the body miraculously produces milk to feed the baby after it is born, so the body somehow produces wisdom in the psyche during menstruation—if it is given the space. Women don't have to *do* anything. In fact the less they do the better. It seems to be a case of sitting reasonably still for a while and letting it happen.

If women meditated every month, think how clear their minds would be when they emerged from their retreats. The leaders of the community should then go to them and ask, "What should we do about this or that problem?" and listen to the clear-minded and heartfelt response that they would receive.

Imagine for a moment, that there is a group of women who are nationally, perhaps internationally, recognized for their wisdom and for their ability to channel the wisdom of the collective. Perhaps some of them are crones who are past the age of menstruation, some of them are still menstruating. When there is a crisis, such as an impending war, these women would be consulted by the political leaders (perhaps they would also *be* the political leaders) and they would go into meditation (for those still menstruating, during their moon-time). The knowledge of what action should or should not be taken would naturally emerge from them and would then be given to the larger community as a recommendation from the wise women of the land.

At the moment many of our wise women are working in the background, exerting what influence they can on a world driven mad by materialism and lack of spiritual connection. It is time these women came out to the foreground and changed the world. As Changing-woman herself spun the web of the beginning of time, so now she must emerge to shift the balance of power so that the children of our children's children will have a world in which to live and love.

NOTES

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Chapter 1. A Brief History of Bleeding

1. Marija Gimbutas, *The Language of the Goddess* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1989); Merlin Stone, *When God Was a Woman* (New York: Harvest/Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1976).
2. Although the Jewish religion had a long tradition of menstrual taboos, these were not common in European culture until the middle ages, when Theodore (the author of an influential medieval penitential) stated that it was a sin for a menstruating woman to enter a church and imposed a penance for infraction of this rule. G. Rattray Taylor, *Sex in History* (London: Thames and Hudson, 1953), 59.
3. Dr. W. C. Taylor, "A Physician's Counsels to Women in Health and Disease," (1871), in *Complaints and Disorders: The Sexual Politics of*

- Sickness*, Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English (New York: The Feminist Press, 1973), 21.
4. Dr. F. Hollick, "The Diseases of Women," (1849), in *Complaints and Disorders: The Sexual Politics of Sickness*, Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English (New York: The Feminist Press, 1973), 29.
 5. Dr. W. W. Bliss, "Woman and Her Thirty Years' Pilgrimage," (1870), in *Complaints and Disorders: The Sexual Politics of Sickness*, Barbara Ehrenreich and Deirdre English (New York: The Feminist Press, 1973), 29.
 6. Germaine Greer, *The Female Eunuch* (London: Paladin, 1971), 51-52.
 7. Credit for much of the early work on the appreciation of menstruation (in the '70s) must be given to the pioneering efforts of the lesbian feminist community.

Chapter 2. Moon, Blood, Earth, and Snake

1. Elinor Gadon, *The Once & Future Goddess* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1989), 2.
2. Barbara Walker, *The Woman's Encyclopedia of Myths and Secrets* (San Francisco, Harper & Row, 1983), 669.
3. W. Carew Hazlitt, *Faiths and Folklores of the British Isles* (New York: Benjamin Bloom, 1965), 418.
4. Wendy Doniger O'Flaherty, *Hindu Myths* (Harmondsworth, England: Penguin Books, 1975), 89.
5. C. G. Jung, *Man and His Symbols* (New York: Dell, 1968), 276.
6. Claudia de Lys, *The Giant Book of Superstitions* (Secaucus, NJ: Citadel Press, 1979), 414.

7. Lindsay River and Sally Gillespie, *The Knot of Time* (New York: Harper & Row, 1987), 69.
8. de Lys, *The Giant Book of Superstitions*, 458.
9. Hazlitt, *Faiths and Folklores of the British Isles*, 417.
10. "Menstruation and the Power of Yurok Women," in *Blood Magic*, ed. Thomas Buckley and Alma Gottlieb (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California, 1988), 191.
11. Penelope Shuttle and Peter Redgrove, *The Wise Wound* (New York: Grove Press, 1986), 284.
12. Gadon, *The Once & Future Goddess*, 6.
13. Barbara Walker, *The Woman's Encyclopedia of Myths and Secrets*, 637.
14. *Ibid.*, 644.
15. Ajit Mookerjee, *Kali: The Feminine Force* (Rochester, VT: Destiny Books, 1988), 33.
16. Walker, *The Woman's Encyclopedia of Myths and Secrets*, 636-37.
17. Shuttle and Redgrove, *The Wise Wound*, 173.
18. Gadon, *The Once & Future Goddess*, 11.
19. Walker, *Women's Encyclopedia*, 265.

Chapter 3. Her Blood Is Gold

1. Anne Cameron, *Daughters of Copper Woman* (Vancouver: Press Gang, 1981), 103.
2. *Ibid.*, 57.
3. "Menstruation and the Power of Yurok Women," in *Blood Magic*, ed. Thomas Buckley and Alma Gottlieb (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California, 1988), 190.

4. Cameron, *Daughters of Copper Woman*, 102–3.
5. Ibid., 101.
6. Colin Turnbull, *The Forest People* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 1961), 186–94.

Chapter 4. The Wounded Woman

1. Cervical dysplasia can be a precursor to cervical cancer. It is most important to have regular check-ups if you are diagnosed with dysplasia, and your doctor will advise you if treatment is necessary. This condition should be taken very seriously and surgery may be the only viable option.
2. Hallie Iglehart Austen, *The Heart of the Goddess* (Berkeley, CA: Wingbow, 1990), 116.

Chapter 5. Working with Menstrual Symptoms

1. J. G. Frazer, *The Golden Bough: A Study in Magic and Religion* (New York: Macmillan, 1957), 792.
2. Claudia de Lys, *The Giant Book of Superstitions* (Secaucus, NJ: Citadel Press, 1979), 46.
3. Frazer, *The Golden Bough*, 795.
4. Denise L. Lawrence, “Menstrual Politics: Women and Pigs in Rural Portugal,” in *Blood Magic*, ed. Thomas Buckley and Alma Gottlieb (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California, 1988), 122.
5. Arnold Mindell, *The Dreambody in Relationships* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1985).

6. Tamara Slayton coined the phrase Pre-Menstrual Strength. Personal communication, Sebastopol, CA, Dec. 1990.
7. Susan M. Lark, M.D., *PMS: A Self-Help Guide for Women* (Carson City, NV: Self-Help Options for Women, 1990).
8. Ibid., 2.
9. Ibid.
10. Arnold Mindell, *Working with the Dreaming Body* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1985).
11. Dena Taylor, *Red Flower: Rethinking Menstruation* (Freedom, CA: The Crossing Press, 1988), 112. In a study of the menstrual behavior of 53 American women it was found that: "Nearly everyone listed a quiet relaxing activity as what they like to do during menstruation e.g. read, stay in bed, be alone, sleep, paint, write, garden, take it easy, meditate, take baths."

Chapter 6. The Sabbath of Women

1. M. Esther Harding, *Woman's Mysteries, Ancient and Modern* (Boston: Shambhala, 1990), 62–63.
2. Robert Briffault, *The Mothers*, abridged by Gordon Rattray Taylor (New York: Atheneum, 1977), 253.
- 3.. Barbara Walker, *The Woman's Encyclopedia of Myths and Secrets* (San Francisco, Harper & Row, 1983), 1020.
4. Monica Sjöö and Barbara Mor, *The Great Cosmic Mother* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1987), 189.
5. Ann Belford Ulanov, *The Feminine* (Evanston, IL: Northwestern University Press: 1971), 176.
6. Ajit Mookerjee, *Kali: The Feminine Force* (Rochester, VT: Destiny Books, 1988), 32–35.

Chapter 10. Rituals of the Moon-Time

1. Gary Dale Richman, "The Santo Daimé Doctrine," in *Shaman's Drum* 22 (Winter 1990–91): 35.

Chapter 11. Bleeding with the World

1. Interview with Susun Weed by Marcelina Martin, 1990.
2. Steve Deese and Debbie Heartsong, personal correspondence, 1991.

APPENDIX 1

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Questions to Encourage Menstrual Awareness

1. Write down three names for menstruation. Think about them. What do they imply to you about menstruation?
2. Think for a few minutes about what it feels like to have your period (for men or for girls who have not yet menstruated, imagine what it's like), and write down a few words describing that feeling.
3. Next time you have your period, carefully track how you feel about yourself. Make notes about these feelings. Do this for two or three months and then, one day when you are feeling quite steady, look at your notes as if they had been written by someone else, someone living on another planet. What is this person's relationship with her body like?

APPENDIX 1

4. How does it feel to say, "I have my period?" Can you say it anywhere without feeling at all embarrassed?
5. Imagine you are from another planet. What would you think menstruation was if the only information you had to go on was a Tampax commercial?
6. Imagine if men were the ones who menstruated. How do you think they would behave when they had their periods? What would the world be like?
7. Imagine you have special powers and you can tell when a woman has her period. What are the clues that you would use?
8. Just for a minute or two, consider that menstruation is magical. What would be the gift of this magical thing?

APPENDIX 2

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Menstrual Blood and HIV

There has been a paucity of research about the whole issue of women and HIV, and it is not known at the present time if menstrual blood is involved in the transmission of the virus. The Centers for Disease Control in Atlanta, Georgia, have no documented instances of menstrual blood as the means of transmission of HIV. Their spokesperson told me that it was theoretically possible to catch HIV from menstrual blood, but at the present time this appears unlikely in practice. However, like all blood, menstrual blood might be infected with HIV, and so we must take suitable precautions.

We do know that the virus does not live for long outside the body because it needs the constant temperature of body heat to survive. This means that pads soaked in cold water and then washed thoroughly in hot water should be safe. The FDA did forbid the sale of

cloth pads in 1976 (before the onset of the AIDS epidemic), stating that they were potentially harmful, but this ruling has since been withdrawn, and their sale is legal.

Where this issue can affect us is in the practice of ceremony involving menstrual blood as sacrament. As a general rule, if you are going to use blood ceremonially make sure that women only come into contact with their own blood.

I feel very sad that we can no longer share our body fluids with each other without anxiety. Historically, the sharing of blood in ritual has been a major factor in bonding individuals and groups, but we live in a time where this is no longer safe.

For more information about women and AIDS see *Women, Aids and Activism* by ActUp and the New York Women and AIDS Book Group, published by South End Press (Boston: 1990).

RESOURCES

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Cloth Menstrual Pad Suppliers and Manufacturers

Cycles Pads
Sisterly Works
R.R. 1, Box 198
Elberon, IA 52225
(319) 439-5451

Ecofem pads, available from
Personal Hygienic Supplies
Ganmill Ltd.
38 Market St.
Bridgewater, Somerset, U.K.
TA6 3EP

Moonwit Pads and Liners
Moonwit,
R.R. 4 Lang's Rd. C-21
Ganges, British Columbia, Canada
VOS 1EO
(604) 537-4683

New Cycle Products
Menstrual Health Foundation
P.O. Box 1775
Sebastopol, CA 95473
(707) 829-2744 or
(800) 845-FLOW

RESOURCES

The Rubber Tree
4426 Burke Ave. N.
Seattle, WA 98103
(206) 633-4750

Women's Choice
#2-360 Bay St.
Ottawa, Ontario, Canada
KIR 6A2
(613) 567-2875

Seventh Generation
Colchester, VT 05446-1672
(800) 456-1177

Classes and Workshops

Judith Barr
Women's Blood Mysteries
P.O. Box 552
Pound Ridge, NY 10576
(914) 533-2373

Menstrual Health Foundation
Tamara Slayton, director
P.O. Box 1775
Sebastopol, CA 95473
(707) 829-2744 or
(800) 845-FLOW

Moonlodge Retreats
Susan Morrison
Nova Quest: Contemporary
Wellness Education
Blomidon, Nova Scotia, Canada
BOP 1HO
(902) 582-7369

PMS and Menopause Center
Susan M. Lark, M.D.
50 Airport Parkway, Suite 151BD
San Jose, CA 95110
(408) 437-4981

Publications

The Rag magazine
Editor: Chris Budewit
R.R. 4 Lang's Rd. C-21
Ganges, British Columbia, Canada
VOS 1EO
(604) 537-4683

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IN MANY TIMES AND IN MANY CULTURES, MENSTRUATION HAS
BEEN SEEN AS SACRED AND SPECIAL, BUT TODAY, REVERENCE HAS BEEN
REPLACED BY SILENCE, IGNORANCE, AND PMS JOKES.



Would we view menstruation differently if men were the ones who menstruated? Would, as Gloria Steinem once speculated, menstruation likely become "an enviable, boastworthy event"? Would men "brag about how long and how much"? Would the onset of the menses be celebrated and respected?

Incorporating ancient knowledge and modern science, *Blood Is Gold* breaks the silence of our cultural taboo and shows women how to reclaim the positive power of the female cycle. Drawing on myth, tradition, and the personal stories of three women, Lara Owen helps women turn shame, pain, and self-consciousness into creativity, self-fulfillment, and healing—for themselves, other women, and the world. Offering practical recommendations, rituals, and exercises, Owen describes the physical well-being, natural strength, and spiritual insight women can enjoy when they live and work in ways that respect their cyclical body patterns.

Comprehensive, practical, and celebratory, this liberating exploration reclaims menstruation as a welcome, natural, even magical time for creativity and renewal.



Author photo by Andrew Murray

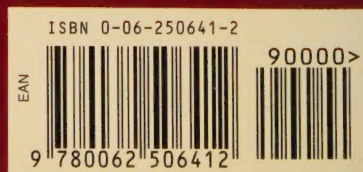
LARA OWEN has written about menstruation for the *Whole Earth Review* and is currently a consultant for the forthcoming documentary on menstruation, *Blood of the Moon*.

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